Life Will Change

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Life Will Change

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Summary

A new era begins for Shadow Weaver and the Head Sorceress.
With King Father Micah finally abandoning his paranoia, his obsession, and letting go of the past, everything changes for him and his family.

But there's someone still missing…

What if there was a chance of bringing her back?
After all, the Universe holds so many secrets…

Notes

Welcome back, everyone!!
How have you been??

I have a lot to say, but I rather be brief. If you follow my socials, then you know what this is about: Time for your daily click!

Now, I introduce you to the final part of this series! (Not counting the eliminated scenes)
I hope this brings some answers to the questions that the ending of TaTM may have generated, and ofc, there's a good dose of angst at the end of the first chapter to make you sure we start off the right way XD

See you each Wednesday as usual!!

P.S.: I almost forgot the summary of the fic overall lol

The Reckoning

Chapter Summary

The council enters in session.
This time around, they lose no time: judgement must be delivered.
But it won't be as easy as expected, for this is an unprecedented case…
» With a bit of a heated argument, the meeting went on for a while, before the council could reach a conclusion on what they would do.
» (…) What could possibly be a sensible sentence now?
» (…) As they were about to conclude the meeting, having established that they had no power to judge the Queen, the Head Sorceress asked for a minute.
» (…) —I should step down as Head Sorceress.

But the things said are not ignored. Queen Glimmer understands, for the first time, the full extent of her father's sorrow, and decides to take him for a little trip.
» —This is called the Chamber of Queens, Dad…
» (…) —I-I see… It's a beautiful place. But, why did you bring me here, baby girl?
» (…) The same hologram she had seen back then appeared once more, reproducing the same words she heard the day of her coronation.
» (…) With a small smile, Glimmer replied once again —I love you too, Mom.
» (…) —No, no! Please, come back!
» (…) —Identified: King Micah.

Chapter Notes

I almost forgot to write this summary too! lol

Ahem, please, enjoy *bows, gesturing you all to come in*

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The chamber was fully silent.

The council room usually had these moments of silence, but this time, it was different.

What they had to judge was… complicated, to say the least. There were no precedents, so not even the oldest ones had any idea of how they should proceed.

As everyone's hesitation to start the meeting was so evident, the King Father had been looking out through the window into the setting sun, with a mix of shame and anger.

—Alright, I believe we must begin this procedure— Geldirik eventually said, taking charge of the situation, as was his duty being the foreman-councilman. —Seeing how the Head Sorceress not only is King Micah's sister, but also took part in the actions we will judge today, I shall be taking over from this moment until we reach a verdict.

—In that case…— Glimmer began. —I will only be here as a witness, and leave the judging to you. It's my family, and I have also taken part in the forbidden spell, accepting responsibility for whatever the outcome was, so I shouldn't judge what happened either…

—Understood— he nodded. —Therefore, I suggest we begin by hearing what both of you, your Majesty, and our Head Sorceress have to say about this: Why you approved of it, why you participated, and what you think of King Micah's actions— Geldirik decided.

—Alright— the Queen accepted. —To begin with, not only allowing the spell to be performed but also participating weren't decisions I took lightly. And it wasn't just because they are my family either. I still believe it wasn't the right thing to do, but they were determined to do it, so I *had* to help them; trying to keep those I care for from doing things I believe are too risky has only led to them doing it behind my back. I've learnt the lesson, and I knew trying to stop them by force or simply refusing to participate would be like abandoning them— Glimmer explained, serious and just as regal as her mother would have been. —The decisions I made were strategic: by helping them, I minimized the risk of them getting hurt, but also the risk of that parasitic magic endangering all of Etheria. It's my responsibility. My duty is to my people, and, it seems illogical, but I realized that any other decision would have been neglecting everyone's safety.

Now fully ashamed, the King Father lowered his sight as his anger waned.

Despite not looking back, he paid special attention as the foreman-councilman asked —And how would you regard your father's actions then?

—I think he was *reckless*. I don't really know if there would be a "correct" way of doing what he did, but… the way things went down, we were just *lucky*. Lucky that Auntie and I showed up before he began, and lucky that I thought about asking Councilman Nolrem to get Adora to help us. Without She-Ra's help, we wouldn't have made it. *Any of us*.

And now Micah felt the urge to apologize.

It was true, he had been reckless and hadn't thought about the consequences of things going wrong again…

—If that's all, your Majesty, we should now hear what our Head Sorceress has to say— Geldirik sentenced.

As Glimmer nodded, Castaspella began —Like she said, I realized I simply wouldn't be able to stop my brother, and the thought of abandoning him to do it on his own, like Light Spinner did, was wholly unbearable. So, the reason I allowed it is basically that I had no choice, and the reason I participated is that I couldn't let history repeat itself. However, I think Micah should have brought this to the council first.

—Are you serious!?— he suddenly interrupted, finally turning to face the council.

—You should have asked for permission!

—Oh really? Look at how well that went for Light Spinner— he argued, his tone quite indignant, almost sardonic.

—I am *not* Norwyn!— Castaspella immediately rebuked, severe. —All I'm saying is that you did everything wrong! You didn't wait for the Moons Alignment and pretended to do it on your own before we arrived, just… just *trusting* your power alone would be enough!— she enumerated. —Glimmer is right, you were reckless! And you know what's the worst part!? I wouldn't have shut you down like it happened with Spin; I would have authorized you to do it, but only after checking that everything was *safe*!

—What would have been the difference?— he questioned her, both surprised and confused.

—We would have realized that, even with your modifications, it still wasn't safe enough. We would have taken more safety measures, calling for She-Ra's help would have been planned, not mere luck! I- She was key in keeping us safe, like Glimmer said! I can hardly believe how similar you and Spin are…

—Can you all stop comparing me to Shadow Weaver!?— he indignantly cried out, before he could think better about it.

—Brother, I…

—What?— he asked, expression defeated.

—Despite disagreeing with the decisions you made, and disapproving of your procedure, I still… have to thank you. And I say it here, in front of everyone, because I won't pretend this hasn't benefited me in any way— the Head Sorceress admitted.

With a bit of a heated argument, the meeting went on for a while, before the council could reach a conclusion on what they would do.

If, for dismissing a spell without their consent, which resulted in quite an inconvenience yet didn't endanger Mystacor, they had put Micah on probation and monitored his spells… What could possibly be a sensible sentence now?

The oldest councillors were immediately put under the spotlight and asked what they would have done if Shadow Weaver hadn't escaped, but their minds were mostly blank. They were sure the woman wouldn't allow them to judge her in any way, so it was difficult to think of anything suitable for someone who had so brazenly gone against the council's back *and* endangered a young pupil at the same time.

Hence, after some time discussing how the hypothetical situation of having to judge her would have been, their conclusion was simple: the circumstances, the intentions, the attitude when facing judgement, and their willingness to mitigate any possible damage that could

come to those around them as a consequence of performing the spell, should all be taken into consideration to properly determine the sentence.

In other words, had they had the chance to judge Shadow Weaver, they would have imprisoned her with the possibility of perhaps being released based on her attitude; knowing it took the woman several decades to admit her mistake and finally regret it, but she actually *did it*, they were inclined to believe the woman would have attained liberty eventually.

But, with the King Father, it was different.

For starters, the circumstances were entirely different; his intentions were noble, like Light Spinner's had initially been, but there was no underlying greed or thirst for power; and his attitude after having performed it was far from that of Shadow Weaver, not only because he didn't kill anyone, but also because he was regretful, ashamed, and had been driven by an intense guilt yet it didn't mean he was proud of his actions. And, of course, opposite to how Shadow Weaver used the powers she gained to further endanger the whole of Etheria, having joined the Horde, Micah had instead come up with a plan to keep the parasite sealed so it wouldn't harm anyone.

When asked once more, for the record, why he had done it, he gave them all a new answer no one was expecting.

—I finally understood so many things. I realized what I did and… the pain I caused— he began. Then, looking at his sister, he added —*This* was something I could do. Something that could be done. So I said "Why not?" I mean, I understand what you're feeling, because I'd be lying if I said I wouldn't give anything to see my wife again. To have her back too…

Therefore, the only issue the council had was how to make sure the parasite's power wouldn't tempt Shadow Weaver's spirit now, yet he had also thought about that: certain spells, sealing spells, are attached to whoever casts them, like having the only key to a locked door. His proposal was to have his sister, his daughter, and himself cast three different seals in the chamber so no one would be able to open the doors, nor would the woman be able to go through them or the walls when far from Castaspella.

In conclusion, the sentence for the King Father was a year of community service along with another year of having his spells monitored, again.

As they were about to conclude the meeting, having established that they had no power to judge the Queen, the Head Sorceress asked for a minute.

—Is there anything you'd like to add?— Geldirik asked her, curious.

Taking a deep breath, she sighed and said —I understand why you can't judge my niece, as her status is far above us, but the same can't be said about me. The Head of the Guild is supposed to safeguard Mystacor's safety, yet I allowed and actively took part in what could have been fatal for us all.

—You don't mean to say…

—I should step down as Head Sorceress— she interrupted the foreman-councilman.

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver's spirit, which was logically *not* allowed to be present in the meeting, walked down the halls of the main building. Eventually, she went past a room guarded by a pair of acolytes, and immediately stopped. Curious, she approached them and tilted her head while giving them a questioning look.

—Since when does Mystacor have restricted chambers?— she finally asked, as they remained silent. But they didn't reply. —Let me guess… You don't even know what you're guarding, do you?

—We're not supposed to engage in conversation with you— one of them finally explained, mildly intimidated.

—Silence!— the other commanded.

—Is that so?— the woman uttered, barely able to hide her annoyance. Keeping a calm demeanor yet raging inside, she condescendingly told them —Let me clarify the mystery for you, then. There's only one thing you could have been ordered to guard, especially from me, and that's the parasitic magic that was summoned from the depths of Etheria.

She could see them immediately go pale, realizing the danger of the thing inside the room, and couldn't help smirking.

—I-It doesn't matter. We can't let anyone in.

—I'm sure— she said. —And the reason you shouldn't "engage in conversation" with me is because I can easily convince you to let me pass…

—We-we won't allow it— one of them stammered.

—Lucky for you, I have no intentions to enter the chamber— she replied. —So you have nothing to worry about.

—Even if you wanted to, we wouldn't be… *swayed* by you— the other one confidently declared.

—You can think that as much as you want but you don't know what I'm capable of— she taunted. —But then again, worry not. I'll simply continue on my way…

With that, Shadow Weaver turned and walked down the hall, leaving a pair of very confused, and scared, acolytes.

Well, now she knew where they were keeping that mass of unfathomable power…

Back inside the council room, the Head Sorceress had just expressed her willingness to step down.

—What!?— both Micah and Glimmer exclaimed.

—Head Sorceress, if you allow me— Nolrem interceded. —Just as the Queen expressed, making a different decision would have *really* put us in danger. What you did aimed at protecting not only your brother, but all of us from a potential catastrophe.

—I agree— Geldirik said. —As you have explained, it would have been letting history repeat itself, making the same mistake *we* did in the past…— he argued. Then, looking around to see if the other councillors agreed, he added —We… don't want you to step down.

Blushing slightly, the sorceress looked away, suddenly shy.

—With all due respect, Head Sorceress, it is in our best interest that we decide, once again, to keep you as Head of the Guild— Arden dared comment.

—You really think so?— Castaspella asked, moved.

—We do, yes— a councilwoman agreed, seconded by the rest of the council.

Barely able to hide her smile, she shyly thanked them —I appreciate it. If… so you wish, then it will be my honor to persist as your Head Sorceress.

As everyone walked out of the council room, one of the acolytes supposed to be guarding the chamber of the parasitic magic arrived, running, to inform them of Shadow Weaver's appearance and her "threat", which didn't sit well with Micah… at all.

—She said *what*!?

—Brother, she was just taunting them— Castaspella quickly pointed out, knowing the woman was simply playing, in her own *twisted* way, with the guards. —You don't have to worry about what she said; ninety percent of the time, she doesn't mean it— she assured him, dismissive.

—*You* can choose to trust her. I don't. Where is she?— he inquired, serious.

The Head Sorceress couldn't help rolling her eyes and letting out a sigh.

She should have expected this.

—Fine, come with me. You'll see it's all bluffing.

The siblings had just left the council and the Queen behind, having turned on a corner, when Shadow Weaver found *them*.

—Good evening, you two… Looking for me, I reckon— she said, grinning.

—Allow me— Castaspella immediately ordered Micah, raising a hand in front of him. —Why did you go to mock those guards, eh?

—Why not? Just some harmless fun…

—So it's all just a game for you!?— Micah indignantly cried out.

—Calm down and let me talk— his sister quickly interceded. —But he's right. You need to take this more seriously. If you give the council a single reason, they will order your complete banishment, meaning the summoning spell will be removed from me, and *you* will have to cooperate… Or, you know, risk letting me die.

—Sis, what!?

—Don't even joke about that— Shadow Weaver warned her, stepping closer. Lowering her voice as she leant her face closer, she added —Quite a smart move, but if I were you, I'd be more careful when risking your own life just to keep *me* in check.

—But it's not my decision. It's the arrangement I made with the council.

—Why would you do something so stupid!?— she exclaimed, indignant. —And you, why allow her!?— she then reproached Micah.

Once again, Castaspella stopped her brother from speaking and replied —That was not something he could control, to begin with. *And*, in case you didn't know, because I trust you. Being the only person on this island who trusts you, I have to take responsibility for you.

—It is one thing to take responsibility for me when it only means having to clean up my mess. But risking your life!?

—I *know* what I'm doing. Do you?

—Of course— she replied, calmer yet looking away, unable to meet Castaspella's gaze.

—Then do me a favour: no more messing around. At least not with things related to the parasitic magic, alright?

—Fine… It wasn't that much fun either— the woman muttered.

—Alright!— Castaspella cheerfully let out. —That's settled, so we should get going— she told her brother, who was in fact quite shocked after seeing his sister deal with Shadow Weaver so easily.

—Going where, may I ask?

—To set up the seals that will keep the likes of you out of that room— the King Father replied, squinting.

—Enough of that… But yes, we will put a few final seals on that thing so we won't need people guarding the chamber all day.

—I see… quite smart, indeed— she admitted. —In that case, I will take my leave— she decided, not without a bit of malice as she grabbed Castaspella by the waist. —I'll be in your room, waiting— she told her, loud enough to let Micah listen.

Only then did she leave, smirking widely as she could hear the sorcerer complaining about her shamelessness.

It was about midnight when the Head Sorceress finally arrived at her room where, just as she said, Shadow Weaver waited for her.

—I'm so tired…

—You should be— the woman snarkily replied. —Do you have any idea how long it has been?

—I-I actually don't know.

—Three hours.

—You're joking.

—No.

—There's no way we just spent three hours setting those seals!— Castaspella insisted.

—And I'm telling you that was the case. Did you really not notice?

—I didn't. I-I'm not even hungry!

—Too bad… You will have to go eat regardless— Shadow Weaver mocked her.

—What? Why!?

—Do I have to explain, once again, that you are alive and require proper nourishment to continue in this state?

Pretending to be offended, Castaspella folded her arms, looked away, and muttered —Or you could just admit you're worried about me and want me to have a proper meal…

—I heard that— the woman warned her, approaching. —What is it? Do you want me to *express* my concern more directly? Don't you think it would only sound fake coming from me?

—It won't sound fake if it isn't fake.

—So you think…— she sighed. She shook her head slightly, held the sorceress by the waist, and let out half a smile before saying —Then here you have it: I'd like you to eat, to have proper meals every day *and* night. Can you do that?

—I can— Castaspella replied with a smile. Leaning on her chest, she let out —Thank you for worrying…

—I…

—If you say you're not worried, I swear…— the Head Sorceress interrupted, but didn't finish her threat.

—I was only going to say I would rather keep this private.

—So… you plan on being just as mean as always about this in public?

—Exactly— the woman smirked.

—Alright— Castaspella sighed, rolling her eyes. —But be nice when we're alone.

—I won't make any promises— she replied, her smirk widening.

—What a bitch!— the Head Sorceress complained, playfully slapping Shadow Weaver's chest.

Meanwhile, back in Bright Moon, Queen Glimmer decided to take her father for a little trip into the caves beneath the kingdom. After walking through barely lit tunnels for a while, they arrived at the Chamber of Queens, and memories of her coronation day washed over Glimmer.

—What is this place?— the King Father asked.

—This is called the Chamber of Queens, Dad… Here I had to, um, well, defeat a guardian monster to become Queen— she explained, giggling slightly at his shocked expression. —Don't worry, Adora and Bow helped me.

—I-I see… It's a beautiful place— he admitted. —But, why did you bring me here, baby girl?

—For this, Dad… Come here with me— she replied, guiding him to the ceremonial altar.

Once on top of the stairs, she placed her hand where she had set the lantern all those years ago, and a robotic voice said —Identified: Queen Glimmer.

Right after, the same hologram she had seen back then appeared once more, reproducing the same words she heard the day of her coronation.

—Glimmer, you are walking in the footsteps of all those who have come before us— it began. Micah was astonished, on the verge of tears seeing Angella again, even if it wasn't really her. —Now, my darling, it's your turn. I wish I didn't have to leave you. But I know you will be all right. Because you are Glimmer, and you are so, so strong. I have done my

best to prepare you to rule, but you were always ready to lead. I am so proud of you, Glimmer. I love you.

With a small smile, Glimmer replied once again —I love you too, Mom.

And right as the hologram disappeared, her father threw his hands at it, exclaiming —No, *no*! Please, come back!

Crying in full earnest now, he knelt and rested his hands on top of where the hologram had appeared.

Seeing him so undone made the Queen slightly regret this, and she knelt with him until the same robotic voice from before spoke up once more.

—Identified: King Micah.

—What?— they both muttered as they stood up in complete confusion.

—Oh, my Love… If you're seeing this, it means you have… somehow, outlived me. Seems impossible, doesn't it?— Angella's voice began, letting out a chuckle. It was yet another hologram, one the Queen had no idea existed. —But, this is probably Fate. I wish I could still be there to guide and accompany our baby, but I'm not. However, *you are*. You can walk this new path in front of her together. Just remember: help her, accompany her, *guide* her. Don't try to control our little girl… she's probably not little anymore— she clarified, smiling warmly. —Be a *father*, don't forget it.

Chapter End Notes

I am so sorry <("^_^) ~~Or am I?~~

Sorry, this idea popped into my mind and I had to…

But I wanted to ask: what do you think of the council's judgement, huh? I'm curious!

ANYWAYS, I hope you enjoyed this!! There are many thingies to come, hehe, and I certainly hope I have everything written in time cause OMGS, I got into two events that are due for MAY!
Speaking of which, if you guys are interested, I encourage you to check this! If any of you would like to join, writers are still on time, and artist have plenty more time to join!!

Well, anyways, see you next week! ^_^

First Ones' Tech

Chapter Summary

A certain matter has been bothering the Head Sorceress lately, and she decides to open up to her niece, who is more than happy to help…
» —Just speak freely, Auntie. I'm all ears and won't say a thing about it if so you prefer.
» —Yes, I'd appreciate it if this doesn't leave the room for now. (…) So, seeing how she isn't really doing anything wrong, I don't think there's any need to take action or precautions of any kind. Unless, of course, I'm being too lenient, and can't see it's a sign that something worse will eventually happen.
» (…) —If you're still unsure, why don't I speak with her? I mean, that way we can know for sure, regardless of whether your judgement is biased or not…

But, despite the infinite patience of the Queen and her aunt, nothing changes and it soon becomes a matter of importance for the council. Yet the meeting won't go as smoothly as hoped…
» —Just think about it! How else would she have "fainted" if not because she was trying something ridiculously advanced in magic to get inside!?
» But Catra disagreed.
» She knelt next to the doors to the chamber and found a couple of glistening metallic pieces that looked very familiar.
» —First Ones' tech.

Chapter Notes

Damn! Almost a 100 hits in just a week with ONE chapter!? You guys are the best! (#^_^#)

Okay, this chapter is a bit longer, which I didn't notice at first, but hopefully it's a good read!!

Anyways, a lot happens here, and there's both really emotional parts (not angsty imo), and very dramatic parts!!

Oh, also, someone once asked in a comment if SW would revive, and I can't recall what I answered (besides that it was not gonna happen), but the thing is, this chapter has a scene that will better explain *why* that shouldn't happen…

So, anyways, I invite you to enjoy today's chapter!!

P.S.: I need to stop saying "anyways" so much...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was a slow afternoon in Mystacor.

The Head Sorceress had finished all her paperwork very quickly, and there was no need for her to oversee any projects or investigations, as the only ones currently working on theirs were Sahm and Ari. And, of course, with Shadow Weaver back, they wanted her to guide them.

Castaspella was far from offended. On the contrary, she was happy to leave this work to her.

And so, she decided to take the rest of the day off and went to visit her niece in Bright Moon.

However, in full honesty, she had ulterior motives; she needed someone with whom she could discuss a little matter that had been bothering her the past few months…

—Just speak freely, Auntie. I'm all ears and won't say a thing about it if so you prefer— Glimmer encouraged her, sitting on a couch in front of her aunt while holding Glow between her arms.

—Yes, I'd appreciate it if this doesn't leave the room for now— Castaspella sighed. —Alright. I-I don't think this is an issue, at least not yet, but… maybe I'm just being too lenient? I'm afraid it will get out of hand and it will be my fault.

—Auntie, whatever it is, it won't be your fault, I'm sure… Just, can you be more specific?

—Right, right— she sighed again, looking away. —The past few months, Spin has admitted she's been… tempted to break into the chamber and steal the power of the parasite— she began. —However, every time it happened, she didn't *actually* attempt anything and only told me she was *thinking* about it. So, seeing how she isn't really doing anything wrong, I don't think there's any need to take action or precautions of any kind. Unless, of course, I'm being too lenient, and can't see it's a sign that something worse will eventually happen.

—A-Auntie…— Glimmer called, interrupting her. —Last time you were thinking like this, you thought it was wishful thinking, remember?— she reminded her. —But it wasn't. You were right about Shadow Weaver… So, maybe, it's okay if you just follow your instincts. Like you said, she hasn't done anything, just *thought* about it, yet instead of acting upon it, she held back and even *told you*! It's just how you said: she really learnt, grew, and isn't the Shadow Weaver we knew. She's, from what I can see, more trustworthy now.

—I hope so, yes.

—If you're still unsure, why don't I speak with her? I mean, that way we can know for sure, regardless of whether your judgement is biased or not…— the Queen suggested.

—I guess that would be a good idea, yes— Castaspella accepted. —Thank you, Dear.

—It's no problem at all, Auntie— she replied with a smile. —I can go to speak with her now, I don't have anything else to do today.

—Oh, me neither.

—Really? Then, would you mind looking after Glow for me?

—Gladly! I always enjoy spending time with her!— the Head Sorceress cheerfully accepted, standing up to take the baby from Glimmer's arms.

Right after, the Queen farewelled and teleported away.

A few minutes after appearing in Mystacor, and having found Shadow Weaver pretty quickly, Glimmer briefly explained she needed to speak with her about something quite sensitive that she would probably prefer to discuss in private. At first, the woman suggested the gardens, but Glimmer pointed out anyone could easily overhear them there, and insisted they needed somewhere they wouldn't be interrupted.

Eventually, they settled for Castaspella's room, which could be considered, technically speaking, Shadow Weaver's room too.

—Well now, your Majesty. Would you mind telling me what is this sensitive matter you need to discuss?— the woman asked, hands joined behind her back.

—Right. Of course— she nodded. —Well, the thing is, Auntie told me about- erm, that you mentioned being tempted to break the seal of the chamber containing the parasitic magic— she began.

—Did she?— Shadow Weaver let out, squinting. —I understand now why you said I would prefer this conversation to be private. Are you here to warn me, your Majesty?

—No. A-at least not this time— Glimmer assured her, shaking her head. —I just want to talk. It probably won't surprise you, but Auntie is having some doubts about her judgement… Specifically, she's afraid her bias may, you know, make her ignore possible danger behind your episodes, so to speak…

—A wise assessment, I believe— the woman admitted. —Then you're here to prove whether my "episodes", as you called them, are a sign of trouble, I reckon.

—Correct. And, for that, I want to ask you: Why would you want to take the power of the parasite now? What use is it to you if you're, well, *dead*?— Glimmer questioned her.

—Want to take a guess?— Shadow Weaver asked back, with that condescending tone the Queen knew quite well.

—Fine, I'll humor you— she accepted, albeit unamused. —Thinking like you… like the *old* you, to be specific, I would say you expect to gain the power to… come back to life?

—And what if I did?

—I will be honest. That would be a terrible idea. But… not for the reasons you think— she replied.

—Then why?

—You may not believe so, but I can assure you that many consider your sacrifice to have been a noble action; you saved Catra, allowed her and Adora to reach the Heart… The Shadow Weaver we knew would have ignored Catra being in danger, and would have simply forced Adora to deploy the failsafe, maybe dying in the process— Glimmer explained. —But, if you undo your death, if you take the power to revive… I think you would erase the meaning of that sacrifice. You being here, both the original summoning and now your return, they were all someone else's doing out of their *own* volition.

—Your point being…

—*My point* is that making a move to undo your death would make it seem like reviving was your plan all along!— Glimmer concluded.

—Wouldn't you say that sounds as delusional as your father claiming I charmed your aunt?— Shadow Weaver pointed out, almost challenging.

—But that's the thing: it wouldn't be that much of a stretch to think everything that has happened since your death was a very careful plan to eventually revive, as if you knew your death would be temporary. Meaning you didn't actually sacrifice yourself that day.

—You're so obviously Micah's daughter, it's baffling…

—You just keep dismissing everything, but I must insist: don't try to revive.

—Your Majesty, you'll probably be glad to know that I have no intentions to do so— the woman finally admitted. —As good as your guess was, it was incorrect.

—Huh?

—I don't want the power to "undo my death", or anything similar, because I'm sure this state of mine is pretty permanent— she began explaining, once again with a condescending tone, as she slowly paced around the room. —In fact, I only… feel like I need that power to stop being so… *useless*. The illusions I can command are a joke. Ridiculous. Despite having this power, in the end, I'm just powerless overall…

—So… you mean…— Glimmer uttered, hesitant, with a worried expression.

—I mean, I'm even more powerless than when I was alive but couldn't use magic— Shadow Weaver admitted, noticeably angry. —You underestimate the "power" of having your own real body… Whenever your aunt isn't around, I can't even read a book!

—A-alright, I get it. Don't get all worked up— the Queen tried to calm her down.

—Besides, what am I even supposed to do if someone or something ever threatens Cas? I can't do *anything*! And I don't mean when she's around… I understand she can protect

herself. But, what if someone broke in here and tried to steal something? What can I possibly do, if I can't interact with reality!?

—Ma-maybe your illusions can't stop them, but if you conceal the exit, it would buy time for someone else to arrive and notice the break-in— Glimmer suggested. —O-or that thing you do, making people see pure darkness! You can blind them like that and tell them they have to return everything or you won't let them go! So-something like that…

—I suppose those aren't bad ideas.

—Look, I… think you're only panicking a bit and picturing the worst-case scenarios. So, maybe, talk with Auntie and come up with ideas like the ones I just gave you— the Queen advised her. —Not only will it reassure you, but it will also make her happy to know you worry about her safety!

—Please… Your aunt is happy with so little…

—Maybe— Glimmer giggled. —But that isn't necessarily a bad thing.

—Alright, alright. That's enough honesty for today. You can leave, your Majesty.

—You needn't call me that, you know?

—No.

—Whatever…— she sighed, rolling her eyes.

Without another word, the Queen teleported back to Bright Moon, leaving Shadow Weaver alone to ponder on their conversation.

Being honest with *herself*, she came to realize the only things keeping her from actually going all out to steal the power of the parasitic magic are simply *guilt and shame*. The thought of betraying Castaspella's trust always invaded her with unbearable guilt, while thinking about Micah's reaction filled her with shame.

Those were such bitter feelings…

And yet, what if that wasn't enough to stop her?

As a couple of weeks go by, Shadow Weaver's mood becomes increasingly worse with each passing day.

Lately, she had overheard, several times, different groups of acolytes talking about Castaspella and her; every single time, they would all express their disapproval of their relationship.

A part of her was amused at how *creative* they could be, imagining all manner of awful scenarios. But deep down, she wanted to drown them in darkness with her illusions to make

them fear ever speaking like that again.

And, about the tenth time she heard such things, her resolve finally *broke*.

She was ready to approach them, tense from head to toe, itching to threaten them…

However, Castaspella's words echoed in her mind. She had told her not to get involved if she ever heard people speaking about them. Hence, she couldn't bring herself to go against her word.

Growling under her breath, she turned around and went to find the Head Sorceress, who was comfortably sitting on her bed, knitting. Her back was to the door, so she never saw the woman enter, and was startled by Shadow Weaver suddenly grabbing her not-so-gently in something akin to a hug, a bit too tight for comfort.

—What the- Bea?— she exclaimed, jumping slightly in place. —What happened?— she asked, surprised. The woman, however, didn't reply. Seething, she only tightened her hold on her. —Please, Bea, you're worrying me. What happened?— Castaspella insisted, trying to look back over her shoulder.

But Shadow Weaver still refused to speak, so she decided to put aside her knitting and wait in silence. She placed one hand over the woman's arms around her, and the other on her head that was resting on Castaspella's shoulder.

And so, once the woman felt *safe*, despite not wanting to admit so to herself, she finally spoke.

With her voice full of hatred, she let out —I heard… a couple of sorcerers… Speaking about us again.

—And…?— the Head Sorceress patiently asked.

—You told me not to get involved when that happens, so I didn't, alright?— she huffed. —But I couldn't help eavesdropping because they were speaking ill of you for… being with me. And I swear, if they dare betray you for something like this…

—I thought you had that mistrust under control— Castaspella interrupted. —Why would they betray me?

—I was just being cautious— the woman argued. With a sigh, she went on —But then, they said- they said that you'd be better off with someone else…—. Angrier, she added —It got to me, and I hate it, but it *hurts*!

Feeling Shadow Weaver hug her even tighter, she caressed her hair and gently began — Bea…

—Don't you dare pity me.

—I don't. Just… calm down— she continued, worried.

—I can't! I hate feeling like this! I refuse to be *weak*!

—Being vulnerable isn't being weak…

—I only want to go back and scare them to death!— the woman exclaimed, furious.

—Listen: the only person who can dictate who I'm better with is *me*— Castaspella stated. —And I chose *you*. That's the only thing that should matter to you— she pointed out.

With a bitter tone, Shadow Weaver argued —I can't just ignore that, woman! If they think so, probably everyone else does!

—Bea! Please calm down! It doesn't matter if they think that! I…— the Head Sorceress began, yet hesitated as she suddenly realized something more concerning. —Do you- Do *you* think I'd be better with someone else?

Once again, the woman wouldn't answer; just hugged her tighter for a moment before loosening her hold.

So Castaspella waited patiently until she admitted —I… do.

Shadow Weaver was trembling, pressing her face against the Head Sorceress' neck, as if wanting to hide from the world.

With a softer tone, she dared ask —Why?

—I just- It's- I can't help it— the woman managed to reply, after struggling a bit. —It feels like the undeniable truth. And… I did this to the girls, didn't I?

—Well… What you did was quite nasty but, knowing you, you would have said that stupidity about "distracting her" regardless. Be it Catra or anyone else, you'd still try to keep Adora alone. It's quite fucked up, but it's definitely not the same.

—As if I wasn't projecting this same thing onto Catra…— she rebuked, annoyed. —And, you said you're the only one who can dictate who you're better with, yet I completely dismissed what Adora wanted in that regard.

—Could be, but at least this time you admit it— Castaspella pointed out.

—I hate this. Needing the comfort…— she huffed, holding her tighter again. They both kept silent for another moment, until Shadow Weaver gathered the courage to speak up once more, albeit ashamed. —Is it- Is it too late to regret it?

—Regret what exactly?

—Everything.

—Even if none of that can be undone… It's never too late to regret it— Castaspella assured her. —It's the only way you can actually apologize for the things you've done. And I've told you, they deserve it. So, if you truly regret it, if you think you made Catra feel what you're

feeling now, if you realize you were unfair to Adora, dismissing what she wanted… Then you better make sure to tell them.

—I'll try…— she sighed. —Again.

—I know you're still pretty bad at apologizing, but keep trying. Try until you do it properly. You owe them that much…— the Head Sorceress softly said.

Quite angry, yet resigned, Shadow Weaver loosened her hug, raised her head, and said —I do, don't I?

—You made so much progress in all these years, now put it all into practice and it'll be worth it— she assured her once more, looking back at her and gently cupping her face.

The woman sighed and finally let go of the sorceress.

—Fine then… I'll… try.

—I promise it won't kill you a second time— Castaspella teased her, letting out a hearty laugh.

—Very funny— she smirked, rolling her eyes.

A month flies by fast, the issues continue, and the Head Sorceress starts to worry.

—Just tell me why you're so obsessed with wanting to be able to protect me!

—I am not…

—Yes, you are!— she interrupted Shadow Weaver. —You're convinced *something* will happen, and that I won't be able to defend myself— she pointed out, severe but keeping her tone as calm as possible. She then approached and placed a hand on the woman's chest as she concluded —I really appreciate your concern, but you're being paranoid, my Love.

They were standing in the middle of their room, a few steps away from the bed, yet she felt *exposed*.

—Do-don't call me that— Shadow Weaver stammered.

—Sorry…— Castaspella apologized, looking away. —Just, please, I need you to stop thinking about this…

—Why?

—Because it has everyone on edge!

—They should mind their own business…

—This is everyone's business— the Head Sorceress insisted. —We're talking about that parasitic magic…

—*I* was talking about your *safety*— the woman clarified.

—Bea, *please*! This is serious! They have called for a meeting in five days, all because *many* have seen you wander near the chamber and it has everyone on edge!

—You already said as much.

—Then don't make me repeat myself— she pleaded.

—I can't make promises, Cas…

The sorceress sighed deeply and let out —I know…

—Why don't we forget about this for a while?

—Do I look that stressed?— Castaspella asked, guessing what she meant by the tone.

—You do…— the woman assured her, leaning down to kiss her neck.

—You can't just escape from these conversations like this— she replied, despite giving in and letting herself enjoy the sensation.

—I can most certainly try, it seems…

—I rather you would escape from that urge… to wander around the chamber… this same way instead…— Castaspella managed to say, interrupted by her own moaning.

Shadow Weaver smirked and guided her to the bed, saying —I'll keep that in mind.

When the day arrived, the Head Sorceress had to leave the woman alone to attend the meeting and *somehow* try to reassure everyone that there was no danger.

Except that Shadow Weaver did exactly what Castaspella hoped she wouldn't, and went straight for the sealed chamber…

Inside the council room, besides the councillors, Queen Glimmer, King Father Micah, Adora, and Catra were in attendance. The sorceress took her time to explain the complicated situation, the paranoia that caused the woman's behaviour, and how she was working on it.

Until…

—Sis!?

—A-Auntie!

Being closer to her, Adora rushed to catch Casaspella before she hit the floor.

She had passed out.

There was no apparent reason, it had just happened.

—What on Etheria is going on!?— Geldirik asked, in utter shock.

—I don't want anyone to panic, but this could be related to Shadow Weaver— Catra suggested. —It wouldn't be the first time…

—Then, come with me— Micah called from the door. —I think I know where she is.

He wished to be wrong.

He *so* wished to be wrong…

But he wasn't.

As expected, they found the opaque magical body of Shadow Weaver on the ground, in front of the sealed chamber's doors.

—Oh, why…

Micah let out a long sigh, looking away.

—I'm really trying here, but this woman does *not* make it easy.

—Of course she doesn't. It's part of the challenge— Catra casually laughed, leaning against the wall. —Now, I'm no expert, but I don't think someone in her condition can possibly faint, right?

As soon as she said that, a glint caught her attention and she approached the doors while the King Father explained why exactly this situation was impossible and how this meant the woman was onto something.

—Just think about it! How else would she have "fainted" if not because she was trying something ridiculously advanced in magic to get inside!?— he argued.

But Catra disagreed.

She knelt next to the doors to the chamber and found a couple of glistening metallic pieces that looked *very* familiar.

—First Ones' tech— she let out, ignoring Micah.

—What?

—This here— she clarified, picking up the pieces. —We have ancient tech involved… I hadn't seen any in a while, I thought we had found it all— she elaborated. —And… she's up — Catra then noticed, extending the first word as Shadow Weaver began moving again.

—What… on Etheria… was that?

—You have a lot of explaining to do— the King Father said.

—We should go back and see if Castaspella woke up too— Catra quickly suggested, before those two could start arguing.

The woman seemed pretty much recovered by the time they arrived at the council room; she didn't need help moving. However, that wasn't the case with the Head Sorceress, who still lay on Adora's lap, so some of the present supposed she was worse than she let them see.

—I'll take her to her room— Shadow Weaver decided, helping her up.

—You aren't going anywhere until you tell us what you were doing— Micah stopped her.

—Nothing. I was *quite literally* just walking.

—Bullshit! You *cannot* faint! You must have done *something*!— he insisted.

—I am just as surprised as you are— she simply replied. —Listen, Micah: I was only walking past the doors. I… intended to pace in front of them as I've done plenty of times before— she admitted. —But then I felt *something* strange, something that weakened me when I went close enough to the doors, and I completely lost control of this summoned body until you two arrived.

—So you were conscious when…

—Yes— the woman sharply interrupted him.

—So, did you see me remove this?— Catra asked, showing the pieces of tech.

—Is that First Ones' tech?— Adora asked, curiously looking at the three strange parts.

—Yeah, that exactly. I think the way they were placed there somehow interfered with the magic of the summoned body— her wife explained. —Any ideas on how this appeared there?

—No, and I'd rather not wait until you find that out. I should take Cas to her room— Shadow Weaver let out, quite bitter.

—I'm fine…

—No, you're not— she quickly retorted when Castaspella groggily spoke.

—Don't worry, we can figure this out on our own— Adora assured them.

—Good, then we're leaving— the woman stated, holding the sorceress tighter. —Ah, but… Micah— she then recalled, and stopped for a second at the door. —You *do know* how it was

that kind of technology that both got us into and out of Despondos?

—Ye-yeah, yes. Your point?

—You may want to take a look at them; if they could affect this level of sorcery… I wonder what else they can do— she ominously commented.

—You're talking about interdimensional travel— Catra realized.

—Am I?— the woman asked, her tone haughty.

Obviously, she refused to elaborate and left with Castaspella, slowly but surely making their way towards their room.

—Of course she's talking about interdimensional travel— Adora let out, knowing everyone was wondering that.

—Excuse me, Princess Adora— a councilman asked. —This kind of technology… Well, it hasn't been seen in Mystacor in a long time. Most specifically, since the war ended, only one of us had any interest in it and how it interacted with sorcery— he explained.

—Really?

—Let me guess: it's the same asshole that got kicked from the council a while ago— Catra interrupted.

—Yes, precisely.

—Did I, or did I not tell you he would eventually pull some shit like this!?— she reproached Adora.

—That was more than two years ago!

—Babe, even *we* had trouble finding tech the past few years. If that guy had everything taken from him, I think two years to recover these parts was *fast*— she assured her.

—Whatever makes you think he could be involved? I-it could be a coincidence— a councilwoman commented.

—With all due respect— Arden interrupted. —I can hardly believe it's such a big coincidence.

—In any case, we'll have to interrogate him— Geldirik stated, hands joined behind his back. —You can leave this investigation to us, worry not— he assured them.

—Can we take these?

—Of course.

—Good, thanks— Catra said, nodding courteously at him. —Oh, right. About Shadow Weaver lurking outside the sealed chamber… I think there's nothing to worry about for now.

—I agree. If anything, if she *suddenly* stops wandering near the doors… then we worry— Adora supported her.

—Can we ask why?— Nolrem inquired, confused.

—Because, in that case, there's either something very wrong with her or…

—Or worse— Catra interrupted. —You don't wanna know what "worse" is.

—I see…— Nolrem sighed.

—Thank you very much— Geldirik said, nodding at them gratefully.

While Adora and Catra left for Dryl, Shadow Weaver arrived at their room carrying Castaspella. She helped her reach the bed and they both pretty much flopped down on it, devoid of strength.

—I can't really sleep but I feel like I need to— the woman said, letting out a bitter laugh.

—Then stay and sleep with me— the sorceress requested.

—*I can't physically sleep*. But I can always rest, I suppose…

With some effort, they made themselves comfortable on the bed and Castaspella closed her eyes while letting out a relieved sigh.

—What was that about the First Ones' tech?

Shadow Weaver was surprised by the sudden question, but she should have known she'd ask.

—Just a theory. I'm sure the girls understand what I mean…

—Can you explain it to me?

Despite the grogginess, her tone was pleading and the woman could hardly resist it.

—You shouldn't worry about that…

—But I'm curious…

—It's just a theory, but I believe those pieces of technology have enough potential to… Well, it's not like I know nearly enough about the subject, but they said it themselves: interdimensional travel— Shadow Weaver explained.

—It makes no sense, Love… How is that related?

—You should ask the Geek Princess…

—I'm asking *you*.

—I just felt it, alright? Stop asking.

—Mean— Castaspella sighed, snuggling between the woman's arms and resting her head on Shadow Weaver's chest.

—Yes, yes. I'm very mean. Now rest.

Meanwhile, at the massive laboratory of the Crypto Palace, Adora and Catra handed in the pieces of tech to Entrapta, who seemed over the Moons with the new addition.

—Are you *sure* these pieces were what caused the "interference"?— Hordak asked, unconvinced.

—There was nothing else around and she recovered after I removed them. So, yes, pretty sure — Catra replied.

—They look the same as any other piece of tech we have seen before— he insisted. —Do you remember *how* they were placed?

—Not really…

—But we have a suspect. If the guy did it, we can bring him in to recreate it and run some tests, maybe?— Adora suggested.

—Hold on. We may not need that— Catra interrupted. —It was his area of investigation, remember?

—Oh! Do we have access to his research!?— Entrapta asked, excited.

—Pretty sure we do!— Adora realized. —Alright, we'll get that. You continue your tests.

—And, Hordak— Catra called, before leaving. When he looked back at her, she smirked and said —You did it once, you can do it twice.

Fortunately, they got ahold of the investigation and gave it to Entrapta that same night.

However, they also wanted to talk with Shadow Weaver, but she and Castaspella hadn't been seen since the incident earlier, so they would have to wait until the following day.

That way, a bit after breakfast, Adora and Catra found them at the gardens.

—Would you accompany me, Head Sorceress?

—Of course, Adora— she agreed.

They both walked away and into the building, leaving Catra and Shadow Weaver alone to speak.

—I take it that you're here about yesterday's incident, am I right?— the woman asked, while looking at her plants now that she could no longer tend to them.

—Yeah, but, a bit more than that. What I'm going to tell you is known only to a few people. Like, a really reduced group— she began. —You can't even tell the Head Sorceress about this.

—You know she will ask… And I rather not lie to her.

—You don't have to lie; you can tell her this part of the truth: it's a secret project we've been working on for years— Catra explained.

—Enough for me— the woman agreed. She then dusted her hands as if there was still soil on them, and joined them behind her back as she turned to fully face her. —What is it that you want to know?

—I need you to tell me everything you know about the First Ones' tech, its interaction with sorcery, and what made you tell the King Father what you said yesterday.

—Why?

—Because I want to fix my mistake… But Entrapta can't locate her. *Literally anything* you can tell me will help.

So it was about *that*…

She quickly realized what the girl meant, and now her expression made much more sense.

—Very well…— the woman sighed.

From a certain height, inside the building, Adora and Castaspella looked outside at the gardens, both with their eyes on Catra and Shadow Weaver.

—It's so hard to believe, isn't it?— Castaspella said.

—You never saw them on *actual* speaking terms, I guess— Adora replied, her expression soft. —This… looks a lot like the broken reality I recall. Them speaking this way, not a sign of fear in Catra… This was her dream— she explained.

—It's such a simple thing… it shouldn't have been her dream but her everyday…

—I know— Adora sighed. —But it has now become her everyday, at long last.

Chapter End Notes

I'll be honest, I feel like maybe the title wasn't that right, because the part that focuses on the First Ones' tech is really short, and only near the end, but HEY, titles are difficult! My brain gets fried every time I have to come up with a title!!

On the other hand, I must admit that the part of SW hearing people say Casta would be "better off with someone else", was actually my way of sublimating my own rage after seeing an old tweet saying exactly that.
It's actually something that really triggers my anxiety, and I wrote this scene shortly after, about two years ago or so, and posted it to twitter back then…
The feelings SW had? Those are the ones I felt, specially since it made me think that, after how I used to be, and despite changing in the past 5 years, I didn't deserve the love of my GF (now I actually have yet another partner too, so now it would be feeling like I don't deserve either of them)
So… nothing. Just a little note on that.

That aside, I'd love to know your thoughts!
What do you think "worse" means in that context? And what do you think SW and Catra talked about? Eh? >^<

Alright! See you next week!!

An Overdue Conversation

Chapter Summary

As time goes by, some things become old news, while others remain a topicality.
Unfortunately, such things are mostly the issues related to Shadow Weaver.
It is simply impossible to keep her out of the center of attention…
And so, a much overdue conversation finally takes place.
And yet, it might not be what they expected…

» —So she's… good with people?
» —No, she's absolutely terrible with people (…) she's just too awkward, doesn't really know how to treat people who don't *need* her.
» (…)
» —She's been so patient with us…
» —Too much, I'd say. She's extremely stubborn.
» (…)
» He'd be damned…
» This was the first time he actually smiled with this woman since her corruption.

Chapter Notes

Welcome back!! Woot woot! New chapter -as early as can be, it's around 1am- with some stuff I had kinda been requested long ago (hinted in the summary and title)

And speaking of requests, this chapter comes with an eliminated scene that *also* includes a certain repeated request I got ~~cause omgs you guys are obsessed, but why not~~

Anyways, I hope you enjoy today's chapter! And I beg the edition to be good enough… I'm currently at the beach, away from my desktop PC and my correction tools lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

One bright morning, Castaspella woke up sprawled on bed. They were just entering the hot season, so the spells to keep Mystacor's cool temperature weren't in place yet. But it was quite difficult to withstand the heat for the Head Sorceress…

Even sleeping naked wasn't enough.

Feeling sweaty and sticky, she pushed herself up from the bed and went to take a cold shower, completely forgetting for a moment that Shadow Weaver was right there with her.

—Good morning, Cas— the woman let out, condescending as she was, startling the sorceress on purpose.

Castaspella jumped a bit, turning around at the sound of her voice, and had to hold onto the frame of the door to the bathroom so she wouldn't fall.

—Oh, my Stars, Beatrix— she sighed, a hand on her chest as she tried to calm down. —I can't believe…

—…You forgot I was here…

—Yes, sorry— Castaspella apologized, expression pained as she gave her a tired look. —I can't believe that after almost eight months I could somehow forget…

—Such an interesting phenomenon, isn't it?— the woman pressed her, standing up and approaching slowly.

—Don't start… I'm just… too tired and too overheated right now— she tried to excuse herself, yawning. However, she immediately regretted her words when she saw Shadow Weaver's smirk. —Don't say anything…

—Why? Did you say you're…

—"Overheated" as in I'm sweaty and grumpy!— Castaspella interrupted. —So *try* to be nice and *don't* mock the way I said it…

—Alright, alright— the woman conceded. —Need any help in there?

—No— the sorceress assured her, walking into the bathroom and closing the door. —I'll be out in just a bit!— she said from inside.

It was longer than "just a bit", which gave Shadow Weaver enough time to come and go before Castaspella stepped out of the bathroom, wrapped in a towel, and sat on the bed.

—Better?

—Much…— she nodded, before letting out a relieved sigh. —You're very lucky your summoned body doesn't emit heat, otherwise, I'd have you sleep on the couch— she then joked.

—Would you!?

—Don't give me that look…

—I'll look at you as I please.

—Whatever… I can't stop you from behaving like a jerk, I guess— Castaspella let out, rolling her eyes.

She expected a comeback from the woman but, right that moment, there was a knock on the door.

—I'll get that if you come a few steps closer— Shadow Weaver offered.

Staying where she wouldn't be seen, but close enough that the woman could interact with reality, Castaspella observed as she received a tray from an acolyte at the door.

—What's that?— she asked, shocked.

—Should I explain the concept of breakfast to you, or is that merely an exclamation of surprise?

—Shut up!— the sorceress complained, her eyes glued to the delicious-looking food on the tray. —Did you go to the kitchen while I was bathing?

—Maybe?

Castaspella could hardly hold back a smile, feeling immense joy, and approached her as she left the tray on the desk.

—Thank you— she muttered, before kissing Shadow Weaver's cheek.

The woman turned to look at her, half a smirk curling her lips, and leant forward briefly to kiss her properly.

—And you wanted to make me sleep on the sofa…

The Head Sorceress couldn't help herself and let out a hearty laugh.

—No! I said I would if you had a real body! Be-because you'd have body-heat— she explained, still laughing a bit. —But, you don't, so, as I said, you're very lucky. *I'm* too lucky — she concluded, leaning against the woman and hugging her waist.

—Well, *lucky girl*, eat now before this goes to waste…

Castaspella giggled and let go of Shadow Weaver; however, instead of sitting at her desk, she took the tray to the bed and invited her to join in.

They chatted about what they would do that day, the sorceress mentioned that Glimmer had brought news about Delwyn the previous night, and that he would apparently return in around two years… Shadow Weaver told her a bit about the investigations she was guiding, and how some were promising talents that could potentially become tutors…

Now distracted, Castaspella felt *much* better.

She wouldn't say it, but it always made her so happy to notice these little details the woman would occasionally have…

Thinking about it, she realized this was her way of apologizing for the scare she gave her earlier, and a way to make her feel better regardless of the heat.

Despite behaving as usual and having a moment of absolute bitchiness, she had managed to make her smile this morning.

Even though she did *not* utter a single nice word, she still did something nice for her, in a way that kept her from feeling "weak" or "pathetic", as she complained several times.

Castaspella had told her to "try to be nice", and she *was*.

Once again, the Head Sorceress found herself appreciating every bit of effort Shadow Weaver was putting into their relationship…

The King Father arrived at Mystacor later that same day. It had been more than a month since the incident with the First Ones' tech. For almost ten days, the council tried to prove whether their former member had been behind what happened, to no avail. Neither his involvement nor his innocence could be proved…

It was a complicated situation.

But Castaspella decided there was no point in further trying; no real damage was done, both the tech and his investigation had been confiscated, and they would achieve nothing by proving *he* did it.

Hence, the matter was dropped.

But it wasn't the end of the problems related to Shadow Weaver.

Not even close.

Micah followed closely all the complaints issued by different acolytes during the subsequent month. Mainly, it was still about her wandering near the sealed chamber; such reports were promptly ignored, as per the agreement. Unfortunately, the rest of them were worrisome.

All morning, the King Father had been going over them in his head and had decided to find Shadow Weaver and confront her about the matter on his own.

People were expressing *fear*.

And that inevitably took him to dark corners of his memory.

Apparently, the woman had been threatening them for little things that angered her, and was very *creative* at it. From throwing something at them to making them piss their pants from fear, Shadow Weaver had uttered a dozen different threats in a single month. She was never even close to fulfilling them, but Micah figured it was thanks to his sister taking her away.

That day, there had been yet another incident, so he was told he could find the woman in an empty room where Castaspella had taken her…

—I'm sorry, Sis… Not that I don't trust you… I don't trust *her*— he muttered, before walking in.

It was an empty parlour, only furnished with three couches and a small table. On the larger sofa, Shadow Weaver sat comfortably, looking down at her lap where the Head Sorceress rested her head. It looked like she was soundly asleep while the woman gently caressed one of her hands, noticing how calloused it was…

—Go ahead, speak your mind…

The sound of her voice brought Micah back to reality.

He was honestly speechless for a long moment.

—Never expected to find such a… soft scene; not including you, at least— he admitted, slowly closing the door behind him.

With a neutral tone, Shadow Weaver replied —You could consider it her fault- Erm, her doing.

That little correction would normally be negligible, but not in this case. The King Father was genuinely surprised as he realized what that meant.

Shyly, he let out —She really changed you.

—Gave me a different purpose, to be precise. Something other than power to pursue— the woman corrected him, still caressing her hand. She then looked up at him to explain —It's what she's good at. Your skills have always been for casting and practical things, while hers lay somewhere else.

—So she's… good with people?

—No, she's absolutely *terrible* with people— Shadow Weaver denied, deadpan. —It is true that she's good at leading people in serious situations; they listen to her because they know she will make sure everyone is safe. But in general situations, she's just too awkward, doesn't really know how to treat people who don't *need* her— she clarified.

—She's good at… *helping* people— Micah reflected.

—She's not what people want, but she's *definitely* what people *require*. We tend to reject what we need if it doesn't adjust to what we want, which puts her in quite an uncomfortable situation, especially if she wants to help someone who keeps rejecting her— she further explained, with a condescending tone.

—Are you hinting at me?

—I never hint. I meant that in general, and it happens to apply to you. And me… I'd say— the woman replied, looking down at the sleeping sorceress.

—But you listened to her from the beginning, never rejected her— the King Father argued, confused.

—Believe me, I did. Just not as… *histrionically* as you— she countered, rolling her eyes.

He had not considered that.

It meant Castaspella had dealt with quite some frustration because of both of them, yet… never gave up.

—She's been so patient with us…— he sighed.

—Too much, I'd say. She's extremely stubborn.

Micah couldn't help letting out a laugh.

However, he had a different opinion.

With a soft look, he expressed —Well, she *is* stubborn, but this… This isn't her being stubborn, it's her giving us one of the purest forms of love. She's genuine in her actions and feelings.

Shadow Weaver could hardly hide the shock.

He really…

—Are you saying what I think you're saying?

—Yes, yes— he uttered, rolling his eyes. —I admit it. She *actually* loves you, you didn't charm her.

—Kind of you to drop the accusations.

—What about dropping the mockery as a thank-you?

—Whatever makes you think I'd thank you?— she asked back, with a scowl. However, as soon as he opened his mouth to complain, indignant, she let out a smirk and admitted —I'm just annoying you. Thank you, Micah. I suppose I can stop mocking you. For a while, that is…

Well, that was more than he expected.

He'd be damned…

This was the first time he actually smiled with this woman since her corruption.

—Better than nothing, I guess.

With a long sigh, the sorcerer walked towards one of the free couches, took a seat, closed his eyes, and rested back for a bit.

There was a long silence until Shadow Weaver decided to break it.

—Your sister is quite the character, you know?— she casually said, her sight on Castaspella's relaxed features. —Once I found her asleep at the library. She was… well yes, completely knocked out and in a really uncomfortable position. It *pained* to see.

—That's… Yes, that's normal of her— he laughed, eyes still closed.

—I supposed she was barely falling asleep and tried to wake her up as "gently" as I could manage, but when I touched her face it became obvious she was deep asleep.

When she *what*!?

The King Father choked on air and doubled down, coughing for a moment.

When he recovered, he sat back again, pretending it was nothing, and shook his head a bit as he asked —Erm, why did… Why would you wake her up by *touching her face*?

—Does it make you uncomfortable!?— she laughed, shamelessly. —Then you shouldn't know more than that.

—But, *why*? Is it another one of your… your *jokes*?

—Your sister is quite easy to fluster, which I've come to find very amusing. So yes, it's partially because of that— Shadow Weaver admitted.

—And why else?

—Didn't I just say you better not know more? I'm warning you…

There was a hint of mischief in her tone, and Micah couldn't help feeling quite scared of it.

—You know- You- Just… just make your point, okay?— he stammered.

The woman was laughing internally…

—Fine— she conceded, holding back. —As I was saying, I touched her face to wake her up; I have my reasons to do it like that. But what surprised me was that she… leant onto the touch. She was asleep, but… that's exactly why it took me aback: without me manipulating the situation, I hadn't been trusted like that *ever*, I think— she admitted, staring at the sorceress. —And I wouldn't have imagined it would feel so… warm.

He couldn't help thinking back at that fateful day, and how she had done the same gesture right before disappearing from his life forever.

He could understand why it surprised her, but he felt like he wasn't quite grasping what the woman meant.

—So…

—She's giving me a different perspective, Micah— she stated. —And I can hardly believe it myself, but it would be foolish to deny or resist it— she sighed, shaking her head slightly.

The King Father looked away, pensive.

He felt so… *troubled*.

This was so far from what he expected when he headed for Mystacor that day…

—I… have to tell you something— he decided to say.

—Go ahead.

—I actually came here to… confront you about the threats you've been making— he admitted.

—*What*!?

—Don't you know people report each time you threaten them?

—No— she hissed. —That's ridiculous.

—They do, Shadow Weaver. People are afraid— he explained. —They didn't do it before, in case you wondered. But, now, they can do that because it's one of the things we agreed upon after bringing you back— he elaborated. —I know sometimes people exaggerate, and that's why I look into each report, but…

—But *what*?

—Even if you don't do everything you threatened to do… it's really *a lot*— he told her, indignant. —You have to understand that only my sister trusts you and knows you well enough to be sure you won't fulfill your threats! The rest of the people around, they really fear for their lives… And I… I don't know what to think.

—So I'm the big bad villain, am I not?— she asked, mockingly. —Tell me something: are the reports anonymous? Or can you see who filed each one?

—I won't disclose that information…

—I don't need it— she interrupted him. —*You* do. Check who has been submitting those threats from me, and how often. I won't deny I said all those things, but don't tell me people are scared of me if it's always the same five people who piss me off— she went on. —And before you tell me I can't justify it… I have nothing to justify, because I've done nothing other than get angry when annoyed.

—That's debatable, but… I will look into the names, alright? And I'll ask around to anyone who may have witnessed those discussions— he decided. —I would ask Casta but they could easily say she's biased…

—I suppose that's fair— Shadow Weaver had to admit.

Micah did as promised. He interviewed as many acolytes as possible, took his time to organize everything he was told, and once he had gathered his thoughts, he went to the council to expose his findings.

Castaspella was gladly surprised to learn he had actually put so much effort into that investigation; she never revealed it, but she was slightly awake back when he went to confront Shadow Weaver, and she had been wondering whether he really believed her or just told her what she wanted to hear…

The final decision was unanimous: while they would continue to accept reports of her threats, they would now require the context that would let them better judge the situation.

Meanwhile, at the Lunarium, Ari and Sahm are exposing their latest investigation to a group of interested acolytes, under the supervision of Shadow Weaver.

—The objective for the end of the year is to craft a safe experiment to demonstrate our theory — Ari concluded.

—And what's stopping you?— an acolyte asked, his tone a bit too snide.

—We *said* we're trying to make it safe— Sahm promptly replied. —Haven't you heard what can happen if proper safety measures aren't taken?— he added, defiant.

—Enough— Shadow Weaver stopped them.

But the acolyte ignored her and pressed on.

—Sounds to me like you're just making up excuses. Why are you presenting this if you have no proof?

—I said *enough*— the woman insisted, but got dismissed with a gesture. She immediately clenched her jaw to stop herself, yet still uttered —Insolent little brat…

—I'm talking to you two, answer— he demanded. —Or will you keep hiding behind a ghost?

—You better stop being so disrespectful towards our Master!— Ari exclaimed, hands closed in tight fists.

—All of you, stop!— she demanded, raising her voice. —Ari, Sahm, the presentation is over. Don't engage in unnecessary arguments.

—But…

—It is *not* worth it— she remarked with a severe tone. She then looked back at the acolyte and told him —As for you, learn to distinguish interest from petulance. If you are *honestly* interested in their experiment, that is *not* the way of expressing it.

—Oh, so now you are a hypocrite!?— he immediately exclaimed. —You want to police how I talk, but when *you* threaten to throw something at anyone who upsets you, it's alright?

—*What*!?

—What did you just say!?

—You didn't…

Both Shadow Weaver and Sahm's indignant questions echoed through the Lunarium, freezing everyone in place, while Ari's muffled mutter died on their hands. The woman couldn't take it anymore, and she knew that, whatever she did next, Sahm would follow suit.

Fortunately for them both, the sound of rushed footsteps called their attention towards the entrance before anyone could make a move.

—Is the presentation over?— Castaspella cheerfully asked, completely oblivious. But it didn't take her too long to notice the atmosphere as she slowed down. —Oh, no. What happened here?

—Want the truth?— Shadow Weaver spat, irritated.

—Of course I want the truth!

—Then *I* should explain— the acolyte immediately said.

—Like shit!— Sahm reacted.

—Alright, enough— Castaspella sentenced, rushing to get between them. She placed a hand on Shadow Weaver's chest to keep her away from the acolyte, while Ari held Sahm back. —Enough yelling, enough arguing. Everyone, get back to your activities— she ordered. —You two have a lot to do, I imagine— she told her former students, hinting that they should leave. —And you, if you're so eager to tell your version of what happened, you're invited to fill a report. We have a new requirement— she *politely* told the acolyte, who simply huffed and walked away, fully intending to submit a report. Castaspella then took a deep breath and reached for Shadow Weaver's hand, saying —Let's go…

—Where?— the woman demanded to know, fuming.

—Just follow me…

Mumbling angrily, she let the Head Sorceress walk her back to their room, yet didn't notice where they were until she had her sit on the couch.

—Am I grounded now!?

—No…— Castaspella sighed, holding back a laugh.

—I am *really* trying, okay!? But it is *not* working!

—Bea…— she called, holding her wrists.

—I so wanted to surround that bitch in shadows and shut him up forever!

—Beatrix! I *know*! I saw Sahm's reaction, it *wasn't* just you— she pointed out. Her tone then turned softer as she pleaded —But you need to calm down and breathe…

—I *don't* breathe! And your damned psychological bullshit won't work!— she was yelling, furious, until a sudden kiss interrupted her. The sorceress pushed her against the couch and little by little she let go of all the tension. Once relaxed, Castaspella pulled back and smiled at her. —Is this your great plan to calm me down?

—This was more of an… emergency measure— she playfully replied, sitting on her lap. —You were so worked up and, again, I saw Sahm was just as angry, so I can only suppose you were provoked.

—You have no idea— Shadow Weaver muttered, glaring at the distance.

—Anyone would get angry in that situation, I'm sure Sahm would have punched him if Ari didn't stop him, but… the one struggling to control her anger and violent impulses is *you*, so I *know* you were about to explode— Castaspella gently explained. —Until you're more in control, I have to distract you however I see fit…

—Is that a promise?

—Yes?

—Perfect.

Tilting her head while a smirk appeared on her lips, Shadow Weaver caught her in a kiss again and pushed her down on the couch…

Chapter End Notes

Well, well, how did you like that!?

So, yeah, I had been asked when these two would have a proper conversation, and while I did give that in TaTM, this is *more like it*. Oh, and actually, I'd say this is a more important conversation, but it will only become obvious next chapter (^v^)

For now, I hope you enjoyed AND here I'm leaving the eliminated scene for you (U3U)

Until next week it is!!

When The Past Returns to Haunt You

Chapter Summary

"All good things must end" is becoming a constant in Castaspella's life, to the point she can't even visit her niece without *something* happening to Shadow Weaver. Be it her fault or not, it's always something different and remarkably unexpected.
» It turned out to be a bad moment for Castaspella to be absent, looking after three-year-old Glow, probably teaching her to knit…
» Why? Because trouble began the moment the stranger *saw* her.
» —You… How the fuck are you here!?

On the other hand, the Best Friends Squad is a step closer to fulfilling their secret project. A step closer to fulfilling their most ambitious mission up to the moment...

Chapter Notes

I particularly like this chapter, and it makes a good point of showing how much Micah has changed. Not only SW has grown, he has too!!

Also, I just finished editing this a moment ago, it's like, midnight, I'm on a friend's computer, not mine, so I don't have my editing tools... I can only HOPE this will be okay <("^-^)

Also x2, I'm trying to make this quick so I can go to sleep, but like, I can't reall if there was anything else I wanted to say, oops!!

So just, please enjoy!!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The following day, the Head Sorceress was in a noticeably good mood, which everyone kept pointing out, gladly surprised. However, this also sparked a wave of rumours that inevitably reached Shadow Weaver's ears.

—And you're just going to let them speak like that about you!?— the woman indignantly asked Castaspella.

—I haven't heard the rumours, which means they are, in fact, respecting the only request I made years ago— she explained. —I cannot control what they talk about, and I shouldn't,

anyways. They are free to think whatever they please, as long as they remain respectful enough and *don't* shamelessly mention it when I'm within earshot.

—Why would you allow it!?

—I can't police their speech. I can only hold them accountable for what they say. It's called freedom of speech, which doesn't mean freedom from consequences, you know?

—That makes… sense. At least for you, I guess— Shadow Weaver remarked. —But I still believe they *shouldn't* be allowed to defame *you*, their Head Sorceress, so blatantly.

—I am *not* a tyrant— she insisted. Squinting, she reproached her —Besides, haven't you insulted Norwyn behind his back, right to his face, as well as several times in the past few years? You've even insulted the council so many times! *And me*! Are you saying you should have been somehow "punished" for it?

—That- I-it's not the same— the woman stammered. —I wasn't talking like they are about yours or anyone's love and sex life!

—Ah…— Castaspella sighed. —I just… Can you *please* ignore them? Like I told you many times: whatever they say, it doesn't matter. It *shouldn't* matter to you.

—It's *so* annoying— she muttered.

—I know, Bea— the sorceress gently said. —But getting worked up over it is *not* worth it. It only feeds your anger, makes it more difficult for you to handle it…

—I suppose.

Castaspella stepped forward and took Shadow Weaver's hands, giving her a soft smile. The woman held them back tightly, trying to suppress the rage she knew the sorceress was could feel through the spell bound to her heart, and, little by little, she calmed down…

Time proved the Head Sorceress right.

As months went by, the rumours died out and it didn't seem to affect Castaspella's reputation in the least. Besides, what's more important, Micah never learnt about them.

Five months had gone by in relative peace; Castaspella's duties barely burdened her so she had *a lot* of time to knit, and Shadow Weaver continued to guide the investigations that some of her former pupils began. She even got requests from *other* acolytes…

At first, she was hesitant. For some reason, she believed it had to be a trap of some sort. But the Head Sorceress encouraged her to give them a chance; if they *were* setting her up in any way, she would personally handle the matter.

And so, for the last three months, she had been busying herself with her new duties.

That day, the woman was walking down the halls after a review session with an acolyte, when she came across someone, apparently the same race as Shadow Weaver but dark-skinned, who *clearly* didn't belong to Mystacor.

It turned out to be a bad moment for Castaspella to be absent, looking after three-year-old Glow, probably teaching her to knit…

Why? Because trouble began the moment the stranger *saw her*.

With a murderous look, that gray-haired elf hissed —You… How the fuck are you here!?—. It bewildered her yet she remained composed, and seeing the woman's lack of reaction only angered that mysterious person even more. —What!? No snarky comments now!? Stars! You can drop the act 'cause I *remember you*. What was it that you said back then? "*Pitiful excuse of a life*"? Or the first time I tried to escape, "*Stop wasting your strength like that, you will never leave this cell, whether you cooperate or not*". Oh, but nothing like "*Just talk, make yourself useful, and your pathetic life shall be spared*"— the elf angrily yelled, calling the attention of few bystanders' around, and gesturing dramatically as he mocked Shadow Weaver's manner of speech. Obviously, no one dared say a word; Castaspella had told them never to get involved in such situations. So they promptly left them two alone. Smirking sardonically, the stranger gloated —How does it feel to be proven wrong? *I fucking escaped*! And I've been wanting to rub it in your face for years! But you don't even remember me, do you? No, of course, *why* would you?

The woman remained expressionless and speechless, only stared without revealing what was going on in her head or the strong feelings she was experiencing.

Having teleported there, Castaspella appeared suddenly before either could speak, her eyes teary from the pain she was feeling. Pain that came through the spell…

—Wha-what's going on!?— she breathlessly inquired. Yet she didn't wait for a reply and simply rushed to Shadow Weaver's side to ask her, in a low tone, —Who is this? Do you know them?

She was about to deny it… until realization hit. The Head Sorceress noticed it in her expression but couldn't stop her from leaving without saying a word. Castaspella considered going after her, but the immense pain she felt made her change her mind. It was evident that Shadow Weaver needed space now.

The elf seemed in shock after witnessing that. Having no idea who she was, the stranger only guessed that she must be the Head Sorceress as she bore the crown, yet the way she had treated Shadow Weaver made it hard to believe. But that thought was quickly discarded as it looked like Castaspella was about to collapse from the pain.

Unable to stand straight, and keeping a hand pressed to her chest, she was resisting the urge to cry. However, she soon heard the elf approach and looked up with a sorrowful expression.

—Are you alright? Do you need help?— the stranger offered.

She certainly needed it and, normally, she would have accepted it and remained polite.

But not this time.

Instead, with a hoarse voice, she severely inquired —What did you tell her!?

—I-I'm sorry!?— the elf uttered, bewildered.

In absolute disbelief, the stranger looked so horrified that it didn't take Castaspella much effort to realize this was someone who *clearly* hated her. She needed to find her as soon as possible, but first she would have to deal with this unexpected guest.

Both seemed equally ready to argue yet, hearing steps approaching hurriedly, their attention was drawn to Micah instead, who was rushing towards them.

—Hey! There you are!— he cheerfully said, addressing the elf. —I've been looking for you everywhere!— he added, before noticing his sister. —Woah, are you alright, Sis?

Yet she didn't reply. She focused on finding Shadow Weaver through the spell and made an effort to teleport to the beach.

Indeed, there she was, yelling at the cloud waves.

With the last of her strength, she managed to reach her and, a few steps away from the woman, she breathlessly called —Bea…

—Cas?— Shadow Weaver uttered, looking back and rushing to catch the sorceress before she hit the ground. —Careful— she softly said, helping her sit on the sand with her. The woman began caressing Castaspella's hair, feeling guilty, and let out a sigh. Then, she apologized —I'm sorry for making you feel like this. I- It's just that- I got overwhelmed and there was this… pain in my chest that I don't understand. I wish you didn't have to feel it.

—It's better now— she assured her. —But, can you tell me what's going on? Who's that elf? What did they want?

Once again, the sorceress felt the pain that Shadow Weaver refused to express, looking unbothered instead.

After a moment of silence, she finally began —Early during the war, years before Adora was brought to Etheria, the Horde captured several important strategists of the rebellion. If I'm not mistaken, you must have been a teenager back then, it wouldn't surprise me if you never heard of him—. Looking away, she went on —But he was always the most outstanding, even before I joined the Horde. He was imprisoned and kept alive *because* I knew he had information. And, while I was never in charge of interrogations, I was sent plenty of times to intimidate him; I was the one who made the decision to keep him as a prisoner, so I had to make him useful.

The woman closed her eyes tightly and Castaspella rested against her while taking her hand.

—Go ahead. I… won't judge you— she promised.

—He was still there when Micah was captured and until he was sent to Beast Island— she reluctantly continued. —And what he said… He repeated several things I had told him. Things I… I never regretted, because I didn't even recall his existence until now— she admitted. —I had just- I erased him from my memories. And now… he reminds me of that time, and how that could have been Micah. Back then, I would have done exactly the same to him, just like, years later, I did the same to Adora and Catra. I had no reasons to think about it before but… I always used the same discourse about being pitiful, pathetic, useless…— she explained. —And it-it's literally everything I've ever feared for myself; in my head, that was what I had to intimidate them with because *nothing could be worse*. But that was *for me*— she realized. The sorceress wanted to comfort her, but she wouldn't dare interrupt her. Shaking her head slightly, Shadow Weaver concluded —For them, it was some emotional manipulation that may have left a scar on them, especially in relation to self-worth, but… I can hardly believe I kept doing to everyone else what I suffered and had always hated so much…

That was certainly enough to justify the painful feeling that had overwhelmed them…

So, how does one respond to that?

What could Castaspella possibly say?

This wasn't the first time Shadow Weaver opened up to her, yet it felt so… special.

Perhaps it was the way she was expressing herself, demonstrating how much her mentality had changed…

Unable to find a suitable reply, the sorceress simply hugged her and sighed.

—Bea…

—Don't ever repeat what I said— the woman abruptly told her, her tone severe.

—Of course, I won't— Castaspella assured her, looking up and cupping her face. —Can I?

—Kissing me will solve nothing— she uttered in refusal.

—I know. I just… feel like you're letting your self-hate take over you, and I wanted to remind you that… you're loved now— the sorceress shyly admitted.

—I- That's- Cas… I *don't* deserve it.

—This again?— she gently asked. —Don't you notice your growth? What you're feeling, this guilt and sorrow that overwhelmed you, the realization… Those are all signs that you *have* changed for the better— she remarked. —You're no longer the Shadow Weaver he knew.

—But I can't erase what I've done!

—I know. And he's probably never going to forgive you either— Castaspella sighed. —Yet, that doesn't mean all your effort wasn't worth it, alright?

—I… suppose.

—So, I'd suggest staying away from that man, alright? It will be better for both of you.

—Certainly.

Shadow Weaver grunted, seemingly frustrated, and looked down at her; this time, it was her who cupped Castaspella's face, moving it closer for a tender kiss.

That little gesture reminded the Head Sorceress why she had to give the woman space and time, without feeling rejected or fearing she didn't really love her.

No, no. She just had so many contradicting feelings, such a messy turmoil within her, that expecting her to effortlessly show love would be ridiculous…

Meanwhile, Queen Glimmer was busy doing some administrative tasks, when an official message from Entrapta was delivered to her. Curious, she dropped everything and opened it, wondering why the princess hadn't simply contacted her through her tracking pad like usual.

It had to be quite important… Enough to make the queen rush to get her husband and friends.

—Hey, Sparkles! What was so urgent?— Catra asked, walking into the former war room, with a confused expression.

—I got a message from Entrapta— she began, showing them the letter she got.

—Written!?— Adora exclaimed. —What does it say!?

She couldn't hold back her excitement and smiled brightly as she told them —It's an official request to start testing our project!

—What!?— Bow reacted, eyes wide open.

—You mean it's complete!?— Adora asked in disbelief.

—At long last!— Catra celebrated. —It's been, what? Seven- No, eight years?

—More, actually… But, well! Apparently, the key was the First Ones' tech— Glimmer pointed out. —And I knew she was making progress thanks to it and the investigation from that sorcerer but… I didn't think it would be ready so quickly!

—She managed in a single year what she'd been struggling with for almost a decade— Bow observed, pensive for a moment. However, his expression went a bit sorrowful as he hesitantly uttered —That's… impressive.

—Just like your projects, which are better each day— Glimmer promptly reassured him, making him smile faintly.

—You're gonna accept her request, right?— Catra finally asked, after giving them a moment.

—Well… As much as I'd love to give her permission right away, I first need to confirm that it's safe this time. For which, perhaps, you should tag along?— she proposed. Then, she seemed to remember something and told Bow —Oh, and she explained her calculations and conclusions in the request but I don't really understand, so perhaps you could take a look? I need a comprehensive explanation to officially process the request if I finally accept it.

—Sure, Love. Should I stay while you all go?

—No, come with us! I'm sure you're dying to see what Entrapta did!

—Alright— he smiled.

And so, once they left Entrapta's letter in Bow's workshop, Glimmer teleported them all to the Crypto Castle…

Back in Mystacor, at the Steam Grotto, the King Father and his friend had been relaxing for an hour, just catching up.

—…And before I knew it, I was chipped!— Micah told him, before letting out a sigh, shaking his head in disappointment.

—Wait, you were chipped!? So was I!— the elf perked up. —That thing of the hivemind was so bizarre. So many voices…

—Yeah, but the voices were nothing compared to his mind control— the sorcerer remarked. —I… was forced to attack my own sister and daughter… It was even worse than torture— he expressed.

—I can't even imagine— his friend admitted, sorrowful. Wanting to change the subject to distract him from those memories, he decided to ask —Speaking of them, how are they? I only heard about Queen Glimmer's coronation, but not much news about the Rebellion reached my hideout. And I *need* to know what happened with your sister earlier.

—Yeah… Let me begin with Glimmer— he awkwardly laughed. —She's clearly happy with her friends and the life they have built together. I'm so proud of her. I… missed most of her life, but at least I was there for her wedding six years ago. And for my granddaughter's birth about three years ago!— he started, cheerful. —I thought I wouldn't see her again, and I could hardly believe how much she had grown, but I'm thankful for being in her life now.

—It's unbelievable how much time went by, right?

—You have no idea. *Especially* when you spent half of that time trapped on a remote island!

—Has it been hard to re-adapt to society?

—A bit?— Micah hesitantly said. —I've been told I lost my social skills and, as much as it pains me, it's true— he admitted. —I had to relearn a lot of things, specially practical skills like cooking, and, of course, more common-sense knowledge like that I don't hold the absolute truth.

—What do you mean?

—Well, after so many years alone, having no one to contradict me, I got used to considering every one of my beliefs was true— the King Father explained. —I had to learn the hard way that… that's simply *not* right— he sighed. —You wanted to know about my sister too? Well, *a lot* has happened with her lately, which is what made me realize how wrong I was…

—I don't think I follow.

—Listen. My sister, she… she also changed a lot since I last saw her. And I was… Ah… I was petty and stubborn, didn't trust her judgement, so our relationship almost got ruined. *I* almost ruined it— he began. —I didn't listen to her, I believed that I knew how she felt, I was sure that I knew better than her what was best for her and how her relationships with others were… When, in truth, *I should have known* I needed to get to know her again.

—And why did you argue so much?

—You won't believe it— Micah bitterly laughed.

—Come on, try me— the elf insisted, sliding closer.

With a sigh, he began —Alright, so… While I was chipped, Casta was so desperate to free me that she made a deal with none other than Shadow Weaver.

—What!?— his friend reacted, bewildered, thinking back to what had happened earlier.

—That's nothing— he remarked. Anticipating his reaction, he went on —The deal was to investigate a way to free me, by means of freeing Etheria's magic; however, Shadow Weaver made my sister promise to stop her if she tried to take the power for herself.

—Stop her!? So-so you're telling me that *the* Shadow Weaver, that power-hungry maniac, didn't want power!?

—In my sister's words, she was being genuine for once when she said she only cared about freeing me before Prime made me hurt others or myself— he explained. —Look, Casta hasn't trusted anyone blindly since… like… her teen years, when she lost her tutor, and *especially* wouldn't trust people who represent a threat to her loved ones, or those with ulterior motives. Despite that, she said Shadow Weaver began proving she could give her a chance, at least a bit of trust, even if she remained wary around her.

—Micah, that makes no sense— the elf stated. —How can you trust someone but be wary of them at the same time!?

—I didn't understand at first, but I saw it with my own eyes: Casta trusting her just enough to allow her to do certain things, yet paying attention to make sure Shadow Weaver wouldn't do

anything evil— he tried to explain. —Imagine… giving someone a certain amount of "freedom" but expecting them to do something wicked, hence being ready to resign that freedom.

—Okay?

—But, again, that's *nothing*— the King Father assured him. —*After* the investigation, their relationship changed. I mean, everyone says they seemed different when they returned. Like… friendly. Which is *impossible* for Shadow Weaver and, as far as I know, they haven't used the term "friends" ever, but that's how everyone else described their dynamic— he continued. —Now, it wasn't the kind of "friendship" in which you do nice things together, like us, no. It was a question of respect, even if Shadow Weaver was still quite an annoyance to Casta. E-everyone told me with a lot of humor that, when they had to explain their discoveries, the woman first allowed Casta to speak when she asked to be the one to do it *but*, soon after, Shadow Weaver cut her and briskly explained everything herself. So, yes, that annoyed Casta, but she reproached the woman with a very light-hearted tone, *and* some pointed out that Shadow Weaver's tone when she replied, the manner in which she told her she was "taking too long", was *soft*.

—That's unbelievable. I can't even imagine that— his friend admitted, disgruntled.

—I *know*! But apparently, a lot of unbelievable things happened. And keep happening, actually… Let me finish the story— he requested. —The last time Casta saw her before she died…

—*Died*!? Wha-what are you talking about!? I just saw her earlier!

—Oh, you did? Well, I- You'll understand soon, really— he promised. —As I was saying, the last time she saw her, Casta says they had a *heartfelt* conversation that made her believe there was some… uh… *good* deep inside her, and that she could have returned here to help us, maybe— he started again. —But she only told me this after *months* of looking depressed and going to the Lunarium just to… linger there in silence. You can imagine it started to worry me— the King Father narrated. Then, he lamented —That was when I made my first mistake: thinking she had been *charmed* by Shadow Weaver yet *never* telling her I thought so. I-I just offered to summon her so Casta could "settle whatever unfinished matters they had" but, in truth, I just wanted to make Shadow Weaver undo whatever she had done to Casta.

—Bu-but… it makes complete sense!

—Didn't I tell you that Casta doesn't trust people with ulterior motives?— he reminded his friend. —I betrayed her trust.

—You were trying to protect her.

—I know! That's what I said! But… I was wrong— Micah admitted. —Casta wasn't charmed, alright? She had genuinely become something akin to friends with Shadow Weaver. She told me how she's the only one who doesn't pretend in front of her, who tells her things as they are, corrects her if necessary, and has taught her a lot… Just like, it later became obvious, Casta taught Shadow Weaver a lot too.

—Sure— the elf incredulously said, clicking his tongue.

—Trust me, I thought the same… but I was blinded by hate.

—You're kidding me.

—No, no. I'm telling you. Casta unearthed the best in Shadow Weaver… and I ruined it— he lamented. —For the summoning, we used her old mask, you know? And in all my rage, I destroyed it. I got into *a lot* of trouble for that. Not only with my sister, also with the council, my own daughter, *and* She-Ra herself.

—Wait, what!? Wi-with She-Ra!?

—She-Ra, or rather, Adora, was raised by Shadow Weaver, along with Catra. They… saw Shadow Weaver die, and recovered the mask. We had asked them to borrow it for the summoning… promised to take care of it, yet I…

—Bullshit, Micah. Why would you feel bad!?— the elf asked, seeing him so sorrowful.

—Long story short… as time passed… Casta, she… *fell in love*— he explained, leaving his friend in utter shock. —And what's more… Shadow Weaver feels the *same way*; it's insane but it's true.

—Ho-hold on… Tha-that's why- So that's why she was so angry at me!?

—You mean when I found you? I forgot to ask, what happened?— Micah asked, curious.

—When I arrived and was looking for you, I came across Shadow Weaver. Now that you mention having summoned her, it makes sense why she looked so weird, but I didn't give it importance at the time. I just- I saw her and immediately blurted out all I had been wanting to tell her, to reproach her, since I escaped.

—Then why did Casta look like that? She seemed in pain— Micah pointed out.

—Well, she arrived a moment after I confronted Shadow Weaver, asked what was going on, and it weirded me out when she went to check on that *hag*, worried-sick! But yeah, she then looked in pain, I tried to offer help, and she yelled at me!

—Wha-what did she say?

—She asked what I had told her! A-as if it were all my fault or something…— the elf replied, indignant.

—Oh, I see… that-that makes sense— Micah stammered, not daring to look at his friend. —You see… Casta, uh, is connected to Shadow Weaver, for *reasons*, and can feel whatever she feels— he explained. —Which means that, believe it or not, the one who was in pain was Shadow Weaver.

With a sardonic spat, the elf mockingly said —Sure! Her ego must have hurt!

—I mean it, man…

—So I'm supposed to be nice to her or what!?

—No, no. Absolutely not— Micah assured him. —Just… avoid her, don't engage in conversation, it's not necessary.

—Look, to begin with, no one should just be "connected" to that nightmare of a woman— he began. —But in general, why is she even allowed to be here roaming free!?

—Didn't I tell you… Stars, you didn't catch it— he realized. Rubbing his hands over his face, she gathered the courage to say —Alright: Shadow Weaver is, uh, Casta's partner now.

—You're joking.

—No.

—Micah, that can't be…

—Much as I disliked it at first, I can't deny how happy I see my sister now. And if Shadow Weaver is the one who makes her happy, *somehow*, then I can't keep getting in the middle— the King Father explained.

—That's insane!

—Trust me… I spent like… eight years thinking like that, feeling that the world around me had gone crazy— he admitted. —But I was… just living in the past, denying the present… I was told several times how immature my attitude was, how paranoid I had become, and that I was obsessed with my *idea* of Shadow Weaver ruining everything I love.

—Because she *does*— the elf hissed.

—She *did*. No one denies that. But it wasn't right pretending she hasn't done some good lately, for a change.

—I don't understand how you can say that.

—Alright, tell me something— Micah finally said, seemingly fed up but refusing to get angry at him. —Have you heard what happened with Hordak, after the war ended?

—I understand he works with Princess Entrapta in Dryl, yes.

—And do you find it somehow unfair, undeserved, or something?

—I… well, I never thought about that, but he's *working* to help Etheria now— the elf pointed out.

—He's the one who gave the orders to capture us, have us interrogated, and who sent Shadow Weaver to do so personally even if it wasn't her duty— Micah reminded him. —But, as you said, he's now making up for all the damage he caused, so it's fine.

—Yes! Exactly! And what is *she* doing!?

—Well, initially, Casta wanted her around because she could provide vital information to help her and the council, you know?— he began. —And, even though I didn't want to recognize it at first, she *did* immediately demonstrate how much she could help, because the information she provided let us save the whole of Mystacor before it was too late— he went on.

—What!? How!? And why would she!?

—Casta had found an old investigation Light Spinner did long ago, about something called the Crystal of Arxia which, only she seemed to know, was the source of the island's floating capability.

—If your sister had the investigation, why would she need her help?

—She couldn't fully understand it, if I recall correctly. So, as soon as the first quake happened, Casta had Shadow Weaver tell her what to do— he explained. —And, for some reason, she *did* tell her. Perhaps because of that, uh, *respect* she had developed for my sister?

—Or because she wanted to earn her trust? Make her believe that she was indispensable so she wouldn't be banished?— his friend proposed, reminding Micah of his own thoughts.

—Can't say I didn't think the same. But now, I'm starting to believe that a part of her, at the very least, was helping her without expecting anything in return.

—Alright. She did that. She did *one* good thing. Great for her… Now, what else did she do in all these years since her summoning?

—She tutored a group of children that had extraordinary magical potential and no other tutor could take charge of— he began enumerating. —She helped with administrative issues, provided information that Casta would only have managed to find with exhaustive investigation, and she *could have helped* with an issue we later had with some magical beasts that caused trouble in Plumeria… *if I had consulted her first*. And that was all within *months*.

—I'm telling you, she was just making herself indispensable to make sure she would be kept summoned— his friend insisted.

—And I'm almost convinced that was the case at first, I mean it. But *after* I broke her mask, she had no reasons to do it anymore— Micah remarked. —Like she had no reasons to apologize to the girls she raised and traumatized at the Horde, or to *me*. Yet she kept helping for years, still does, and… she put effort into learning how to apologize, *just for us*.

—So that's it, isn't it? She apologizes and suddenly you stop hating her— the elf accused him.

—No, no. I was- Sometimes I still have my doubts but, recently, I finally got undeniable proof that she cares for Casta— he assured him. —She's still a bitch to most people but she seems to be making an effort for her.

—What makes you think that?

—Do you remember how she would get whenever she didn't get what she wanted or when we insulted her? The fits of rage and all those violent magical attacks?

—Absolutely.

—Well, now she's far more controlled. Seriously. Instead of jumping to attack or, well, scare people which is the only thing she can do now, she either leaves immediately or throws a threat she never fulfills— Micah told him. —It's far from ideal, but it's still *so shocking*, I kid you not.

—Sure…

—But back to the point I was trying to make… Doesn't it make us hypocrites to be "fine" with Hordak being free, and getting a second chance, but then thinking the opposite about Shadow Weaver?

—That's- I- What the fuck, Micah!?

—Look… You don't have to agree with me, but please follow my advice and stay away from Shadow Weaver; it'd be for the best.

—Fine… Of course I disagree, but, ugh, whatever. It's your sister, not mine, so…— he reluctantly accepted, leaning back. —Well, then… Changing subjects: what about dinner?

The following day, early in the morning, Castaspella came across Micah, who happened to be looking for her. He waved and rushed her way.

—Oh, Sis! Finally.

—Looking for me?— she asked, curious.

—Yes, I- A-about yesterday…

—Ah, yes— she interrupted. —Actually, I wanted to ask: who is he and why was he here?— she inquired, visibly confused.

—I invited him to visit! He's my friend! We were both imprisoned together by the Horde.

—Why only now, after so many years? Obviously he escaped long ago, so why didn't you invite him soon after the war ended?

—When he escaped, he traveled very far away…— he first replied. However, as Castaspella stared in silence, he added —Really far away…

—Brother…— she insisted, giving him an incredulous look.

—Alright, I had no idea where he was hiding until last month.

—Well, that explains it. But why invite him *here*!? Why not to Bright Moon?

He laughed sheepishly and explained —We promised each other that, if we both survived, we would come here to take a bath in the Steam Grotto.

After a moment of shock, she finally told him —I won't even tell you how that sounds…

—What?

—Forget it. Just… a little heads-up next time. Especially since, and you should have known, he could easily cross paths with Shadow Weaver— Castaspella reminded him. —If you had told me, I would have made sure that wouldn’t happen.

—Really?

—I understand why he exploded at her, trust me. And I would rather have avoided it overall — she admitted.

—Wow, um… Thanks, Sis. I-I’ll make sure to tell you if he ever visits again— he promised, grateful.

Chapter End Notes

If you caught it, you caught it!!!

That would be all, and, like I said in the initial notes, I'm trying to make this quick to go to sleep, so I can't recall what else I wanted to say here ._.

In any case, I hope you enjoyed this chapter, please leave me your opinions, and see you next week!!!!

A Question of Trust

Chapter Summary

Castaspella's duties have her leave Shadow Weaver unsupervised in Mystacor for about three days.
Just three days. What can possibly go wrong?
What about *everything*?

» —Head Sorceress… I…— he began, but interrupted himself when he noticed Geldirik behind the sorceress, shaking his head and gesturing at him to stop. —Excuse me, it's nothing. I apologize.
» (…) —Sho-shouldn't we tell her?
» —Not us. Let *her* be the one to tell our Head Sorceress everything; we'll later solve this at the next meeting.
» —Are you sure she will tell her the truth?
» —Ah… She better, because our Head Sorceress will easily see through her lies if she tries to twist the story.

Chapter Notes

I have to say, it's quite unfortunate that Micah's words about SW's progress will feel so bitter in this chapter but HEY, he's still not wrong!!

This chapter will HURT in a way, but also further proves SW's change and growth, I believe (UvU)

Oh, and, one of the things I wanna mention is that *SW cries/sobs* in one scene, which I struggled to make as credible as possible.
I believe it's not really ooc, but rather just a show of how much this situation affected her, to the point she did something that feels so different to her expected behaviour...
So it might be weird to read, but I promise it makes sense.

Anyways, I'll let you read now :D Enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Two days later, a request arrived from the Kingdom of Snows, seeking the Head Sorceress' help with some matters that weren't urgent but needed to be solved within the month. Hence, Castaspella decided to prepare everything and depart a week later…

She would be away for three days, and in that time, Shadow Weaver would *technically* be left unsupervised, so they had quite a conversation before she left and, just in case, Glimmer was notified about it. After all, if anything happened, she would have to intervene in her aunt's stead.

Fortunately, the issues were solved and Castaspella returned to Mystacor in time as planned.

However, there would be more waiting for her on the island…

Even before the Head Sorceress set foot there, she was focusing on the spell bound to her heart, so she knew Shadow Weaver was in their room, and rushed there immediately.

She had no idea, but the woman was *hiding*.

However, she pretended everything was fine and even accepted Castaspella's kiss without a second thought.

—Oh, my. I'm so happy to be back— the sorceress expressed. She expected Shadow Weaver to mock her, call her "silly" or a fool, or even "childish"… But, as the woman didn't, she teased her —And I take it that you missed me?

—Sure…

—Aw, come on. Don't be nervous!

—Who says I'm nervous?— Shadow Weaver reacted, before realizing it. —That damned spell…

—Indeed. So, why don't you tell me what's going on?

—Don't you have anything to do?— she asked back, refusing to reply.

—Ugh, fine, yes. I need to have lunch, settle back, and deal with whatever the council has kept for me to review and all…— Castaspella admitted, groaning.

—Then better go.

—Alright. But we'll talk later, understood?

Once the Head Sorceress had her lunch, she finally went to meet the council, which they so eagerly awaited. She reported the situation she had found in the Kingdom of Snows, explained everything that was done by her and the pair of acolytes that accompanied her, and was happy to announce everything went smoothly.

With that matter settled, the foreman-councilman asked for a second meeting to be held later that same day, and Castaspella dismissed the session.

—Head Sorceress…— a councillor called her, before she could leave the room. —I…— he began, but interrupted himself when he noticed Geldirik behind the sorceress, shaking his head and gesturing at him to stop. —Excuse me, it's nothing. I apologize.

—Oh, alright. Well, then, see you later— she farewelled.

Once she was out of earshot, the councilman asked Geldirik —Sho-shouldn't we tell her?

—Not us— he denied. —Let *her* be the one to tell our Head Sorceress everything; we'll later solve this at the next meeting.

—Are you sure she will tell her the truth?

—Ah…— he sighed. —She better, because our Head Sorceress will easily see through her lies if she tries to twist the story.

Castaspella arrived at her room soon enough, only to find Shadow Weaver looking out through the window.

—Bea?— she called. As the woman wouldn't reply or look back, she approached and hugged her from behind. —Is everything alright?

—Sure…

—Ah…— she sighed, knowing something was *absolutely* not right. —Why don't you tell me how these three days have been?

The woman opened her eyes wide, surprised.

She didn't know yet…

—I… don't want to talk about that for now— she admitted.

—Please, Bea…

—I can't!

—Why?

—I'm… ashamed— she finally admitted, letting out a long sigh and looking down.

—So that means something bad *did* happen— Castaspella concluded, reaching for Shadow Weaver's face to gently turn it towards her. —Look at me— she requested. When she did, the sorceress assured her —It's a good thing that you're feeling ashamed of what you did. *Anyone* can do bad things, anyone can be as violent as you, but as long as you recognize how wrong it was, instead of taking pride in it or justifying it, and as long as you regret having done that, then I consider it progress, and so should you.

Feeling somewhat comforted, Shadow Weaver fully turned, smiling faintly, and ready to tell her everything, she hesitantly began —I…

Yet a muffled scream reached the room and interrupted her.

—She did *what*!?— Micah's voice yelled.

—Alright, listen to me— the woman rushed to say, panicking now. Holding Castaspella's arms, she explained —I didn't mean to do it. I can't justify what I did, even if I didn't know I *could* do that, and I know it was wrong to get so angry, to begin with. But I swear I would have never done that intentionally.

—Done what!?— Castaspella asked, confused and scared now.

—I'm sorry! I really am! I just… couldn't bear it!

—Bea, what-what happened? What did you do?

Frenetic knocking on the door called their attention, and Shadow Weaver simply *broke down*.

—I was yelling, she approached me from behind, and then her arm was… a-all black an-and corrupted!— she finally explained, sobbing against the sorceress' shoulder and barely holding back tears, while desperately clinging onto her.

—Oh, my Stars, Bea…— she lamented. —Alright… calm down, yes? Calm down…— she tried to comfort her, ignoring the knocking on the door. —I have to open before he breaks in, alright? You just stay here…

—Don't!

—I have to— she insisted, sorrowful. —It will be worse if I don't talk with him.

—Damn it…— the woman muttered, reluctantly letting go of her.

Taking a deep breath, the Head Sorceress reached the door and gathered strength before opening it.

Micah was fuming.

—Where is she!?

—Hold on…

—Do you know what she did!?

—Yes, now I know— she replied, keeping calm.

—Then where is she!?

—Micah, listen to me— she severely ordered. —I didn't know it before, but this must be why Geldirik called for another meeting later today— she explained. —So, whatever you want to

say, save it for the meeting.

—So what!? You'll prepare her defense in the meantime!?

—Brother, calm down!— she insisted. —I have no need to do that— she first said. —What I want to do is to speak with the acolyte to know what happened while I was gone.

—Her arm is all corrupted! And *she* did that! She had told me she'd never carry out her threats! But look now! What else is there to know!?

—I need *context*, Micah! You understood that well enough when we updated the requirements for the reports— she reminded him.

—What use is context now!? She-she *hurt* someone! Who cares if she was provoked!? I don't care if that acolyte was literally poking her with a stick! This shouldn't have happened!

—And you're right! But *I* do care about what happened that led to that! If the acolyte was poking her with a stick, I want to know. If the acolyte was passing by and Spin simply didn't like her face, *I want to know*!

—Fine— he grunted. —As you wish. As long as you make sure she's in that meeting *ready* to face the consequences.

—Of course— she agreed. —But, next time, don't be so *violent* when you come to complain about *her* violent behaviour.

—Right— he admitted, rolling his eyes yet slightly ashamed. —Sorry.

The time for the council meeting arrived faster than expected, and Castaspella had to rush there along with the young acolyte she had been interviewing for a long while. Even Shadow Weaver was there already, pretending she didn't notice the councillors muttering about her sulking.

—A-are we late!?— the Head Sorceress asked, promptly taking her place, while the acolyte behind her awkwardly stood near the door, hands behind her back.

—Of course not. We were simply early— Geldirik said, making her chuckle.

—I-I'm sorry…— the acolyte finally dared say.

—Oh, right. Please come closer, yes? You can stand here— Castaspella told her, gesturing at a spot to her right.

The young acolyte cleared her throat and with a confused expression asked —I'm sorry, but I was told this is about what happened yesterday?

—That's correct— the foreman-councilman nodded.

—Bu-but I never filled out a report…

—We know, but this issue can't be overlooked— Micah chimed in, earning a severe look from Geldirik.

—As King Father Micah said… it is our duty to address this matter promptly. Waiting for our Head Sorceress was enough delay.

—It's not that severe…— she tried to argue, but Shadow Weaver herself interrupted her.

—It is. If anything, I would know— she assured her, looking away in shame.

—I know this is serious, but I only need it healed or something— she replied. —There's no need for the council to get involved.

—Ho-how can you say that?— Micah blurted out, indignant. —You'd just let Shadow Weaver get away with it?

—She didn't mean to, and even promised to help me get rid of the corruption— she revealed.

Realizing things could get out of hand if she just allowed this to go on, Castaspella clapped her hands together, calling everyone's attention

—Alright. Enough unnoficial discussion— she declared. Then, addressing the acolyte, she calmly explained —Like I told you earlier, I would rather not do this, nor put you through all this process, but… things concerning any harm done by her must be discussed by the council. It's part of the agreement made to *allow* her to be here in the first place.

—I see… I'm sorry— the acolyte finally accepted, lowering her head and rubbing her arm slightly behind her back.

—Well then, this meeting officially begins— she declared again. —I would like to begin with a little summary of what happened. Although I have been informed, I believe someone who witnessed it is better suited for this— she then clarified.

Having said that, she gestured at the acolyte to encourage her to speak.

—A-alright. It began with a bit of a discussion. We were at the library, most of us studying, and I could hear Shadow Weaver correcting a draft of some investigation, I think. It sounded pretty advanced— she started. —She was explaining something when another voice interrupted and accused her of, like, poisoning the minds of everyone she's been teaching. So I went to see what was going on, and the other guy was yelling something about, uh, her proving his point because she was enveloping him in darkness— she went on, hesitant as she tried to remember. —I don't know why I did it, I should have known I'm *not* like the Head Sorceress, but I tried to defuse the situation. I forgot she was incorporeal, my arm went right through her, and then…— she explained, interrupting herself as she raised her right arm, which she had been hiding until then. It was all bandaged, yet it still emitted an eerie glow. —It burnt awfully so I screamed, and that was when she noticed. She-she stopped and was in

shock. The other guy accused her again, she ignored him and asked what happened to my arm. She then recognized it was like the parasite magic and promised to help me get rid of it… In the meantime, she told me to keep it wrapped like this and avoid sorcery. Which helped soothe the pain, I swear— she concluded.

—You're saying… she apologized?— Geldirik asked.

When she nodded, Castaspella glanced at Micah, who seemed conflicted.

—Tha-that's hard to believe— a councillor let out, shaking his head. They were standing next to the King Father, and gave him a look like expecting his support.

—I *told you* they wouldn't believe it— Shadow Weaver hissed, addressing Castaspella.

—Yes, I know— she replied. —However, I have proof of her regret— she clarified. —If you allow me, I could tell them what happened earlier— she then offered the woman.

—I would rather be banished than let them make a mockery of me— the woman first refused.

—This could be your only chance to prove us wrong for our disbelief— Arden pointed out, wanting to convince her.

—Indeed. But of course, I will only disclose what happened if that stays in this room— she clarified. —I will take immediate action if anyone spreads rumours, dares comment on this, or even makes fun of her. And if anyone now makes any reference to her having weakened or softened, you will *not* like what will come of it— she warned them, severe.

And yet, after a moment of silent agreement from almost everyone, the councillor next to Micah spoke up, with a smug look.

—Oh, so if your "girlfriend" here is mocked you will become a tyrant?

While the rest of the council exchanged surprised looks, yet remained speechless, Castaspella let out a bitter laugh and asked back —Does that sound like me?

They didn't know how to interpret it, the rest of the council seemed confused too, but Nolrem and Arden caught it immediately and looked at each other with shock.

—You don't mean to say…— Arden began.

—You would step down— Nolrem completed, noticing their hesitation.

—Exactly— she confirmed. —Because if you let me down like that, if you show no respect which is the *only* thing I ask of you, then I'd have to take it as a sign that you're not worth my time and energy; much less the effort Spin has been putting into learning and growing, because you can easily ruin all her progress if you make such comments, mock her, or spread rumors— she added. —Am I clear? Keep this to yourselves.

Some nodded, some muttered in agreement, and Micah took a deep breath before saying —I promise.

Surprised, Shadow Weaver looked up and her expression revealed clearly mixed feelings.

—Thank you— Castaspella gently said. Right after, she looked back at the woman and asked —Then, would you trust me?

Her sight lingered on Micah for a moment before she finally agreed and moved closer.

—Just… be brief— Shadow Weaver requested.

—Of course— she nodded. —Basically, when I arrived today, she was in our room, which seemed normal to me. The second time, I found her staring out of the window, and when I asked how these days had been, she… admitted feeling ashamed. When Micah came looking for her right at that moment, she didn't explain what she had done, only apologized profusely and swore she didn't intend to do it nor knew she could— Castaspella began. —Later I learnt she had been hiding there since what happened; she still refused to speak, but told me whom she had hurt— she went on. Looking back at the acolyte and gently placing a hand on her shoulder, the Head Sorceress concluded —She told me everything she has told you, and confirmed Spin did apologize as well as how she promised to help her out.

Once again, there was silence. With mixed looks, the council seemed to be in some sort of silent debate. The King Father looked at the acolyte as if expecting her to show signs of being intimidated or under a spell, and the councillor next to him only squinted at Shadow Weaver.

—I am really sorry too— the acolyte said, calling everyone's attention. —I-I didn't think something like this could happen just because I was… arrogant enough to believe I could defuse the situation as if I were the Head Sorceress— she expressed, repeating her words from before. —Actually, I knew I only had to get everyone away, like our tutors instructed us, but… I don't know why I did it.

—You shouldn't have needed to defuse anything to begin with— Shadow Weaver bitterly said. —Regardless of the fact that none of us knew I could… cause that— she added. —Whatever you want to punish me with, go ahead and order it. But first, allow me to get rid of that corruption in her arm.

With all testimonies heard, the woman was told to wait outside, and the acolyte was dismissed.

However, before leaving, the young acolyte stopped to tell her —I'm sorry for this…

—You shouldn't be— she replied, serious but not severe as usual. —Why didn't you file a report?— she then asked, curious.

—I was *trying* to avoid this.

—But why?

—Because it feels… unfair— she explained. —That guy was being so mean and annoying, I don't even know what he meant by that but… I know many of your former pupils, and also several people who have gone to you for help lately— she went on. —They are far from

being “poisoned” like he said— she stated. —And I know you didn’t mean to do this. It was my own fault— she concluded, looking down at her bandaged arm.

—No, of course not— Shadow Weaver sighed. —You’re not to blame at all.

—But…

—Listen: I’ve blamed others for *my* bad deeds enough times. This was entirely my fault, and that’s why I *will* fix it too— she assured her.

—That- Tha-thanks.

—Now, tell me something. Why did you try to defuse the situation? Weren’t you scared?

—I was. Yeah. But I knew that, if you hurt him, everything would focus on you doing wrong, ignoring what *he* was doing to you— she explained. Then, with a scoff, she pointed out —Yet it still happened because of this…

—I see…— the woman let out, pensive. —Alright, just forget it. Focus on keeping that arm covered until we find a solution, am I clear?

—Of course— the acolyte nodded.

Bowing slightly to thank her, she finally walked away.

It didn’t take long for the council to reach an agreement, and Shadow Weaver was soon called inside again.

The sentence? She was now forbidden from using her illusions without Castaspella around, lest someone went through her again. They knew there had been cases of people going through her and nothing had happened, so they presumed it was related to this kind of sorcery she was still capable of. Logically, they considered that would be the best solution.

On the other hand, she was expected to help the young acolyte, which meant she couldn’t simply “give up” whenever she wanted, unless there was proof that everything had been tried.

Meanwhile, the reason Queen Glimmer wasn’t present at either of those meetings, despite knowing what had happened, was simply that she and her friends were at Dryl.

She had given her permission for their project to be tested for the first time.

—What if it fails again?— Catra hesitantly asked.

—Don’t worry. Entrapta included a failsafe so it will shut down if it’s unstable— Glimmer assured her.

—That was my idea— Adora proudly said.

—Of course— her wife sighed, rolling her eyes yet smiling a bit.

—Alright, let's back away a few meters— Bow said, interrupting their conversation.

—Good thing we left the kids with Melog— Glimmer pointed out.

—Alright! Time to begin!— Entrapta excitedly announced. —Everyone ready!?

—We're all in position— Lonnie assured her.

—Then pull the lever, Hordak!

As nighttime arrived, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver walked back to their room when a thought occurred to the woman.

—You know, I was expecting you to scold me as usual— she began. —You could say I was looking forward to *what* you would point out this time.

The sorceress let out a chuckle, finding it a bit amusing.

—Oh, Bea… Do you know why I scold you?

—Because it's entertaining for you?

—Aw, come on. Think— Castaspella insisted.

As they reached the door to the room, Shadow Weaver halted and reflected —I suppose it's because you want to make me see what I'm not seeing?

—That's correct— she smiled. —This time you could see it all perfectly in my opinion.

—Really?

—Yes. I have nothing to reproach you— she assured her. —Except that you won't let me show you love— she then joked, pretending to be offended and crossing her arms in front of her chest.

—You're ridiculous— Shadow Weaver replied, rolling her eyes. —Let's go inside and I may just let you indulge…

Chapter End Notes

Ok, let me see…
I wanted to say that I put a lot of thought into this chapter, but mostly I wanted to explore what would happen without Casta around or close enough to just show up and

advert a crisis lol
So that's mostly what this chapter is about + showing SW's growth!!

Also, did I just make a "pull the lever, Kronk" reference? Yes, I did lol



Erm, btw, the second council meeting, when Casta warns everyone about mocking SW, and tells them to keep it to themselves, you know how Micah said he promises, instead of just saying “yes” like the others? That’s a REALLY obscure reference I don’t expect anyone to catch. Basically, it’s because of how, so long ago, Light Spinner made Micah promise to do everything she said. We don’t have in canon his answer, but it’s obvious you reply that “I promise” when someone asks you to promise something XP
Oh, and, btw, I spent a good while debating whether to make Casta say “my room” or “our room” because I really wasn’t sure whether she’d say it like that or not. I also considered making her correct herself from “our” to “my”, but finally decided to have her say “our room” because I’m pretty sure she’s proud of her relationship with SW, opposite to how SW has a hard time feeling any kind of pride or joy in admitting she loves her, solely because she still hasn’t cast out her belief that love = weakness.

The Return

Chapter Summary

What she broke, she will fix. Yet getting rid of the parasite's corruption will prove a real challenge for Shadow Weaver.
It will take her long, but not as much as some bargained…

» —No way! She actually has the solution already! *Someone* owes me.
» —Only if you can find them.
» —Please, I'm begging you. *What* is going on!?— Lance asked, one final time, on the brink of tears.

And just as everything falls into place… it's finally time for a most awaited return.
Catra's most difficult mission, a trial of sorts…

» —I realize everything has changed too much while I was gone. The war ended, the stars must be back, and surely my girl is now the Queen. Why would you want to take me back? I am not needed anymore.
» It made Catra shake her head immediately.
» —No! That's not- E-everyone pretends I didn't- I-it's like I've done nothing wrong, but that isn't true. Some things I can't fix, this was one of them. But now I can! And-and…

And?

Chapter Notes

Well… This chapter is SO long… almost 9k words, guys. Can't say I don't feed you well XD
Nah, but seriously. I considered cutting it, but it was a bit unbalanced like that. And yet, only the last… 3 almost 4k words are actually "the return" as the title says… But well, same issue as with "First Ones' Tech", alright? Titles are hard!

Also also, Finn's stellar apparition will make you all cackle, I know it XD

Now…

Enter Angella…

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Much to everyone's surprise, Shadow Weaver dedicated almost all her time to finding how to help the acolyte she had somehow corrupted. The only one who wasn't surprised but rather proud was, obviously, Castaspella.

For a whole two weeks, the woman spent all day until midnight at the library, occasionally helping with other investigations, but mainly concentrating on her own. The Head Sorceress would sometimes try to help her too, reviewing her notes and giving a well-deserved break to whoever had been helping her that day.

—If only I had my own body… I wouldn't need others' help when you're not around— Shadow Weaver angrily muttered when they were both alone.

—Please, Bea— Castaspella gently said. —They are helping you because they want to, alright? It's not pity or anything. You've… earned their respect!

—Or they expect me to owe them…

—Why the negative thinking? Did something happen?

—No! That's the problem! Nothing happens! Everything I try, it all *fails*!

—Bea, Bea… You *just* began about a week or two ago— she reminded her.

—Precisely. It's pathetic— she uttered, shaking her head.

—Stars, woman… You're being too hard on yourself.

—Listen. I know what that thing is, I know its effects, and I *should* know how to get rid of it — she explained. —So I'm trying again tomorrow, and this better *work*!

—Can you please listen to me?

—What!?

—Even if you fail tomorrow, the important thing is that you're not abandoning that girl— Castaspella emphasized. —And you're worried about her well-being, even if you don't want to admit it. You've made sure the corruption doesn't get worse, that it doesn't hurt her more… Don't you think that's already a lot?

—But not *enough*!

The Head Sorceress sighed deeply.

She no longer knew what to say to change her mind.

—Alright. We'll… see tomorrow, okay? Now let's rest for the night.

—I would rather stay here with this… but you'd be stubborn enough to stay with me just so I don't bother another poor soul to move the pages for me or write the notes in my stead.

—See? I didn't even have to say it! Now come on…

—Fine. But I'm taking these notes with me— she finally agreed.

—As you wish— Castaspella accepted. While they walked out of the library and made their way to their room, she suddenly commented —I'm not sure how you manage to understand so many different hand-writings…

—I was a *tutor*, remember?

—And?

—Have you never corrected exams?

—I never take written exams, *remember*? We didn't either during the months you taught here!

—Right…

The next morning, when the Head Sorceress woke up, it surprised her to find herself alone. Shadow Weaver's notes were on her desk, but where was the woman herself?

Confused and a bit worried, she quickly got changed and left her room in a hurry, searching for her through the spell.

The gardens.

—…I know this will be the sixteenth attempt now, but I can't know what will work without trying— Shadow Weaver was explaining.

—And if it hurts again?

—We stop— she sternly replied. —But it's the only option because we *cannot* perform any kind of analysis on your arm. At least, nothing that isn't invasive.

—I see…

—Listen, I am *not* trying to make you suffer— the woman clarified, seemingly angry, but actually feeling anxious. —If I could- If I still had my body, I'd test it myself. But I can't.

—It's alright, I get it!— the acolyte assured her, a bit awkward.

That was enough…

Clearing her throat, Castaspella stepped closer to them and called —Spin? Everything alright?

—Absolutely— she immediately said, standing straight. —I was just mentally preparing her for today's attempt.

—I see— the Head Sorceress smiled. —Should we go for your notes?

—Not yet— the woman denied. —First, you two have to eat breakfast— she ordered. Then, addressing the acolyte, she added —Especially you. We wouldn't want you fainting in the middle of the process…

—O-of course— she accepted, bowing slightly as a farewell before returning inside.

—Can I tell you how much of an amazing progress you've made, or will that upset you?— Castaspella asked, moving closer to the woman and wrapping her arms around her waist.

—I'd rather you *don't* tell me how this is what I should have done with the failsafe…— she replied, rolling her eyes. —And let go of me before someone sees— she added, without exactly pushing her away, but looking like she wanted to.

—Sorry.

—Don't be— she denied, shaking her head slightly and gently making Castaspella turn around to handle her hair. Once she tied it up in a bun, oblivious of the sorceress' bright smile, she let her turn back to look at her. —Just go for your breakfast. It must be ready by now— Shadow Weaver told her.

—Why, thank you!

As arranged, about an hour before noon, Shadow Weaver took the acolyte to the Lunarium and asked Castaspella to help with the process as usual.

The woman guided her through the procedure of drawing the necessary sigils with crushed lunar crystals, and then preparing the basin for the girl to submerge her arm.

For a moment, it calmed down the pain, the burning sensation, and it seemed to be working…

Until it didn't.

The water began glowing brightly and, as the magic took effect, the parasitic energy within her arm seemed to "wake up". The sensation scared the acolyte so much that she began yelling desperately, begging them to directly cut her arm off.

It took Castaspella a long while to calm her down enough to bandage it again, while Shadow Weaver immediately left without a word.

The Head Sorceress knew where she was: the beach, possibly blowing off some steam.

She just needed time…

Despite the failed attempt, the acolyte found the woman the following day and asked her to retry.

—Why would you want to try again? It's evident it doesn't work— Shadow Weaver reminded her.

—Except that, today, we can use the eclipse— the girl pointed out.

—I… hadn't thought about that— she admitted. Pensive, she finally sighed and agreed —Alright. I'll get my notes. You can wait for us at the Lunarium.

Rushing to find Castaspella, she startled a few people on the way without even noticing. And, as soon as she explained what the acolyte said, they both hurried to get the notes.

—She wants to try again!?— the Head Sorceress asked, shocked, without halting or slowing down. —After her reaction yesterday…

—She thinks the Moons' alignment can help.

—Oh, shit. The eclipse!

—Exactly.

—How hadn't we thought about that?

As they finally arrived, Shadow Weaver picked up the notes and admitted —I've been wondering the same.

Then, they rushed once more to find the girl at the Lunarium.

—Alright, then… Let's try again— the Head Sorceress said, approaching the acolyte next to the basin. —Are you sure, though?

—Yes. I- Yeah— she nodded.

How unfortunate that it didn't work either…

Halfway through it, Castaspella recalled how Shadow Weaver had explained the surge of magical energy that the alignment causes, how it was so strong that it even bound the summoning spell to her heart, and all… And it hit them a bit too late that, not only the spell wouldn't work, but also, it would hurt her even *worse*.

—Get your arm out!

—What!? Why!?

—Just do as she said, please— Castaspella pleaded, both from about two or three meters away.

—The eclipse is almost…

—Take it out! Now!

—Why!?

—Please!— they both exclaimed, feeling powerless as they couldn't step into the sigils on the ground.

They didn't know how it would affect the process.

What if it made everything even worse?

—But…— the girl was saying when the eclipse began. —Ah!

—Fuck it!— Shadow Weaver let out, rushing forward to pull the acolyte away from the basin.

The sorceress managed to catch the girl and hugged her tightly while she continued screaming terrifyingly.

—It's alright. It will be alright— she repeated, letting the acolyte hold on tight as she began crying. Castaspella felt her lose strength after a moment, so she carefully knelt with her.

—I'm so sorry…— the girl sobbed.

—It wasn't *your* fault— Shadow Weaver pointed out, fists tightly closed as she looked away. —It was *mine*.

—Spin…

—No!

This time, the woman hid inside their room and refused to leave it for at least a month…

Nothing anyone said could convince her otherwise.

She only asked for books to be brought to her, waited for Castaspella to sleep to take notes on her own, and discarded so many ideas that her frustration became a constant feeling for the Head Sorceress.

Although the woman eventually returned to her routine and socialized a bit more, even after half a year went by, she had no solutions for the acolyte.

She didn't want to work with trial and error ever again, but now she hardly made any progress and was quickly running out of ideas.

However, despite her terrible mood, Castaspella convinced her to accompany her to Bright Moon for Glow's birthday.

—It will help you clear your thoughts, alright?

—I need to concentrate, not to clear my *head*.

—Fine, I said it wrong, but you got the idea. And yes, you need it!

—Cas…

—Please…

—Listen! The corruption has been climbing up her arm!— she began, getting so worked up that Castaspella could feel it with great intensity. —If it reaches her heart, it can *kill her*! The chances of surviving it are so slim, I still don't know how *I* could bear it! And, even if she managed to survive too, she'd be damned like me! Tied to the parasitic magic after her death!

—I… imagined as much— the Head Sorceress admitted. —But you will achieve nothing by burning yourself out… So, please. Have just a few hours of distention, and then, when we return, you can… go on with the investigation…— she offered. —Like every night…

That last addition actually hit Shadow Weaver.

Castaspella didn't mean to complain, but it was true that the woman had, technically, abandoned her a bit.

They no longer slept together, or sat together when the sorceress had her meals…

Nothing.

—Alright. I'll go— the woman accepted, letting out a sad smile.

—Thank you— she replied, her tone grateful and gentle.

With a sigh, Shadow Weaver offered her hand and, when she took it, she pulled Castaspella into an embrace before giving her a tender kiss.

—Why did you let me be such a jerk to you lately?

—You were too frustrated. I understand…

—Next time, don't be so understanding— she smirked.

The little gathering for Glow's birthday was cozy and joyful. Everyone was sitting around the large table in the dining room, and different conversations were taking place at the same time.

It reminded Shadow Weaver of that reunion Glimmer and Bow had organized to announce they planned to have Glow.

And she couldn't help feeling like back then: as if she wasn't really present.

The fact that only Finn would occasionally talk to her, didn't help either.

It really seemed like they were the only one who could see her…

—…So, you don't eat?— they curiously asked her.

—I have no need to. I am not alive— she calmly replied.

—But… why?

That would be difficult to explain to a ten-year-old kid…

—You know about magic, right?— she asked. As they nodded, she went on —Well, I died a long time ago, and thanks to magic I am back again.

—So you *are* a ghost— they concluded.

—Yes…— she sighed.

—Then why does Mom say I can't call you "Ghost Lady"?

—I- Which one of your moms said it?

Finn pointed at Adora and then said —She's Mom.

—So what do you call your other mom?

—Mamma!— they happily replied.

—I see… Well, what did your Mom say?

—That you have a name.

Shadow Weaver couldn't help chuckling at that.

—And what would that be?

—Erm… Light Sprinkler!

They said it with so much conviction that the woman had to bite back a cackle.

Alright, it *was* endearing…

—You almost got it— she finally managed to say. —But if you prefer calling me "Ghost Lady", I don't mind.

—Thanks, Ghost Lady!— they celebrated, noticeably excited.

Right that moment, Catra called, from the other side of the table, —Finn! Come here! Food is served!

—Okay, Mamma!— they yelled back. —Bye, Ghost Lady!

They immediately ran to their moms and sat on their chair, ready to dig in.

—Didn't I tell you not to call her that?— Adora reminded them, serious but gentle.

—She said I can call her that!

Rolling her eyes, Catra sighed —Fine. Keep calling her that… why not…

—Are you sure?

—Yeah, Love. It's kinda better, I guess.

Back at the other side of the table, Castaspella was chatting with Bow's dads and had completely missed Shadow Weaver's conversation with Finn.

—…Of course, there were serious consequences… but, as I said back then, I can't deny that it benefited me— the Head Sorceress was saying.

—It's actually so sweet! I'm so glad you and your brother are on better terms now— Lance exclaimed, his eyes practically shining.

—I agree. And I'm sure it was worth the effort— George nodded. —I am no longer fit to take risks…— he began, interrupting himself a moment to briefly look at Lance. Then went on —…But I would certainly risk everything for my husband.

—Yes…— Castaspella sighed.

—The three of you have locks of white hair already. *None of you* should take risks at all— Shadow Weaver interrupted, rolling her eyes as she tried to hide the warmth she felt.

—Hey!

—No need to point that out— Lance shyly uttered.

—You would too if you were alive— George pointed out.

—Not really. My species is *very* long-lived.

—Well, that's unfair— Castaspella complained, folding her arms.

The woman was about to make some snarky remark in return, but whatever Micah and Glimmer were talking about made them gradually increase their tone until the discussion got so loud that it caught everyone's attention.

—Well, you might *not* remember, Dad, but it happened! I have told you before that you used black magic against us!

—I perfectly recall how Prime made me attack you all, but what do you mean!? How could I *not* notice black magic corrupting me!?

—Maybe because you were chipped?— she pointed out, indignant at how obvious it was.

—But I recall everything else!

—You could have just blocked it! Yo-you completely ignored that part when I first told you! — his daughter reminded him.

—But…

—But what?

—Shouldn't I be scarred all over? That corruption is *permanent*!— he argued.

—I purged it from you. That's how I defeated you back then— she explained, trying not to yell anymore now that everyone else was silent. —I just- I was so scared, Dad. I thought I would lose you too… Again— she admitted. —I channeled everything in me, purged the corruption from you, and… you passed out. Auntie held you until you woke up.

Hearing that, Micah looked back at Castaspella, who silently nodded.

—I see…— he sighed.

—Sorry for that, guys. I- We got a bit… engrossed in our conversation.

—No need to apologize, your Majesty.

Everyone was surprised to hear Shadow Weaver, of all people, saying that.

—But…

—In fact, I have to thank you for drawing attention to that little argument you had— she went on, her tone… *curious* for everyone else.

—A-alright. *What* are you talking about?— Micah asked, utterly confused.

—Didn't you hear her? *She purged the corruption from you*— Shadow Weaver pointed out, giving him a meaningful look.

It took him a moment to catch it, but his expression showed exactly when he did.

—No way… That's- I can't believe it— he sighed.

—Erm… I'm sorry, can someone explain?— Lance politely asked.

—Yeah, can someone *include us* in the conversation, maybe?— Catra agreed.

—What they said— Castaspella seconded. —You're being very mean, Spin…— she was reproaching her, as the woman smirked sardonically, until she *also* understood. With a little jump on her chair, she exclaimed —Oh, wait! I hadn't thought about it! A-and you didn't know because you weren't there! Oh, Stars! You're right! Glimmer's powers are the solution!

—My power is the solution to what!?— the Queen inquired, even more confused now. —Is someone corrup- Oh… *Oh, fuck*!

—Sparkles!— Catra complained, covering Finn's ears.

—Does anyone else know this super-secret thing that's being discussed in parallel!?— Lance asked once more, now low-key offended. —Do *you* know, Son!?

—I… Don't?

—Actually, you do, Love…

—I do?— Bow asked her, raising a brow. Like the rest, it took him a moment to finally realize —The acolyte!

—What acolyte?— Adora asked.

—Mystacor has a bazillion acolytes, Arrow Boy… Could you be more specific?

—The one with the corrupted arm?— he added.

—*Corrupted arm*!?— Bow's fathers asked at the same time.

—No way! She actually has the solution already!— Catra laughed. —*Someone* owes me— she smugly said.

—Only if you can find them— Adora joked.

—Please, I'm begging you. *What* is going on!?— Lance asked, one final time, on the brink of tears.

—Alright, yeah. We really should explain— his son admitted. —Erm, well. A few months ago…

—More than *half a year* ago…— Shadow Weaver interrupted, arms folded and resting back on her chair.

—Right. Like seven, almost eight months ago, there was an incident in Mystacor, while Casta was away, and… an acolyte *may* have been corrupted… slightly.

—I got angry, tried to scare someone, and that acolyte tried to stop me, or calm me down. Instead, her arm went through me, and somehow got corrupted— the woman interrupted once more, looking at Bow's dads. —He's being too lenient by saying it like that.

—But the important thing is that she had promised to help get rid of that corruption, and now she found the solution!— the King insisted, sounding too positive for Shadow Weaver's taste.

—Don't even get me started…

—Then don't start— Castaspella reproached her.

—Alright. That's… scary— Lance finally managed to say.

—How could something like that happen?— George asked, confused.

—We didn't know it was possible. Otherwise, we would have had regulations to avoid it, at least— the Head Sorceress explained.

—Now I'm forbidden from using my illusions if she isn't around— Shadow Weaver explained, gesturing at Castaspella.

—Okay, okay— Adora let out with a loud tone, calling everyone's attention. —What matters is that it's now solved. Glimmer just has to repeat what she did with her father, and it'll be fixed!

—Uh, yeah! I can go tomorrow, maybe, a-and we'll get it done— the Queen offered.

—That would be wonderful— Castaspella accepted.

—While I'm *thrilled* to see that you're so enthusiastic and willing to help… the way you put it makes me think you don't know *how* to do it— Shadow Weaver interrupted.

—Right…

—But don't fret. You only need some instruction, a bit of study, and I'm sure you'll do just fine— she assured her, albeit with that condescending tone some had come to associate with her manipulation or sarcasm.

—Does she have enough time for me to "study"?— Glimmer asked, her expression conflicted.

—I may have expressed some concern for the negative evolution of her corruption, but you should have enough time, I believe— Shadow Weaver nodded, her tone more neutral now. —I'm sure it won't even take you a month to master it. Far less, I'd say…

—Let me guess: because I'm the daughter of a powerful sorcerer and an angelic being?— the Queen asked, rolling her eyes. —You used that one long ago…

—No— she simply replied, confusing Glimmer. After a moment, she elaborated —As you already did it once, all you need to do now is figure out *how* to repeat it. And you just so happen to have a very dear friend who had to do just that with her own powers, don't you?

Catra choked on her drink as soon as she heard that.

—You’re serious!?— she asked, her voice a bit strained.

—Do I ever joke?

Although Castaspella made a face suggesting she does, everyone understood what she meant.

—Well, damn. You want to give us a heart attack or something— Micah finally let out, almost laughing.

—Very funny…

—He kinda has a point— Catra commented. —Quick! Say something mean or we’ll think you are chipped!— she laughed.

While everyone tried, and some failed, to hold their laughter, when Castaspella looked back at Shadow Weaver, she was surprised to see her smug expression.

—First, attempt to teach her. Then we’ll see who laughs at whom…

However, the comment only made everyone laugh even harder. Even Finn, who chuckled while covering their mouth with both hands.

Meanwhile, Glow slept soundly on her baby chair next to Glimmer…

Two weeks passed.

Glimmer focused all her efforts on the study of angelic magic, cleansing sorcery, and the combination of both.

Just as Shadow Weaver had said, all the Queen needed was Catra’s guidance to turn an “accident” into a purposeful action.

—Well, Sparkles. I think you’re ready to try.

—And if it doesn’t work?— she asked, worried, and looking exhausted.

—As long as it doesn’t hurt her, no damage is done. Literally— Catra pointed out. —Besides, at this point, it’s the only way to know for sure if you’ve mastered it or if you still need to polish something.

—Hey, guys!— Bow interrupted, walking in after knocking twice on the door to the study. —Wow, Glim. Are you alright?

—Yeah…

—I’ve been telling her she can take a break already, but she refuses— Catra explained, rolling her eyes. —Even now when she’s pretty much ready, she still won’t trust she can do

it.

—Well, I also think you need to rest— the King agreed, approaching and placing his hands on Glimmer's shoulders. —Besides, you've been sleeping too little lately…

—I just want to get this done before it's too late.

—What do you mean by "too late"? Sparkles, it's been two weeks, *two*. Shadow Weaver said even if it took you a month, the acolyte still has enough time!

—But…

—No more buts, Love— Bow gently told her, tilting her head up to look at him. —Let's have dinner and go to sleep, yes?— he insisted. —I'm sure Catra would like to go home too, don't you think?

—Right… I've been holding you here, I'm sorry.

—No big deal, Sparkles.

—Alright— Glimmer sighed, standing up. —I don't think I can go tomorrow, but I'll try to go this week and see if I can purge the parasite from the acolyte.

—Well said— her husband smiled. —Then, good evening, Catra. Thanks for the help.

—Yes, thank you immensely.

—See you soon— she replied, smirking.

It finally took three days for the Queen to visit Mystacor. She asked Catra to accompany her, and they both went to find the Head Sorceress, who was on her way to the library.

While she went for the acolyte, they waited at an empty chamber where Glimmer would be able to perform the cleansing safely.

—So… I was thinking about Entrapta's last update. I don't think I understood what she meant— Catra admitted. —What does "travel the tangent of dimensions" mean?

—Well, Bow told me it means she's searching for a way to travel the "space" between dimensions, so to speak, instead of just from one dimension to the other…

—Oh, right. Because she's…

—We're here!— Castaspella accidentally interrupted, walking into the library with the acolyte in tow. The girl now had all her arm up to the shoulder bandaged. —Just… this doesn't look pretty, alright? It'll be better if we don't remove the bandage.

—Well, that glow *definitely* isn't pretty— Catra had to agree, taking a step back. —How have you been living with that for so long?

—The bandages help with the burning sensation; sunlight, or any light in general, appears to "bother it". And, well, without performing any sorcery, it doesn't hurt either— the acolyte explained.

—You don't think…— Glimmer began asking, but trailed off, seeing Catra's face.

—Alright. Let's get rid of that thing— she sentenced. —You know how it goes, Sparkles. Focus on feelings, don't hesitate, and even if it looks as violent as you recall it to be, remember that you can feel whether it's working or not.

—It's just that… Dad yelled so much, and then passed out, and…

—I'll be alright— the acolyte interrupted. Holding her arm, she explained —I've already gone through awful pain in past attempts. If this works, if I wake up with this thing gone, then I don't mind passing out for a few hours or even days.

—Hopefully, you won't— Castaspella commented. —But if you did, my brother woke up just a while later.

—Okay— the Queen sighed. —I need you two to step back and… I hope these walls are… sturdy.

—Ah, worry not— her aunt let out, with a dismissive gesture. —They are enchanted. Here we practice most offensive spells.

—Good— she sighed again, before taking a deep breath. With a determined expression, she drew the sigil as she recalled it, apparently a combination of spells she had seen in her studies and now understood better, and cast it, throwing it at the acolyte. —Ready?

The girl nodded, extended her right arm to the side, and Glimmer placed a hand on it. After a second, a bright pink beam shot forward, crashing against the wall at the back, and completely engulfing the bandaged arm.

The acolyte first bit back the pain, but eventually couldn't anymore and let out a scream that reminded the Head Sorceress of that last failed attempt with the eclipse.

Castaspella put a hand on her chest and looked like she wanted to intervene, so Catra placed a hand on her arm and gave her a reassuring look.

If Glimmer hadn't stopped, it meant it was working.

After a few agonizing seconds, it was done.

The girl seemed dizzy but nowhere near unconscious, and just staggered back.

The three women went to check on her, concerned, and helped her sit on the floor. They noticed her arm no longer glowed like before, and Castaspella dared remove the bandages.

The acolyte was like in a trance, and didn't process anything. She couldn't hear them, barely saw what was in front of them, and didn't feel her arm being released, now parasite-free.

For some reason, despite all her gentleness before, Shadow Weaver now refused to see that acolyte again. She made sure to stay away from her, left the library whenever she went there to study, or the gardens when she would go exclusively to talk to her.

—Why are you doing that?— Castaspella finally asked, confused after a month of noticing that.

—Not your business.

—I just don't understand why you're doing this to the acolyte! What has she done to you!?

—Nothing…— the woman muttered.

—Bea…— Castaspella sighed. —What is that pain?

—You have to *stop* doing that!

—But you're being irrational!

—Forget it. Just forget it.

Shadow Weaver couldn't bear the conversation anymore and immediately left, leaving the Head Sorceress alone in the halls, with the bitter taste of defeat.

Another four months passed in the blink of an eye.

Things appeared to return to normal, the acolyte seemed to have given up on trying to speak with the woman, and instead focused on her studies, managing to graduate soon enough.

But it was just appearance, indeed…

Once graduated, the first thing the acolyte did was start her own investigation, on the parasitic magic, no less.

And so, as was probably her plan, this attracted Shadow Weaver's attention.

For the first time in *months*, they both spoke again.

—Why?

—Because I want to?— the girl replied, obviously offended still.

—What do you expect to achieve with this investigation?

—Just some insight into something that has caused so much trouble *because* it's seldom been studied…— she confidently explained.

—And you expect me to guide your investigation?

—I don't expect anything from you. Not anymore— the girl lied. —It would be ideal, but you avoided me for so long, I can only think you hate me.

—I don't.

—Then why did you do that?

—Why do you care?

—Because I wanted to thank you! Fo-for the effort, and the help, and for not giving up on me!

—I wasn't the one who solved it. Your gratitude should be only for the Queen…

—I was told *you* realized she could help me!— the acolyte retorted. —And even if I shouldn't thank you, why would you avoid me like that!?

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes, trying to hide her shame, yet averted her sight as she muttered —Because I'm clearly a menace to you.

—Holy shit! The Head Sorceress *really* knows you well— the girl pointed out, surprised.

—What are you talking about?

—She told me you weren't saying why, but she supposed you were avoiding me precisely because of that!

—That little…

—Listen. I just- Would you help me if I promise *not* to mention the incident or try to thank you, or anything else?

—That is *not* the problem.

—Is it because I was so dismissive of what happened?

—Perhaps— the woman hissed, squinting. —You clearly have poor risk judgement.

—Alright— the girl sighed, rolling her eyes. —Then if I start being more… uh, wary around you, will you *please* help me!?

Instead of answering, Shadow Weaver approached until she towered over the acolyte, expression serious. Without hesitation, the girl cast a light-green shield between them but, instead of fear, there was a defiant look in her eyes.

The woman smirked and backed down, yet she didn't drop the shield, which made her raise a brow in surprise.

—Well… I suppose you passed— she finally let out.

—I… did?— the acolyte uttered, confused.

—Bring me a draft of the structure plan for this investigation tomorrow. I'll give you material, and *then* we'll talk again— she ordered, hands joined behind her back. —And, remember to keep it low, lest you upset the council…

—O-of course! I will— the girl replied, holding back from thanking her.

Right as the acolyte left, Shadow Weaver turned to leave too when an excited Head Sorceress found her.

—Spin! Quick! Come with me!— she exclaimed, grabbing her by the hand.

—What are you- Where are we going?

—The gardens!

—Why? And why are you so excited?

—Entrapta brought some machine here for a special mission Adora and Catra are about to carry out!

—Special mission?

—Yes! They only told me they needed the space because it would make the contraption more stable, but no one knows what it is!— she explained, pulling from the woman as she rushed through the building.

—Ah, must be their secret project…

—Their what!?— the sorceress exclaimed, halting abruptly. —Then you *know* what it is!

—I told you before…

—Never mind, let's go!

While her sudden dismissal of the matter greatly shocked Shadow Weaver, she still followed her to the gardens without saying anything else.

They arrived just before the machine was activated.

A small crowd had gathered around, but only Entrapta's crew, Adora and Catra were allowed near it. Everyone else stood at a safe distance determined by the Queen; the King, on the other hand, was nowhere to be seen, as he had stayed behind to take care of Glow and Finn while they handled the mission.

—Right on time— Micah's voice said, calling Castaspella's attention. —Do we know what they are doing?

—Nope.

—Yes…

—Tell us!— the siblings exclaimed in unison.

—I promised not to— Shadow Weaver excused herself.

—Of course you did— the Head Sorceress grunted.

—Why the mystery?

—Oh… you'll see— the woman smirked. —You will certainly like it.

—Are you sure you want to go in there with me?— Catra asked Adora, once more, just to be sure.

—Again, yes. If you're so eager to go right away, then I rather accompany you— her wife assured her, holding her hands. —Besides, if we *don't* find her for some reason, I… want to make sure you'll return.

Catra let out a soft smile, almost on the brink of tears.

—Fine— she accepted. —We're ready, Entrapta!

—Perfect! Since the activation of the portal, you'll have an hour to return. Only one— she explained, cheerful at first, but more serious when she clarified the time. —With the device I gave you, interdimensional communication should work! So once you give the order, we retrieve you!— she added, back to her cheerful tone. With a loud, almost maniac laugh, she concluded —This is going to be fun!

—Uh, sure, fun… Wait- What do you mean this thing *should* work!?— Catra asked, shaking the device they had been given.

—Don't worry, I'm sure it will— Adora assured her, taking the device from her. —And I'll carry this…

When they stepped into the portal machine, neither knew what to expect, but they certainly weren't expecting the pure whiteness that surrounded them.

—What… is this?

—I… recall everything was collapsing, but… After she removed the sword, it halted— Adora recalled. —There-there should be *something* here— she uttered, already feeling defeated.

—Wait. You said she disappeared after removing the sword, and that it alone was left… right?— Catra asked, suddenly struck by an idea. —You were in the broken reality! That's what you recall— she explained. —This must be where the Queen was sent *from* there! The-the space between dimensions!— she reflected.

—And how do we navigate this? We only have an hour…

—I'm not sure…

—I could ask Entrapta.

—No, no. Wait. Let me just… think.

—Alright— Adora sighed, trying to calm down. —So, space between dimensions…

—Entrapta has told us it's devoid of everything, right?

—Yeah?

—That means, devoid of time and space…

—I guess?

—Adora, that's it! We don't have to navigate this place, because this is *nowhere*— Catra realized. —It's- How to explain it… We know she's here because Entrapta located her magical firm using Glimmer's, right?

—Yeah?

—So she *must* be here… but, I mean, at the same time she isn't— her wife tried to explain.

—I don't follow.

—We need to focus on her, and we'll find her. She *is* here, but we're not seeing her because we're not on the same… uh… whatever Entrapta called it— Catra tried one last time.

—So we just… think about her?

—More like… we need to *feel*… It's like my powers. It's all emotional.

—But we already want to find her— Adora pointed out.

—Yeah, but… I suppose… We both need to allow ourselves to really feel it… The-the shame, the guilt, the regret— Catra enumerated. —Or whatever you feel, of course…

—I feel all of that too, Love— she assured her. —But I guess I also feel gratitude and affection…

—Then, just focus on that; we'll find her like that.

Nodding, they stood close to each other, Catra holding Adora's free hand, and then closed their eyes, taking a deep breath at the same time.

They felt dizzy for a second, held onto each other's hand tighter, and were forced to open their eyes to make sure they weren't actually moving.

—Ca-Catra— Adora called in a quiet tone, looking up.

—I… see her…

High above them, Angella was floating, all curled up, knees against her forehead, embracing her legs loosely, and wings closed.

They were wondering how she could be in such a state, without actually flying, when the angelic being raised her head.

—What?— she asked, her voice a whisper.

Angella had felt a disruption in the ever-static in-between she had been trapped in, and that made her react for the first time in… she didn't know how long.

After blinking a few times, she finally looked down, and opened her eyes wide in shock, feeling a shiver run across her body.

She had been… found!?

But how!?

And, were those Adora and… It couldn't be.

Angella could swear she recognized that face.

She looked different, but that was undoubtedly the Horde captain she recalled from the great battle in Bright Moon.

Hadn't she been told later that the girl was Hordak's second-in-command too?

But then again, she looked so different; so did Adora.

They looked… older.

And their clothes… No one would wear those in a war-ridden world.

Unless…

Could the war be over!?

How long had it been!?

Wouldn’t that mean Glimmer…

She must have become Queen!

And managed to end the war!?

As her thoughts overwhelmed her, little by little, Angella lowered to the ground. She noticed right in time to extend her legs and land on her feet.

In all her height, Catra felt… intimidated.

—Don’t be scared— Adora muttered in her ear.

Noticing their intimate treatment, Angella teared up, and finally said it aloud —So the war ended…

Exhorted by her wife, Catra took a step forward yet remained about a meter away from the angelic being, as she began —I… am sorry, your Majesty. I was the one… who activated the portal and broke reality.

She was!?

As more tears fell, Angella looked back at her and could only ask —Why?

—I wasn't thinking— she admitted. —I only… I knew it could destroy the world… and part of me wanted that. I didn't think… at all.

As Catra looked down, sorrowful, the angelic being realized she understood what the girl meant… yet she stopped herself from feeling any sympathy.

With her fists closed, she inquired —Then why are you here *now*?

Adora recognized the tone… She didn’t trust Catra, as expected.

But the girl didn’t back down.

She shook her head and looked up at her to explain —I never intended to do this to you! And I know- A-as soon as I knew how reality was fixed… I tried to ignore it, to pretend it wasn't my fault. But then, the rest of the Horde came, and Glimmer and I were trapped in space until Adora came for us… I couldn't fix what I had done, but at that moment I could make sure not to do the same to your daughter.

Catra blurted out the words without thinking about how much or how little sense they could make, how much or how little meaning they could have for Angella.

And they had… close to none.

Noticing her confusion, Adora placed a hand on her wife’s shoulder and decided to chime in.

—She sent Glimmer to us before we arrived at Horde Prime's ship, but we rescued her all the same. If we hadn't, we wouldn't have won the war— she remarked. —I assure you, your Majesty, she's honest.

—I never thought I'd have the chance to fix what I did to you, but we could, we found you— Catra expressed. —Please, your Majesty, forgive me. We can take you back to Etheria.

Angella's face darkened as she looked down at her joined hands.

The *rest* of the Horde?

Space?

A ship?

That could only mean one thing…

With a sorrowful tone, she expressed —I realize everything has changed too much while I was gone. The war ended, the stars must be back, and surely my girl is now the Queen. Why would you want to take me back? I am not needed anymore.

It made Catra shake her head immediately.

—No! That's not- E-everyone pretends I didn't- I-it's like I've done nothing wrong, but that isn't true— she desperately spoke. —Some things I can't fix, this was one of them. But now I can! And-and…— she went on, looking away with a serious expression, until she interrupted herself to take a deep breath. —We lost… our mother figure. An awful person, nowhere near as caring as I was told you were, yet we suffered so much seeing her die…— she admitted. —I know what Glimmer felt, and now I want to take you back to her; even if everyone else decided to go on.

More tears flooded Angella's eyes, and she promptly washed them away.

This was… not what she expected.

At all…

So what could she do now?

What would be the right choice?

After what felt like the result of her bad choices, could she possibly know what would be the right thing now?

Should she *trust*?

Adora trusts her…

But she doesn't know what could have happened between the last time she saw her and now… So, could she just rely on Adora's judgement?

And then there's everything she has missed…

If she returns, would they receive her with open arms? Or would she be a stranger in her own home?

But then again… This girl, her enemy… had come to rescue her…

She seemed to regret what she did, enough to be here now…

It appeared she expected distrust and wariness, but still came herself.

Adora could have come on her own, but this girl *wanted* to be right here and now, facing her and owning up to her actions.

Angella took a deep breath, eyes closed, hands joined in front of her mouth, and slowly sighed as she made up her mind.

Opening her eyes, she extended a hand towards Catra, who was still looking away. After a moment, she looked back and shyly took it, only to be pulled into a tight embrace.

—Thank you.

—Fo-for what!?— Catra stammered, stiff and shocked.

—Helping my daughter. Not giving up on me… and making the effort to change— Angella replied with a small smile.

It took her a second to finally process it, but once she did, Catra relaxed and hugged her back, sobbing.

—I'm so sorry…

After a moment, the angelic being finally released her, held her arms tightly while leaning down a bit to give her an understanding look.

It was quite an emotional sight.

—Let's go then— Adora suggested, approaching them with a smile.

Confused as she stood up straight again, Angella pointed out —How? I still don't understand how you found me.

Catra gave her wife a look, who chuckled and turned on the device she still carried with her.

—Entrapta, we found her! Take us back!

Fortunately, it worked.

An electronic voice soon replied —Alright! Hang on, your Majesty! Etheria is waiting for you!

When the three emerged from the portal machine, there was utter silence in the gardens. It took Angella a moment too long to recognize where she was and, as the machine turned off behind her, she looked back only to be surprised by the sight of none other than Hordak behind the controls.

Just how much had she missed!?

Once she looked at the front again, the first person she saw was Glimmer, whom she could hardly recognize.

—Welcome back, Mom— she let out, crying with joy.

Adora and Catra moved away to let her and Angella join in a tight embrace, and a loud cheer from the crowd immediately followed.

—This is really you?— her mother asked, tearing up again, and burying her face on Glimmer's shoulder.

—Yes, Mom, yes!— she sobbed, smiling brightly.

—You're Queen now…

—And you're Queen Mother— Glimmer giggled. —I missed you so much!

A few steps away, the King Father was tightly gripping his sister's arm while staring at Angella, eyes red as he held back tears. In turn, Castaspella seemed in utter shock seeing her again, but there was something *more* behind that look…

Rolling her eyes, unable to stand it anymore, Shadow Weaver addressed Micah, and "encouraged" him —Go.

—Ye-yes— he stammered, struggling to move. Castaspella snapped out of her shock just in time to help him and actually encouraged him to approach Angella. —But, do-don't I look too old?

—And?— they both asked at the same time.

—Fine— he accepted, gulping nervously. After taking a deep breath, he finally took a step forward, and another, tentatively moving closer to his family. Once Angella looked up from her daughter's shoulder, her eyes opened wide, and he let out —A-Angie?

Glimmer felt her mother's embrace loosen after hearing him, and decided to let go of her, smiling softly. She only gestured at her to approach him and nodded, like confirming it's truly him.

—Micah? But I thought…

—I know— he interrupted, finally letting his tears fall. —I tried to tell you… But then…

—In that fake reality— she realized.

—Yes— he sobbed. —I tried…

She gently shushed him, rushed to pick him up, and they hugged tightly as she said —It doesn't matter now. You're back. I'm back…

—I missed you, Angie— he cried.

—As much as I missed you, my Love— she replied, now looking at him with a sad smile.

Chuckling slightly while tears wet their faces, they finally shared a long kiss.

Meanwhile, Adora and Catra joined Castaspella and Shadow Weaver a few meters away from the happy reunion.

—Well, everything went according to the plan— Adora happily announced. —Thank you very much for lending us the space, Head Sorceress.

—Yeah, and… thanks for the information, Shadow Weaver— Catra added. —I don't know how you knew, but… Yeah, just thanks.

—You're welcome— the woman said, before noticing how it sounded. —That… wasn't on purpose.

They both chuckled and shook their heads, amused.

—Ah… — Adora sighed. —Your brother looks so happy— she then told Castaspella, but interrupted herself when she looked back at her. —Are you alright, Head Sorceress?

Neither had noticed, but she definitely didn't look fine at all.

What Shadow Weaver had taken as that anguish that stemmed from seeing again someone she thought was gone, as a tightness in her chest produced by overwhelming joy, was actually a mix of grief, guilt, and shame.

Yet she couldn't understand it at all.

—Cas, what is it?

Catra gave her a gentle look and carefully placed a hand on her arm as she encouraged her — This is the opportunity you wanted. I know you must be panicking but…

—Hey, Casta!— Micah suddenly called, waving at her. —We're showing Angie everything that has changed! Want to tag along?

—I- So-sorry, I have to… go— she uttered, shaking her head before running away, back into the building.

—What!?— Shadow Weaver let out, shocked.

Albeit confused by her reaction, Micah, Glimmer, and Angella decided to drop the matter for the moment, and began their little tour around the new, war-free Etheria.

But Adora and Catra were too worried to simply "drop it", as they knew something the others didn't.

—Oh no…— Catra sighed, looking down.

—What on Etheria is going on!?— Shadow Weaver insisted, looking in the direction the sorceress left, as if she could still hear her, and then back at Catra.

—I don't think it's my place to explain…— she denied, starting to leave.

Adora was about to follow her wife when Shadow Weaver, with that scary and threatening tone the girls knew well, bellowed —Catra!

The girl tensed up, frozen in place, and her hair stood on end, feeling triggered by the woman again, for the first time in years.

However, when she dared look back, in her unmasked face there was *utter fear*. No rage, no frown…

—A-alright, calm down— Catra stammered, raising her hands.

Seeing the gesture, Shadow Weaver realized what she had done and apologized —That- I didn't mean to…

—I know. I can see it— she assured her. —You're scared.

—I just need someone to explain to me *what* just happened.

—And I understand that, but without Castaspella's permission, I can't simply disclose private information she entrusted me with.

—Then get her permission, if it's so necessary, but tell me— she pleaded. —I don't understand what she's feeling, I cannot help her— Shadow Weaver insisted, increasingly sorrowful.

—Give us a moment, we'll find her and then return here— Adora offered.

—Fine…— she complied, resigned.

A while passed, the people that had gathered at the gardens promptly left, and Entrapta quickly dismantled the machine with help from the Horde Trio and Wrong Hordak. Meanwhile, she had sent Hordak to upload all the data gathered into their computers back at the laboratory.

And so, by the time Adora and Catra returned, there was close to no one in the gardens.

—We're back.

—And?

—She wasn't sure at first, but… she said I can tell you— Catra nodded. —Why don't we sit?

—As you wish— the woman uttered, rolling her eyes and following them to a bench.

—Listen. What I'm going to tell you is a delicate matter for her. So don't get angry at her for never telling you— she began. —Remember that time, years ago, when she woke up crying? That she said she'd explain later but never did?

—Funny enough, I do. She was about to tell me when someone knocked on the door… She *said* she'd explain later but, as you said, she never did— Shadow Weaver recalled.

—Yeah… she mentioned that— Catra nodded. —The thing is, we were talking about how, many times, I can't really tell Adora why I'm feeling like the Head Sorceress is feeling now, yet she can comfort me regardless. She mentioned that you had done the same for her on that occasion, despite her never telling you what it was about.

—And how is that related to what's going on now?

—Because something I said made her think she could tell me what she *hadn't* told you. And it *is* related to Angella— she explained. As the woman remained silent, she went on —I don't know if something happened that day or what but, apparently, she had a realization before going to sleep. It was about how she had… called Angella a coward after her brother was captured and presumed dead.

—She did?— Adora asked, thinking back to the Queen Mother's last words before pulling out the sword.

—Yeah. If you're thinking about what happened with the portal… It *is* related to that— her wife replied as if reading her mind. —Castaspella recalled what you told everyone, about Angella telling you she was a coward— she told Adora.

—You can't mean she blames herself…

—Wait— Catra interrupted Shadow Weaver. —It's more complicated than that. She didn't just insult Angella, she also blamed her for everything that went wrong afterwards, even in Mystacor. Apparently, that's why their relationship was so strained as Sparkles mentioned— she explained, thinking aloud that last part. —The thing is, even after she stopped that, realizing it was unfair, she never apologized. And that day, it appears that she also remembered what others said about the portal reality. She even knew about how nice you

were to me— Catra laughed lightly. —But, for her, nothing had changed at all. Which made her realize, only then, that she was unfair in every sense, since she had blamed her for things that were totally unrelated to the King Father being here or not— she finally sighed.

—And she woke up crying because of that?

—She went to sleep thinking about that, about how Angella said the same she had told her, and it replayed in her dreams, making her feel guilty. That's what she's feeling now.

—It's ridiculous. How would it be her fault in *any* way?

Catra shook her head and sighed —This is why she didn't want to tell you. She knew you'd say something like that…

—What did *you* say?

—I told her it wasn't necessarily her fault, but also thanked her for acknowledging that her words could have affected Angella… Just like *your* words affected me— she replied, serious. —I'm not asking for *another* apology from you. The point here is that… well, the Head Sorceress mentioned regretting never apologizing, yet now that she can, she's panicking.

—I see…— the woman sighed, looking down. —I don't think I can help her then…

—I partially believe the same, but… you can try— Catra told her. —You still *suck* at apologizing, but if anyone has at least attempted such difficult conversations at all… that's you.

—I think that, more than help her, you can share your experience learning to apologize to us — Adora commented.

—She was the one who taught me. What can I possibly tell her that she doesn't know?

Catra let out an amused scoff and pointed out —As someone who handed out apologies left, right, and centre for the first couple of years after the war, I can assure you there's a lot she doesn't know.

—She may have apologized before, but this is something she doesn't feel capable of doing so, it's not the same— her wife added. She then nodded at Shadow Weaver as she insisted — Telling her your experience can give her some perspective, so she takes the first step and *tries*.

—Then, of course, seeing it to the end is another thing. No matter what you tell her, nothing can prepare her for the feelings she'll experience that will… make her want to flee— Catra added. —You can give her an idea, but the real thing is…

—You're never ready for how it will feel— the woman completed. Standing up, she decided —I see. Then, I'll try to speak to her.

—Good— Adora sighed.

—In the meantime, if someone asks what happened with Cas…

—We'll tell them she just needs some time— Catra nodded.

—Much appreciated— Shadow Weaver replied, bowing slightly in gratitude.

Right after, she left the gardens, and the girls took a moment to enjoy the feeling of relief, the happiness…

Years ago, *many* years ago, they wouldn't even entertain the idea of having such a conversation with that woman.

Being asked for counsel, being heard by her, and thanked…

Never in their wildest dreams.

Chapter End Notes

I was in tears writing this, you have no idea… I actually rewatched The Portal to write Angella's rescue and I was SOBBING
ALSO, for a visual of how Angella was when they found her, I made a drawing long ago… You can see it here. It's not my best work, but it's something… <(“^_^)

Ah, ah, and before I forget!! About the acolyte… Rereading to edit this beast (and the previous chapter), I realized the acolyte is SO MUCH like Casta! Like, her way of talking to SW and all… gee... It wasn't on purpose, I dunno what happened there <("^_^)

Of Forgiveness And Resentment

Chapter Summary

After everything that happened, a new challenge now awaits the Head Sorceress: apologizing to Queen Mother Angella.
However, she'll need quite a lot of encouragement before she's ready to face her…
» —Hey, Pretty Boy. (…) I reckon you still care about her…
» —Why wouldn't I?
» —Well, if that's the case, then let me tell you something before you go to see her. (…) I still have a hard time understanding friendship and all, but I have observed that the more support from *friends* someone has, the more likely they are to carry out whatever they want to do. No matter how scared they might be.
» —Ah, yes. That would be correct. Then it will be my pleasure to help with this. I don't know the Queen Mother yet, but…
» —Better that way. You won't be a neutral party, but rather someone *on her side*.
» —On her side… Oh, of course. So she knows we're saying it for her own good, not just because it's the right thing to do, or because we're siding with the Queen Mother. (…) In that case, by all means. Just tell me where she is and I'll handle it.

But there will be one last issue for Castaspella to sort… and things will get *ugly*.

Chapter Notes

This chapter is insanely long…

Also:
There are a few headcanons of mine regarding ages later in this chapter
You may agree or disagree but, in any case, the final notes are a bit about that, alright? Check them before commenting, pwease.

Oh, one last thing I rather explain here: You'll see Casta mention that Ari has grown a mane, and like, yes, that's because Ari is lion-like, so to speak. When I decided to name them "Ari", it was just the name that popped up in my head. I hadn't planned how they would look or anything... And I absolutely had no idea this is what Google says about the name!

> Ari is a popular gender-neutral name with roots from across the globe. Its Scandinavian origins suggest Ari means "eagle," while its Hebrew origin means "lion." In the Badaga language, Ari means "sun-like." This beautiful title is attractive for its humble melodiousness.

So, like, Ari IS a gender-neutral name and I didn't know, but I'm glad. And, tbh, you could say Ari is a bit of a combo of all the things mentioned up there. They're lion-like, they have sun affinity (I don't recall if I had mentioned it before), and while I could come up with something to relate them to eagles, I rather leave that out. Oops!

Now yes, welcome to this mega-long chapter!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After her conversation with Catra and Adora, Shadow Weaver went straight to find Castaspella.

As she couldn't go through the door to their room, she guessed the sorceress had to be in the bathroom, which was closer than the bed. They both happened to open the doors at the same time.

—Bea!— Castaspella yelped, as soon as she noticed who was walking into the room.

The woman immediately closed the door behind her and approached, smirking.

—Should I help you with the towel?

—Maybe?— the sorceress replied, looking away with a faint blush. —Did they tell you?

—Everything— Shadow Weaver replied, wrapping her arms around Castaspella's naked body and pulling her closer. —Can we talk about that for a moment?

—Right now? Can't it be in a bit?

—Is there something you have to do first?

—I was hoping you'd… help me relax— she smiled.

—I see…— the woman sighed with a faint chuckle. —Alright then. Tell me what you want…

About an hour later, Castaspella was tired enough to *want* to sleep, yet not sleepy enough to actually fall asleep.

So perhaps it was a good time to have that conversation.

—So… What do you want to say about, erm… my issue with… you know…

—I won't reproach you for not telling me. I understand why you didn't— Shadow Weaver began. —But I must ask: what are you so afraid of?

—Well… I fear she won't… you know, forgive me. But I don't- Ugh, I think I don't care about her forgiveness as much as I care about how getting it or not will affect my relationship with Micah and Glimmer— she admitted.

—What makes you think Angella's response to your apology will somehow influence your personal relationships with your brother and niece?

—Well, I can't know what Micah will think, as he never knew what happened after he was taken prisoner and all… Perhaps he'll be offended knowing everything I told Angella, all the accusations I made… And, of course, Glimmer may side with her mother like she did before. A-and with all due reason, of course. I… get it.

—Get it? You don't *like it*. Don't force yourself to "get it" or accept it.

—But I can't force them to stay out of our conflict, either— Castaspella argued.

—You don't *have to* force them to stay out of it. They *will* stay out of it if they truly value their relationships with both you and her.

—But…

—Cas… Think for a moment that they *will* stay out of the matter. What else scares you? What is stopping you from finding her now to apologize?

—I suppose… I-I don't know. Perhaps just rejection? Or that I-I loathe the awkwardness I'll sure experiment from merely approaching her.

—Have you forgotten what happened with Hordak?

—What exactly?

—When you hadn't knit him a sweater?

—Oh, my… I- No, this is… different.

—How is this different?

—I-I don't know. I felt… less exposed… in that case.

—Less exposed? That was in the middle of a huge gathering, with all close people who know you personally… And it was evident to everyone that you had *not* thought about him at all…

—Please, stop— she begged, covering her face.

—Just tell me why you feel it'd be worse to face Angella— Shadow Weaver insisted.

—I don't know! She just…

—She what?

—Scares me!

That took the woman by surprise.

She pushed herself up and looked down at Castaspella for a long moment. Then, she cupped her face and lowered herself slowly.

—I've seen you face your fears before… And that includes *me*— she muttered. —Won't you do it one more time?

—I can't…— the sorceress denied, her voice shaky with imminent tears.

—Trust me, you can— Shadow Weaver insisted, before kissing her slightly. —If I could, you can too.

Castaspella looked up at her, tearing up, and sobbed —I can't ruin everything now…

—And you won't— the woman assured her.

Once again, they kissed, deeper this time, and Shadow Weaver helped her sit up. After a moment, when the sorceress finally broke the kiss as she needed air, she gave her a look that said enough.

—I'll try. But… not yet.

—Enough for me— the woman sighed. —You'll probably want to get changed now…

—I should— she admitted, smiling faintly. —I'd rather stay hidden here the rest of the day but…

—You need to have lunch. I'm not allowing otherwise.

—Alright, alright. I'll get some food as soon as I'm decent— she accepted.

The Head Sorceress did as promised.

Then, while she returned from lunch, decided to hide in her room and knit for a while, she came across a *very* nervous Bow carrying not-so-little-anymore Glow between his arms and followed by Finn.

—Ah! Casta! So-sorry— he stammered.

—Oh, my! Are you alright?

—Hi, Auntie!— Finn interrupted, and she smiled at them.

—Yes, yes! I was just- Can I ask you to look after Glow and Finn for a while? I- Well, I have to handle a few things at the palace before the Queen- That is, the Queen Mother arrives…

—Oh, of course— she gladly accepted, taking the girl from his arms. —Are you sure everything is fine?

—Of course! Again, I just need to prepare some stuff at the castle, and… I needed someone to take care of them in the meantime— he insisted.

—Alright, don't worry. I'll keep an eye on them for as long as you require.

—Thank you *very* much— the King sighed.

Oblivious to Bow's blatant lie, Castaspella happily took the kids with her to an empty chamber where she'd usually go to knit, and once again attempted to teach Glow how to crochet.

From the couch where she had sat, the Head Sorceress warned Finn —Careful sitting there. It's dangerous.

—I like sitting on windows— they argued.

—Well, but we wouldn't want you falling, would we?

—I'll be fine, Auntie!

—Alright— she laughed. She took a moment to try guiding Glow through crocheting a single stitch, yet failed again. It was amusing, however, and Finn had begun exactly like that, so she just chuckled and addressed the older kid again. —And what are you knitting this time?

—A pair of socks for Mamma.

—Oh, really? I'm sure Catra will love them— she cheerfully replied.

—Yeah!

She felt relaxed and happy…

The kids both seemed to be enjoying being with her…

But she had an odd feeling that quickly made sense as someone opened the door to the chamber.

—I'm sorry, I was looking for… Ah, Castaspella— Angella said, at first distracted enough that it took her a moment to actually see who she was talking to. The angelic being inevitably looked around, noticed the kid on the window waving at her, and hesitantly waved back at them. Then, she finally saw the familiar-looking girl on the sorceress' lap. —What- Who is that?

—I'm sorry?

—The child.

—What with the kid?

—Who is that!?

—Wait, you don't… know?— Castaspella asked, disgruntled.

—Why should I?

She thought about how they both have the same eyes, similar skin-tone, and of course, the fact that Glow looks so much like Glimmer with Bow's hair… and couldn't believe Angella hadn't made the connection.

After staring silently for a moment, the Head Sorceress finally asked —Are you *looking* at her?

—Yes, I am! That's why I'm asking! Can you please answer me!?

Such levels of anxiety were uncommon in her, and it didn't help at all with Castaspella's hesitation to apologize.

If she was reacting like this *now* and about *this*…

—I think you need to talk with Glimmer— she hesitantly said.

—Why can't you answer me!?

—Because it's not *my* place to do so, Angella— the sorceress calmly replied, perfectly hiding her own anxiety. —There must be a reason why Glimmer hasn't told you yet…

—Ugh— she groaned, massaging her temples. —You know what? Alright, I'll get my daughter… I don't even know why I came here…

Castaspella had to close her eyes and take a deep breath to avoid uttering anything remotely offensive, and decided to focus on Glow once more, ignoring the voices discussing outside.

Meanwhile, Angella was leaving without closing the door, when she almost walked into someone. Quite literally.

—Your Majesty…

—What on Etheria are you doing here!? A-are you… a *summoned being*!?

—Perhaps…

—Hey! Ghost Lady!— Finn's voice exclaimed from inside, apparently having heard her.

—Excuse me, that would be me— Shadow Weaver said, dismissing Angella's confused expression and intending to walk around her to go into the room.

—Hold on. What- Why is a kid calling for you… a-and calling you *that*!?

—There is a lot you still don't know, your Majesty. I suggest you speak with your daughter…

—You too!? Why won't anyone tell me what's going on!? Who are those kids, and what has happened that you're… *like that* a-and roaming free!?

—From all of that, I can only answer the last part of your question— the woman casually replied. —In short, I died. However, I was summoned for… *reasons*. Long story short, I helped with the mission to bring you back, so, you're welcome— she smirked, aiming to continue on her way.

But the Queen Mother was too suspicious of her, even more now, and hissed —What have you done?

—Too many things. Care to be more specific?— she asked back, without turning to look at her.

—Who summoned you? Why? How did you "help" with my return? And how did you manage to be set *free* as if you had done *nothing*!?

—Those are a lot of questions that would require far more time to answer than hours in a day — Shadow Weaver condescendingly replied.

—I cannot believe it's become so difficult to get answers!— Angella complained.

Having obviously heard that last part, and before she could say another word, Castaspella finally gathered the courage to go save Shadow Weaver from the never-ending awkward "conversation".

—There you are, come on, now— the sorceress blurted out, grabbing Shadow Weaver by the arm and pulling her inside.

—What- Why are you two…— Angella was asking, until the door shut close. —Rude.

Yes, it had been rude.

But not as rude as Castaspella could have been if she didn't have so much self-control…

The Queen Mother finally left for Bright Moon, angrily taking off and flying out of the building in the blink of an eye.

—I can't do it. Nope. Forget it— Castaspella stated, pacing in front of the door.

Finn and Shadow Weaver were now sitting on the couch where she had left her knitting, with Glow slowly falling asleep between them.

—Aren't you being a bit fatalist?

—No, no. I swear, you- I can't explain just how bad it was before you arrived— the sorceress insisted.

—And yet you went for me— Shadow Weaver pointed out.

—Why is Auntie so nervous, Ghost Lady?— Finn asked, confused, watching her walk back and forth.

—She's scared— the woman replied.

—That's a euphemism— Castaspella scoffed.

—Scared of what?

—*Don't* answer that.

—Alright— Shadow Weaver conceded, raising her hands.

—Listen, I'm just… a bit nervous.

—Because of the tall bird lady?

—That's… a way to call her. Yes, because of her— the sorceress answered Finn. —But it's nothing you should worry about.

—Cas, listen. You have nothing more and nothing less to say than "I'm sorry for what I said to you". You can be more specific if you want, but that's all you have to do for now— Shadow Weaver assured her. —You needn't explain anything else to her. You don't even have to tell her about us if so you prefer.

—I'll go insane…

—If you keep ignoring me, yes, you will.

—Mo-Mom! You are back already— Glimmer stammered, confronted by a very annoyed Queen Mother. —How was the flight around Etheria?

—Lovely. Everything is *lovely*. Except for the fact that I seem unable to get straight answers from anyone— she replied, sardonic.

Glimmer wasn't sure she had ever heard Angella talk to her like that.

In fact…

This was how she'd sometimes argue with Castaspella.

—A-answers about…

—That little girl who looks so much like me? Or Shadow Weaver being a summoned entity walking around free and seemingly close to Castaspella? I even saw her *grab her arm*! How can it be!? Summoned beings can't physically interact with reality!

—Oh, Mom…— the Queen sighed. —Please, calm down… Let me just get Bow and we'll explain everything, yes?

—Can't you just explain these things to me?— Angella insisted, calmer but noticeably exhausted from getting no answers. She then knelt in front of Glimmer, gently held her arms, and insisted —Won't you, please, clarify everything to me? I have missed so much…

—I know, Mom. You have. But, ah…— she sighed. With a gentle smile, she pleaded —I just want to do it with my husband by my side. Is that alright?

Right. Her *husband*.

Angella lowered her head, closed her eyes, and slowly let go of her daughter.

Just like Micah before her, she had to get used to the fact that Glimmer was no longer the young girl she last saw.

—Of course— she finally accepted.

—Wait- You mean she already *saw Glow*!?

—Apparently!

—How!?

—Must have been at Mystacor! She-she also mentioned Aunt Casta and Shadow Weaver being close! And how she's a summoned being but Auntie could grab her!

—Great. It backfired— Bow lamented. —I never thought she'd go see your aunt before coming here…

—I don't think she was looking for Auntie…

—Why?

—It doesn't seem like either of them wants to see the other at all— Glimmer pointed out. —I remember they had some… differences. But this looks far worse than I remember.

—Then we better go talk to your mother before she goes insane— Bow sighed.

The couple returned to where Glimmer had left Angella, and found her with Micah, seemingly calmer.

—I know it's kind of difficult to process so much in one go, Angie, but it becomes easier when you just accept the world doesn't stop with us— he assured her.

—But these things make no sense…— she replied, looking down at him with a confused frown. —And why is it so difficult for me to get answers? Is there something I shouldn't

know?

—Of course not, my Love. I'm sure it's just a question of… *not* overwhelming you with information you don't need yet— he tentatively replied.

—Hey, Mom— Glimmer decided to interrupt. —I'm sorry I didn't say it before, and I'm sorry if it annoyed you that Auntie didn't want to tell you, but we… wanted to tell you ourselves— she said, glancing briefly at Bow. Angella looked back at Micah for a moment, only to see him smiling sparklingly at her. It made more sense when Glimmer finally explained —You're a grandma!

—I'm sorry, *what*!?

—Her name is Glow, she turned four a few months ago— Bow explained.

—And she looks so much like you…— Micah added.

—We just didn't have a chance to present her to you earlier— the King apologetically said, disguising his nervousness for lying to her.

—We-we wanted to surprise you!— Glimmer lied too, her expression more cheerful, trying to lighten the mood.

—Oh, it was *certainly* a surprise, yes— Angella remarked.

—Don't be too hard on them, Angie— Micah told her, grabbing her hands. —We're all so… *so* glad to have you back! We don't even know where to begin! What to show you first! And our little granddaughter is such a cute little baby- Well, girl, she's grown a lot already… I assure you no one was trying to hide her from you.

The truth was that, in fact, they *were* hiding her; as they had no idea *how* to tell her about Glow, they were doing everything to delay it… Incidentally, it had only dragged Castaspella into the issue.

—Of course, I know— she nodded, closing her eyes as she tried to calm down. —Well, but… can we just sit down and talk about all these things I can't understand? I *need* answers. I feel too out of place— she admitted.

—Then come here, Angie— Micah invited, taking her to Bright Moon's gardens, followed by Glimmer and Bow. —Why don't we all sit here, take a moment, and calmly discuss this? I know it's difficult. I went through it in the middle of an invasion— he chuckled.

—Invasion… The rest of the Horde?— she asked, sitting down.

—Yes— her daughter nodded.

—That girl… Catra. She mentioned rescuing you…

—She did. She wanted to keep Adora from being captured. But, we couldn't abandon her either. And if we hadn't rescued her, I don't think we would have won the war. Adora says

she saved her— Glimmer explained.

—I see… But then, this other thing they mentioned, having lost their mother figure… whom, I reckon, would be Shadow Weaver, who *also* mentioned having died…— Angella hesitantly recalled.

The Queen and King exchanged a glance, and he explained —Yes. Shadow Weaver died getting rid of some… monster. That allowed Adora and Catra to reach the Heart of Etheria, deploy the failsafe, and save us all.

—How?

—The First Ones did something to the core of Etheria, made it siphon our magic, and… only She-Ra could take and deploy the failsafe that a rebel faction of the First Ones left behind— Glimmer clarified.

—It's a long story, but the important thing is that we managed to free the magic and defeat this… intergalactic conqueror called Horde Prime— Bow concluded.

—That sounds… like a lot— Angella managed to reply, having no words to express what she was thinking and feeling.

—Are you alright, Angie?— Micah asked, concerned.

—I am— she gently smiled. Giving his hand a slight squeeze, she assured him —How wouldn't I be, being reunited with you all? Learning you managed to free the world I had been struggling to protect for so long…

Her husband couldn't help smiling too and kissed her hand before asking —Anything else you want to know?

—Let me think… There was a kid, there with your sister, besides, uh… Glow— she recalled. —Who's that?

—That's Finn— Glimmer replied. —Catra and Adora's kid.

—Oh— Angella let out, surprised. —I wasn't expecting that— she admitted. —Especially since they seemed so… *fond* of Shadow Weaver, to put it in some way.

—If that surprises you…— Micah chuckled.

—Is there something that should surprise me even more?

—There definitely is— Glimmer giggled. —Remember your question about Auntie grabbing Shadow Weaver despite her being a summoned entity?

—Yes… *That*— the King Father uttered, eyes wide open as he considered how to explain it all.

—Right. I have a lot of questions about that— Angella admitted.

—I think I'll handle that— Micah decided.

—Are you sure, Dad?

—Of course, Baby Girl. Don't worry— he nodded. He let out a faint laugh, finding it a bit ironic that *he* would explain that, and turned to look at his wife with a mix of shame and awkwardness. —You see… After the war ended, I was told a few things about Casta's interactions with Shadow Weaver since I was… uh, chipped, and how they made a deal since they *both* wanted to save me— he began. —Oh, right. We didn't explain the thing about the chipping. In short, Horde Prime had some of us mind-controlled.

—A-alright?

—And, well… apparently, they had become friendly since investigating together a way to free us or defeat Prime? Different people mentioned they seemed playful, bickered a lot but not with hatred like before, just… light-heartedly. A-as a banter that had some underlying respect, if you will— Micah went on.

—Yeah. Actually, Casta managed to make Shadow Weaver admit that the Spell of Obtainment was a mistake— Bow recalled. —And when Catra interrogated Shadow Weaver about the failsafe, she didn't want to answer until Casta ordered her to do so— he added.

—Yeah… So, I then learnt that she wanted to invite Shadow Weaver to return to Mystacor, to help or something. Except that Casta wasn't expecting her to… die— he hesitantly continued. The difficult part would come now… —So, for a few months, I saw Casta sink into a very-well-dissimulated depression, and I thought… that Shadow Weaver had charmed her— he admitted.

—And?

Ashamed, he looked back at Glimmer, who gave him an encouraging look.

—And so I offered Casta to summon her— he continued. —I lied to her and said it was to give her the opportunity of having some closure, but in truth I wanted Shadow Weaver to undo whatever she had done to her… And I was *so* wrong.

—Alright, that explains why she was summoned and who did it. But, about what I saw… From what I know, only within a summoning spell area can an entity in her condition interact physically with reality. So how could your sister grab her being *outside* the summoning area?

—That's because, well… you know that old Guild Dance?— he asked back. When his wife nodded with a confused expression, he explained —It seems to have some magical properties none of us knew about and… for some reason I can't, for the life of my, understand, Casta and Shadow Weaver danced it… a-and the spell got bound to…

—To her heart!— Angella interrupted, gasping in surprise. —I had read about such things but… I didn't think it was real.

—Well, none of us had any idea that was even *possible*. And, from then on, everything went… downhill for *me*.

—Why?

—Long story short… Casta, um… fell in love, and I didn't like it. I broke the anchor we used to summon Shadow Weaver, her mask, without even thinking about it. That was even before a year went by since the summoning— he began. —I had a *lot* of problems with the council because of that, as well as with Adora and Catra, but I was convinced I had the right to do that. That it was… reasonable? A-and yet…

Noticing his hesitation, Angella encouraged him to go on, asking —Yes?

—Time proved me wrong— he completed. —They eventually found some… magical groove where Shadow Weaver could appear thanks to the summoning spell still being active within Casta, and for *a whole decade*, those two continued… uh… seeing each other? I don't know how to put it— he admitted. —But, if Casta wasn't really in love before, after all that time she sure is. And, surprisingly enough, so is Shadow Weaver.

—Let me guess: they are together now— Angella reckoned.

—Yes— he sighed.

—I knew it— she scoffed, amused. —Since that first interrogation, I *knew* there was something there…

—The first- I…

—*What*!?

All three of them gave the Queen Mother a questioning look while simultaneously exclaiming in shock.

—You see: when I asked her to help with the interrogation, I expected her to want revenge or to punish her for what she did to you before her corruption and all… but instead, she said she wanted her to *answer* for her crimes. Not to *pay*— Angella began. —I thought she was being lenient, perhaps naïve, but when we realized the woman was dying, Castaspella halted the interrogation and asked me to speak outside, only to suggest we granted her demands because we couldn't wait for the Alliance to make a decision!

—I think I remember hearing part of that— Bow admitted. —She sounded… concerned about her not having much time.

—Yes, when you came to distract us— she replied, raising a brow in reproach, and making him awkwardly scratch the back of his neck. —The thing is, I dismissed it as her being soft or something, but then I recalled how she used to admire Light Spinner, and all the exaggerated stories the council had to tell her; the things *you* had to tell her to finally make her hate the woman instead— she went on, addressing Micah again. —So, no. I'm definitely

not surprised about this outcome— she laughed. —Or of your reaction, of course— she added, giggling before kissing his cheek.

—It would have been *so different* if you were here back then— Glimmer groaned.

The four spent long hours catching Angella up with the *many* changes she had missed, until they finally remembered they had to pick up Glow and have dinner…

But what attracted Angella the most was the interesting "interplanetary relationships" set of rules and regulations that Glimmer had had to design with the help of their first outworld ambassador.

Fortunately, Delwyn returned to Etheria the next day, so the Queen Mother's curiosity would soon be satisfied…

But not before he visited Castaspella first and foremost, as he had promised his children…

He was walking down the halls in Mystacor, wondering where he could find her or who he could ask about her whereabouts, when he came across Shadow Weaver. Or rather, walked past her without noticing until she addressed him.

—Hey, Pretty Boy— she mockingly called out.

—Oh! Shadow Weaver! Good to see you— he replied, halting immediately and approaching her. —I was *just* looking for Casta. You don't happen to know where she is, do you?— he asked, knowing perfectly well she did.

The woman smirked and tilted her head forward to say —I reckon you still care about her…

—Why wouldn't I?

—Well, if that's the case, then let me tell you something before you go to see her— she requested.

—Sure. Did something happen?

—In short, yes. The Queen's mother has been brought back— she stated.

—She- That would be Angella, right?

—Exactly— Shadow Weaver nodded. —And while quite a joyous occasion for everyone, it has instead put Cas in a bit of a predicament.

—Ho-how so?

—You do know her brother was presumed dead before being found and brought back from Beast Island, don't you?— she began. As he nodded, she explained —Well, while thought dead, Cas and Angella may have had some disagreements of… *significant* proportions. And she may have said a few things that she regretted after learning of the former Queen's sacrifice.

—How bad?

—Enough that she had a panic attack seeing her back.

—That's *really* bad.

—While it seems like she wants to apologize, it also scares her so much she intends to avoid her as long as she can— Shadow Weaver further explained. —You don't need me to tell you why that's less than ideal…

—No, of course. I understand— he nodded. —I reckon you've spoken to her about this?

—Yes, and she understands and wants to try but, like I said, she's scared and feels incapable.

—You want me to convince her?

—I still have a hard time understanding friendship and all, but I have observed that the more support from *friends* someone has, the more likely they are to carry out whatever they want to do. No matter how scared they might be— she told him.

—Ah, yes. That would be correct— he agreed, smiling politely. —Then it will be my pleasure to help with this. I don't know the Queen Mother yet, but…

—Better that way. You won't be a neutral party, but rather someone *on her side*— she pointed out.

—On her side… Oh, of course. So she knows we're saying it for her own good, not just because it's the right thing to do, or because we're siding with the Queen Mother.

—Precisely— Shadow Weaver nodded.

—In that case, by all means. Just tell me where she is and I'll handle it— he accepted.

Just a few minutes later, the ambassador found Castaspella in the kitchen, having her lunch.

—Oh, Delwyn!— she exclaimed, happy to see him again. She immediately put down her chopsticks and rushed to hug him. —I wasn't expecting you yet…

—I know, I forgot to send notice of my return— he admitted. —Can I join you? I wouldn't want to interrupt your meal.

—Oh, sure. Would you like a serving?

—That would be appreciated, yes.

—Good, because I made plenty of noodle soup— she happily replied, going for a bowl to serve him some. —Here, I hope you like it.

—Thank you— he answered, accepting the bowl and chopsticks. —If you don't mind… what has happened since I left? I heard a few things already…

—Well… let me think— Castaspella sighed. —Oh! Right! You won't recognize Ari when you see them! Their mane suddenly grew a few months ago!— she told him, excited.

—I didn't know they- What species is Ari?

—No idea, to be completely honest. I always knew they weren't the same as Catra, even if they have features in common, but apparently they're not far— she giggled.

—I see— he nodded. —Anything else?

—Well, I'm a bit lost with the dates so I can't recall exactly when you left— she admitted. —But, let's see. Two significant events here in Mystacor would be, first, that we found out something very dangerous Spin can do, and second… that Glimmer's mother was brought back— she decided to say.

—What is that something about Shadow Weaver?— he curiously asked, genuinely curious but also intending to delay the matter about Angella.

—Well, I left for a few days, Spin was here alone, and apparently had a fit of rage. An acolyte wanted to stop her, calm her down, but she may have forgotten she's literally like a ghost, unable to interact physically with reality when I'm not around. So her arm went right through Spin, while she was using her illusions to scare the guy that angered her, and… well, the girl's arm got corrupted— she quickly explained, while he ate.

—That doesn't sound good…

—It's terrible. I really thought she'd be banished. But, fortunately, she handled it well enough to have the acolyte's support, and the council decided to just… forbid her from using her illusions without me around, just in case.

—Oh… that's good. But what happened with the girl?

—The other resolution was to help her get rid of the corruption, which Spin had already vowed to do, and you have *no idea* how much effort she put into that— she explained, smiling proudly. —It took her months, but she finally found the solution after learning that Glimmer had purged all traces of black magic from Micah back when the war was about to end!

—So the acolyte is alright now?

—She's perfectly well. *And*, what's more, she graduated shortly after, and asked Spin to guide her investigation!

—I would have never thought she'd end up doing that— Delwyn admitted, laughing slightly. —That must have been quite a ride…

—You have no idea— she agreed.

—And, about the former Queen's return…

—Well, believe it or not, it seems like Glimmer, Bow, Adora, and Catra had been working with Entrapta for years on some secret project, and even got some help from Spin. All with the goal of getting Angella back— she told him. —So, yes. She was brought back just yesterday.

—And?

Castaspella seemed to recall she hadn't finished her soup and promptly returned to it, her expression sorrowful.

She didn't want to answer.

She had no idea whether he knew something or just suspected it from her expression. He could just be that intuitive…

But the thing was, she didn't want to tell him.

—And that's it— she concluded, once she finished her bowl.

—Are you sure?

—Yes…— she replied, standing up and taking her bowl to the sink.

Delwyn sighed and quickly finished his soup too. He then stood up and did the same as her. As she stood there, just looking down into the sink, he lingered and gently tried again, more sincere this time.

—Someone may have told me you are avoiding her…

—Really?

—That there's… something you want to apologize for but won't dare…

—Ugh— she groaned. —I can't do it, alright!?— she exclaimed, walking away.

—Casta, why are you so afraid?

—I had this conversation already. I cannot do it. And it would be for nothing!

—Why do you think that?

—I just- I'm sure she won't accept my apology, a-and may even put Micah and Glimmer against me— she admitted.

—Don’t you think you’re exaggerating?

—No…

Delwyn sighed as he realized that approach wasn’t working, and decided to try another way.

—Tell me something: what if Shadow Weaver had thought like that?

—Huh?

—What if, sure that Catra and Adora wouldn’t accept her apology, she had thought as you do now and refrained from it overall?

—That’s- It’s different— Castaspella argued.

—It is not. Just listen to yourself…

—Delwyn…

—It’s for the best that you apologize— he insisted.

—Why!? Because she’s one of the most prominent figures in Etheria!? Because she’s so perfect that *how* dared I speak to her like I did!?

—Casta, calm down— he gently said, approaching carefully. —Listen, I don’t know exactly what happened, what you said or why. And I don’t know the Queen Mother at all. But… what I *do* know, is that you’re considerate, caring, and would never hurt someone unscrupulously. I am sure regret and shame are eating you from the inside— he expressed, daring to place a hand on her shoulder. —It doesn’t matter if she accepts your apology or not. Do this for yourself now that you can. It doesn’t matter if she’s some perfect supreme being or the lowliest of them all; I understand, from the way you said it, that *you* feel like it was a terrible transgression to speak to her the way you did…

—I don’t know how I feel, I don’t know if apologizing will lift the burden of shame and regret I’ve been carrying, or if there’s something else I’m feeling that will still burden me even if apologizing *does* help somehow— she muttered. —Ugh, I don’t even know what I’m saying…

—Perhaps there’s also resentment? Perhaps you both want and *don’t want* to apologize?

—That makes no sense…

—It does if a part of you resents her and feels like you have nothing to apologize for— he explained, now trying to look at her face, which she kept moving away.

—No, no. I don’t- I wouldn’t resent her… I have no reasons to do so— she assured him, still refusing to look back at him.

—Then why can’t you tell me that while looking at me?

—I just don't want to see the pity in your expression!— she admitted. —Damn it… that's what Spin hates the most…

—See what I mean?

—I can't believe this…— Castaspella sighed. —But, still, even if I went to find her now… I don't even know where to start!

—Just begin with a simple "sorry"— he suggested. —If she knows why you say it, that's enough. If she doesn't, she'll ask, and all you have to do is answer her questions; let that direct the apology until you've gotten everything out.

The Head Sorceress closed her eyes, took a deep breath, and finally turned to look at him.

—Alright. Thank you…

—No need to thank me.

—You just put up with my stubbornness and didn't… give up on me— she argued.

—Because it was worth the effort. After all, Shadow Weaver entrusted me with helping you face your fear of apologizing to the Queen Mother— he commented, smirking.

—Really? Why?

—She said she doesn't understand friendship but noticed that friendly support helps people do things despite their fear…

—Really?— Castaspella asked again, smiling faintly. —That's… quite sweet.

—It is, but better don't tell her— Delwyn laughed. —Now, get going. I'll speak with the Queen and later meet her mother, so you should have plenty of time…

Feeling an awful tightness in her chest and a knot in her throat, Castaspella made her way to Bright Moon, forcing herself to do it once and for all.

She'd speak with Angella and whatever had to happen, she'd let it happen…

By the time she finally found her, Castaspella's hands were all sweaty and she felt so anxious she wanted to turn around and run away. But the angelic being saw her and, curious, waved at her, inviting the Head Sorceress to enter the gardens.

—Good afternoon— she said, her tone surprised as she hesitantly approached. Angella was sitting at a bench, looking regal as remembered. —Are you looking for Micah or something? I wasn't expecting you to come…

—Not really…— she denied, focusing on keeping her breath even. —I was… looking for you.

—Really? After your reaction yesterday, I was half sure you'd avoid me or something…

—Trust me, I kind of did— she muttered, so nervous she couldn't keep her hands still. —Yesterday I was- I wasn't ready to… speak to you— she finally admitted.

—What do you mean? If this is about the thing between you and Shadow Weaver, you have nothing to be ashamed of. I don't question it— she quickly clarified.

—I- Wow, tha-thank you— she stammered, even more nervous now. —Bu-but no, it's not about that…

—Then what is it? You look pale— she pointed out, concerned now.

—I…— she tried to begin, but had to interrupt herself to take a deep breath. —I am sorry, Angella. For the things I said after… we thought Micah had… been killed.

—What- Why are you- That was long ago— the Queen Mother said, despite her expression turning somber.

—It was, but… I never apologized for the things I said— Castaspella insisted, looking away.

—Why now?— she asked, her tone serious.

—I never… did before you- I realized, after the broken-reality thing, that I had been unfair, blaming you for things you have no remote relation to, and then I thought I'd never have the chance to apologize— the sorceress replied. She finally looked back to conclude —Now you're back, so I *had to*.

—No, you did not— Angella disagreed. Shocked, Castaspella remained speechless as the Queen Mother looked away, just as ashamed. —I wasn't exactly nice to you either.

—I'm not seeking an apology. I just want to right my wrongs… It was undeserved, and even when I recognized I was being unfair to you, way before the whole portal thing, I could have apologized and never did— Castaspella uttered. —I was- I just expected everything to be forgotten and then got offended when you didn't answer my letters— she added with a scoff.

—Which is exactly why you shouldn't be apologizing as if only you were in the wrong!

Angella stood up from the bench and approached Castaspella, seeking some hint of sarcasm in her expression.

But there was only shame, sorrow, and regret.

—I said all I had to say. You don't need to accept my apology or apologize back. Just… don't put my brother and my niece against me— she begged, before turning around to leave.

—Wait, Casta…— the Queen Mother stopped her. —You really think- You believe I would put them against you?

—I fear as much, yes. Purposely or not, that's what happened with Glimmer before…

—That- No, no. I swear I didn't try to keep her away from you— Angella assured her, hoping Castaspella would turn to look her way again. —And I absolutely won't do it now. I-in fact…

—What?

—I wanted to thank you for… taking care of them while I was gone— she gently said. That finally made the sorceress look back to see her sincere expression. —I'm sorry too, for dismissing your pain, for ignoring your letters, for mocking you…

—Stop, stop— Castaspella let out, shaking her head. —You don't have to.

—But I want to— she replied, giving her shoulder a light squeeze. —You deserve it.

—I don't— she denied again, feeling her eyes watering.

—Why would *I* deserve an apology and not you?

—I made you responsible for his supposed death, as if you had killed him yourself! If you were bitter to me, it was all my own fault!

—But I should have known better— Angella argued. —Like I said, I dismissed the fact that you were as hurt as me. I had lost my husband and you had lost your brother…

—Still doesn't justify what I said— she sobbed, trying and failing to hold back her tears.

—And what you said doesn't justify my reaction either. Can't we just agree to leave this in the past?— the Queen Mother proposed. —No more feud, no more drama, or petty remarks…

—I… would like that, yes— Castaspella managed to say.

—Then that settles it— Angella smiled, finally letting go of the sorceress. —I'll tell you what: come tonight for dinner, yes? And… I guess the invitation extends to Shadow Weaver even if she doesn't eat— she added.

—Re-really?— she asked, washing away her tears.

—Absolutely. I was given a summary of the past decade and all, but I would rather hear it from you too— she confirmed.

—Tha-thank you very much— Castaspella gratefully accepted, calming down her sobbing. —We'll be here then.

Everything went rather smoothly for months after Angella's return.

However, all good things must end…

Near the end of the year, just two weeks before Glow's birthday, a certain someone showed up in Mystacor.

Someone who had been banished…

—What are *you* doing here!?— Castaspella hissed, frowning at a light-skinned elf, who looked at least Micah's age.

He only smirked smugly as he said —Ah… Head Sorceress, is it now? When the council said they would call the Head of the Guild, I wouldn't have imagined it'd be you… Much less that you'd actually come in person. Does that mean the audience I requested won't be denied, Dear?

—Don't you *fucking* call me that! And no matter what you want to say, you are *banned* from the island. You should *not be here*!

—You wound me— he sarcastically replied. —Yet the council seems to disagree. Otherwise, they wouldn't have called you.

—That is not true— a voice behind Castaspella said. She turned to find Nolrem approaching with the most serious demeanor she had ever seen in him. It could even be said it was a rather threatening expression. —"The council" didn't approve of your presence here. Two of the youngest councillors, who have no idea who you are or what you've done, saw no issue with your arrival and called the Head Sorceress as per your request— he clarified, coming to a halt next to Castaspella. —But make no mistake. You're very much banned from here still. So we'll have to ask you to leave immediately.

—Oh, Nolrem, Dear. Still so hurt?— he mockingly said, confusing the sorceress.

—I don't know what you're talking about, but I don't care. *Leave, now*.

—Of course you don't know— he laughed. —I suppose no one told you…

—That's enough mockery. You've been ordered to leave. Comply or we'll have to get the Queen involved— Nolrem insisted, noticing that more and more people were gathering around.

—Really? Are you going to hide behind the Queen's back?

—No. I would rather kill you with my own hands, but that's unfortunately forbidden. If you don't leave, we're calling the Queen to make sure I don't actually throw you out through the window this time— Castaspella replied, expressionless. —Choose your next move carefully.

—What the fuck is going on here!?— Shadow Weaver's voice suddenly exclaimed, appearing from behind the elf.

Her voice was calm, but her rage was clear.

She could feel Castaspella's tumultuous emotions, and it wasn't difficult to imagine how Nolrem had to be feeling to speak in such a way.

And yet, the irreverent elf looked unfazed when he turned around. He didn't seem to recognize her, only noticed their common race and didn't hesitate to introduce himself with an exaggerated bow.

—The name is Anil Ju…

—Kid Ju!?— Shadow Weaver reacted, instinctively wanting to take a step back.

—That… nickname. You can't possibly be…— he hesitated. —Light Spinner!?— he realized, before letting out a cackle.

—Enough of this! Your mockery won't be tolerated. Leave Mystacor at once! And don't *ever* step here again as long as your ban remains in place— Castaspella interceded, setting aside her confusion as her wrath was far greater.

He turned back to look at her, smirking, and argued —Ah, but that's the thing. I have come to request an audience to have my ban lifted.

—*Request denied*— Nolrem and the sorceress spat at the same time.

—Rude…

Castaspella scoffed, shaking her head in disbelief, and retorted —*Rude*!? We are being *too* polite. Because if what you told Councilman Nolrem means what I think it means, then you're *lucky* we aren't pushing you over the edge!

—If we haven't, it's solely because of our status as leaders of Mystacor.

—*Unfortunately* …

Hearing and feeling the Head Sorceress so enraged, Shadow Weaver stepped closer to her, fighting the urge to calm her down, yet wanting to get between those two, protectively.

—I would gladly throw you out myself instead; I'll let you choose whether that's screaming in fear or agony…

From behind, Castaspella placed a hand on Shadow Weaver's shoulder and calmed herself a bit to remind her —While I'd certainly enjoy the sight, even better if you threw him all the way to Beast Island, I'm still responsible for you and can't allow it. *Regrettably*.

—Quite— Nolrem agreed. —But it has been enough leniency from us already. I'll get the Queen.

—So you allow this woman, this *murderer*, to be here, but *I*, who didn't kill anyone, remain banned?— he argued.

Both sorceresses felt alluded to by the comment, but couldn't react. Instead, it was Nolrem who replied, before actually leaving.

—*You* are a backstabber cheater who betrayed our trust and was rightfully charged for treason — he reminded the elf. —So, if you're referring to how Light- Shadow Weaver obliterated Head Sorcerer Norwyn, at least she had the *decency* to do it all herself and own up to it.

—While you *used me* to get your way, cursed my master, and even had the gall to plead innocent!

—But I didn't force you to kill her, did I?— he smugly replied, leaning forward, his tone lower but just loud enough that their little "audience" would hear.

—You, petty little bitch!— Castaspella exclaimed, resolution broken as she tried to reach for his neck.

—Don't— Shadow Weaver stopped her. —Strangling him isn't worth it…— she told her, squinting back at Anil. She then addressed Nolrem, ordering —Get Queen Glimmer *now*.

Noticing the people around were now shamelessly whispering amongst themselves, the councilman was hesitant to leave them alone.

But the sooner he brings Glimmer, the faster they'll get rid of the elf.

—So he's gone— Anil let out with a smirk, after watching Nolrem teleport away. —That leaves us three… and all these people, of course. I *hope* they couldn't hear me…

—I'm begging you, let me kill him— Castaspella growled under her breath, once again trying to advance towards him. —I have nothing more to lose.

—Yes, you have— Shadow Weaver muttered. —Don't let him get under your skin. That's *my* job— she told her, with a bit of humor, trying to distract her. —And I would rather not be called as a witness in a trial for murder.

Holding onto the woman, the Head Sorceress finally looked away from Anil and instead gave her a sorrowful look.

—He's just standing there with that stupid smile as if he had done *nothing*. I can't bear it…

—Just a minute, Glimmer will be here any time soon— Shadow Weaver assured her, embracing her tightly and trying to ignore the people around.

Fortunately, the Queen appeared right that moment, along with Nolrem and two of her guards, and didn't miss a second.

—Anil Ju, in my capacity as Queen of Bright Moon, I hereby arrest you for violating the terms of your banishment— she declared, serious and setting her staff firmly next to her. —Further charges will be pressed after I review your original case.

With a gesture, she ordered the guards to escort him all the way to Bright Moon. Fortunately, he complied; he was a proud man, but not stupid enough to defy the Queen.

—You better not be taking him to a spare room— Shadow Weaver remarked, as the Queen approached them.

—No, no— she quickly said, before Castaspella could comment on that. —I actually took longer to arrive because, after hearing what he had done, I ordered for a proper cell to be fashioned out of an old cellar— she proudly explained.

—That sounds better— the woman smirked. —I'll pay him a visit later.

—Alright. But now I need you three to explain everything to me.

—That would be less than ideal— Shadow Weaver muttered.

—All these people heard him. Telling Glimmer will make no difference— the Head Sorceress replied, looking down.

—The council room should be empty, your Majesty— Nolrem said, remaining as formal as possible despite how upset and awkward he felt.

The four of them headed there, briefly walking past the sealed chamber, which Shadow Weaver eyed for a second…

As soon as the door was closed, the Queen let out a sigh and turned to look at them.

—Now: What happened with that guy? Councilman Nolrem mentioned he cursed someone? That's why he was banned?

—That would be correct— Castaspella nodded. —But the full story is a bit longer.

—Please tell me everything, Auntie. I won't go easy on him if he hurt you.

—Go ahead— Shadow Weaver encouraged her.

—When I was… perhaps fifteen years old, and completely unknown here, I met him— she began. —I don't know if I ever told you, but… I had a tutor named Zosia back then; she warned me from the beginning about him. If I had listened to her, she'd probably- I don't know if she'd be alive to this day, but she would have certainly lived far longer.

—Did he… kill her?

—No— Castaspella sighed. —I did— she admitted, making her niece gasp. —I had to. She begged me to do it because she couldn't do it herself.

—I don't understand. Why!? How!? Did he do something!? Is it related to the curse!?

—It is. But… it was my fault that he even got the chance…

—Auntie, why would it be your fault?

—Because I let him in… like an idiot— she hissed, closing her fists tightly. —He told me everything I wanted to hear. When most said I was a failure, he would say I was misunderstood. When the council censured my… admiration for Light Spinner, he would say everyone, even your father, were in the wrong. That I was right. He just… literally told me what I wanted to hear, which Zosia repeatedly warned me about, but I didn't want to listen.

—You were just a teen, Auntie… A-and he looks just as old as Dad.

—I should have known better. Especially since he is, in fact, a bit older than your father. I should have… stayed away from a man his age that kept showing intentions beyond… friendship— she argued. —But I was all flavours of stupid and didn't think straight at all.

—It was *not* your fault— Nolrem interrupted. —If anything, it was ours…

—Why would it be?

—Anil was *my* boyfriend back then, and I never noticed what he was doing. Or rather, I convinced myself it was nothing, despite seeing him too interested in you… I didn't think he was capable. Even called Zosia a liar when she told me to keep him away because she found him about to… kiss you.

—Ah, yes. *That*— Castaspella recalled, shivering. —Don't make me talk about that. Thank the Stars she showed up in time. Back to the matter at hand, like I said, I was stupid. I let him convince me everyone was against me, that I could only trust him… and ended up facilitating him with all the means to sneak into Zosia's private workshop— she explained, looking away. —How to avoid all alarms, how to unlock the doors, how to sort the illusions maze leading to the workshop… I told him everything without even… stopping to think— she lamented.

—That fucking little piece of shit— Shadow Weaver muttered, angry and disgusted. —I never thought he would turn out to be like them; I especially didn't expect him to be that much worse than me…

—You know him too?— Glimmer asked, confused now.

—Was that why you called him "Kid Ju"?— Castaspella inquired right after.

—My master was a cunning person, quite questionable, and possibly the person who taught me the most about… manipulating everything to my favour— the woman explained. —Anil Ju was their son.

—We were barely around twelve when they attempted the Spell and died. But Anil never met them…

—If I recall correctly, that would be because his uncle took care of him instead. And, if my calculations are correct, he's about four or five years older than Micah, must have been eight years old, at most, when my Master died. He never met them because he only came here to begin his studies once he turned twelve.

—I recall you told me that was the mentor you admired the most— Castaspella nodded. —That you wanted to prove they weren't bad like the rumours said…

—That was how *I* reacted to their death. But Anil grew surrounded by those rumours, and became a perfect copy of his parent. That's why I called him "Kid Ju".

—Hold on— Castaspella interrupted her. —Then, how old were you when you tutored my brother?

—Twenty-three— she replied. —I graduated at nineteen years old, if you're wondering.

—What!? Your whole reputation… you build that in four years!?

—Yes— she proudly said.

—I can confirm. She was quite masterful. I, on the other hand, graduated the same year she attempted the spell, just a few months before, despite being her age.

—And I graduated at that same age! That's the average age for graduation! Only Micah had graduated earlier than usual, and he was *twenty*!

—Excuse me, when did my- our pupils graduate? How old was the youngest of them?— she smugly asked. The Head Sorceress folded her arms and muttered something, yet she wanted to hear her and insisted —Louder.

—Sixteen…

—Well, some of them were younger than the usual age at which pupils are supposed to begin their training— Nolrem argued.

—Yes, I know. But her age doesn't bother me that much. I just can't believe she could build such a reputation as a tutor in only four years!

—Did you never think about this before? It's simple math. You know our age difference, you could have made the calculations yourself…

—I never did because Micah had told me you looked like thirty!

—*What*!?— Shadow Weaver exclaimed, indignant. —Excuse me while I go die a second time…

Her dramatism made them all laugh for a moment.

—I *told you* so much studying was making you look older— Nolrem joked.

—It was the *veil*! I didn't look that old without it!— she argued, indignant.

Castaspella could hardly hold her laughter, yet something came to mind and she let out —But, now that I think better about it… The numbers make no sense. I was told the incident

with your master happened about a decade before I was born! If Anil was eight, Micah must have been four, perhaps three, so it would have been one or two years before my birth…

—And who told you that?

—I don't remember. But when we talked about this last time, you didn't correct me…

—I hadn't thought about it— Shadow Weaver argued.

—"Did you never think about this before? It's simple math"— Castaspella repeated, mocking her. —Or what? Will you argue you were, perhaps, *distracted*?— she teased her, referencing something Nolrem couldn't understand.

The Queen, on the other hand, immediately caught what she meant and both of them laughed loudly, making the woman blush and cover her face, which made the councilman chuckle too.

They kept laughing, barely able to control themselves, until Glimmer realized they had deviated far from the matter at hand and forced herself to calm down.

—A-alright. With that sorted out, can we return to the cursing and banishment thing?

—Of course, excuse us— Nolrem apologized.

—Basically, I realized too late what he had done. I just… couldn't find him one day, decided to go see Zosia instead, and noticed the alarms were off… I rushed to find her, but he had already cursed her. And I went blind with rage…

—That thing about throwing him out of the window…

—I almost did that, yes— Castaspella interrupted Shadow Weaver, expression darkening again. —I wanted him *dead*. If those acolytes that showed up hadn't appeared in time, I would have killed him. Instead, I threw him at their feet and told them what he had done.

—And… why did you have to kill your mentor? Why did she want to die?

—Because the curse caused her unbearable pain— she explained. —It hindered her mobility, became worse with time, and pained her terribly, more and more each day… So I- Eventually, I couldn't stand seeing her like that anymore and finally gave her some spider poison as she wanted. I stayed with her all night until she passed…— she narrated. —After that, I made such a mess of my room; I broke things, punched the walls, screamed as if I were going to die too… Until I realized what I had done, how I had stalled my studies. And that made me decide never to reach such a low point again. I swore never to let my feelings get so out of control, and *never* to trust blindly again. Especially in those who threaten the people I love.

—Nolrem mentioned as much— Shadow Weaver recalled, giving him a look, and he nodded, confirming it. —That's why it surprised him that you trusted me.

—Like it happened with, well… Adora at first, I needed proof that you weren't the threat I initially believed you to be.

—That's why you questioned my friendship with Adora after she broke those lunar crystals?

—Indeed— she nodded. —As I said back then, I feared she'd break the Lunar Lenses and put us all in danger— she explained. —It would have been repeating history in the worst way possible. But she then saved us…

—Why didn't you tell us any of this?

—It was- I was ashamed. Of everything— Castaspella admitted. —I'm sorry, Glimmer. But if you want all the truth… When I started making a name for myself, completely unwillingly, I started feeling so guilty I wanted to escape. I had nothing left here, I had grieved her already… I was going to leave Mystacor and disappear. U-until you were born.

—What?— Glimmer softly asked, surprised.

—It wasn't enough to convince me to stay, but it did delay me. I especially wanted to flee because the council was offering me to be Head Sorceress and hardly took a no for an answer…

Hearing that, Nolrem remained silent, only gave Shadow Weaver a guilty look, and let Glimmer further ask —Then why did you stay?

—When we thought your father died… I accused your mother of being a coward. So I couldn't bring myself to abandon Mystacor, the kingdom that trusted me, like a *coward*. The guilt I felt was too much, but not as much as it would have been if I left Mystacor to their fate when, for some reason, they trusted me…

—I'm so sorry, Auntie— Glimmer apologized, rushing to embrace her.

—It's quite alright. You didn't have to know. I didn't want to burden any of you with this— she gently replied, hugging her back.

After a while, Shadow Weaver accompanied Castaspella back to her room, told her to have dinner, let her hug and kiss her as much as she needed, and finally left her alone to visit Anil Ju, as promised.

Part of her wanted to end him, swiftly and silently, without any chance of him getting away. But another part, perhaps even more wicked, wanted to see him rot in that cell, suffer, pay for what she considered a heinous crime that even *she* wouldn't commit.

It was, in fact, quite satisfying watching him pace around a cold stone room, hands chained together keeping him from performing any magic, and occasionally struggling to open the iron gate.

—Hello! Someone out there!— he called, sounding bothered. —Will you keep me here for long!? Hello!

The single guard left there to watch over the cell, in case he tried to escape, completely ignored him.

That was probably for the best…

However, Shadow Weaver had no trouble passing through to observe Anil from the shadows.

When she finally decided to reveal herself, she startled him saying —Kid Ju…

—Fuck! Ho-how long have you been there!?

—A while.

—And why are you here? You're clearly as psychotic as me, you have *nothing* to reproach me— he spat.

It amused her that, suddenly, he behaved more defensively instead of smugly like before. She couldn't help but smirk at the realization…

—I have a *lot* to reproach you. From an immoral point of view, you're a lowly coward. You didn't get your hands dirty. You skillfully manipulated your way into Zosia's workshop, yes, but didn't have the guts to kill her yourself. *Instead*, you cursed her in such a way that it would force the woman to end her life on her own— she began. —If you had planned to force Cas to kill her in your stead from the beginning, it would have been *genius*, but that part was an accident, wasn't it?— she scoffed. —You only manipulated her for information… Quite pathetic and short-sighted if you never intended to kill the woman yourself…

—I just wanted her to *suffer* for letting my father perform that spell! She was supposed to be their friend! And yet she let them walk right to their death!

—You think Zosia didn't try to stop them!? She tried! I saw it! They were just too stubborn to abandon the idea! You cursed the only person that actually cared for your father! The only person who never spoke ill of them!

—No! I heard the stories! Everyone considered them crazy! Everyone rejected them! They had nothing left and that spell was a last desperate attempt to fix their life!

—Your father was an egocentric maniac. They "lost everything" when their wife died, and it became their obsession to bring her back! They thought that the spell would let them achieve that, but it only made everything worse for *you*!— she remarked. —They hadn't lost everything. There was still *you*, yet they didn't care…

—No, no! My-my father loved me and Mother. I-I know it!

—Trust me, I'm not trying to be cruel when I say they did *not* care. In fact, Zosia took care of you while you were a baby and until your uncle could take you in, because your father was always "too busy"— Shadow Weaver revealed. —But you never knew that because, by the time you finally began your studies, you already hated Zosia and never gave her a chance!

—That's not true. None of that is true…— he breathed out, shaking his head and looking on the verge of tears.

—It is. I have no reasons to lie. I came here only to tell you that the difference between you and me is that you were stupid enough to betray all the people who genuinely loved you… and you did it out of *spite*. For someone who wasn't worth the revenge you enacted!— she sentenced. —Zosia, Nolrem, even Cas… they *all* cared for you, loved you, yet you weren't worth that love, after all, were you?— she added, condescendingly. —We may have a lot in common, Kid Ju, but we aren't the same because me being treacherous was a result of people failing me even when I was trying *so hard* to protect our world! But you? You just wanted to avenge someone who doomed themselves, on their *own*!

—No…

—Zosia wasn't to blame! She was the last person to love you like your mother did!

—No! She let Father die!

—She struggled to stop them to no avail. For *you*. But, as I said, they never cared…

—Shut up!— he sobbed, finally breaking down. —None of that is true!

—Truth hurts, Kid Ju. But if you hadn't avoided it for so long, it would have hurt less…

Meanwhile, back in Mystacor, Castaspella left her room and stealthily walked down the halls.

Soon, she found herself in front of the sealed chamber.

She stared for a long while, clenching and unclenching her hands… taking deep breaths, trying to calm down so the woman wouldn't feel anything strange from her… and getting mentally ready.

She had thought this through for enough time already; since peeking at that acolyte's investigation on the parasitic magic months before.

She only needed this last push…

She'd *do it*.

As one of the people who placed the seals on the chamber, she knew exactly what part would be unprotected if she took her seal down. She had always known that sneaking in was *actually pretty easy*, but it didn't matter until this moment.

Soon, the sorceress was inside, staring at the pink rhombus holding the amorphous mass of parasitic magic, once again taking deep breaths.

After a moment of hesitation, she finally breathed out —Nothing can be as difficult to handle as Beatrix…

And stuck her hands into the containment.

Chapter End Notes

Guys, guys.

The age is a headcanon of mine, alright? I hc that Micah was 14 aprox, that Casta may have been 8, and LS about 23. Why? They kinda look the part. Micah actually looks younger, but that may be his personality. He was supposedly a “third-grader”, which in school is either 8/9 in primary school, or 14/15 in secondary school (at least in this country?) and Micah was definitely not 8 or 9.
And if you think Casta looked far younger, I invite you to look at different 8yo kids. She could have been just petite as a kid, but, regardless, I fully believe she could have easily been 8. If not, well, what, 6? There’s not much of a difference in appearance I guess. It would add two years to their age-gap, but who cares…

So, calculations give me 23 for LS at the time of Light Spinner episode, which can be argued, yes, BUT my counterargument is that I am 24 rn and for a long time I’ve been told I look much older than my age; when I was 16 I would get confused with 25! So I find it plausible that she’d look older to all of us, but may have been younger. It also puts an emphasis on her skills and all that she so much brags about. She was supposed to be the best of the best, a non-natural prodigy, opposed to Micah, so this is basically my take on the matter. I made a lot of calculations and editions to make it make sense, trust me…
If you disagree, that’s perfectly fine by me.

Again, even if the age-gap were larger, it doesn’t matter because SW and Casta met when Casta was already over 30 in canon. SW could be 60 or 70 by then (instead of, like, 50) and it wouldn’t matter. Besides, if she really is a long-lived species as I believe her to be, all the more reasons! Even with +60 years she’d be the equivalent to a 40/50yo woman perhaps…

But it’s all me, myself, and I, thinking this, alright? You don’t need to adhere. This is not the first time I’ve given them this 15 years age-gap, but it is the first time I calculate what LS's age would have been when teaching Micah. So… yeah…

Now yes, leave me your thoughts on the matter if you want!!

Onto the next subject: my headcanon of why Casta reacted like she did on *In The Shadows of Mystacor*.
Basically, it would be this: She promised to herself never to trust so blindly ever again, and never to lose it like that anymore; hence, lines like “This is the kind of person you hang around with?” that she told Glimmer after Adora broke those lunar crystals at the

Lunarium, in this context remembering Anil, who got in thanks to her and destroyed her life like Adora destroyed those crystals. And the “She could have destroyed the lenses that protect Mystacor”, that would be akin to how, because of him, her tutor was cursed; she loves the people of Mystacor and wouldn’t ever let anyone get hurt, she wants to protect them like she couldn’t protect her tutor. Also, the way she kept reminding herself of SW’s antics in the Woods; after all, the last person to have caught her eye -okay, this is me inserting Castaweaver solely because of that furious blush- betrayed her, only used her, she allowed it, and that led to her having to kill her tutor to end her suffering.
If I sound insane, maybe I am…

Finally, this is the last clarification: yes, Anil’s parent, while non-binary, is still called “father” by him because he never knew them and never got around calling them anything else. They were male-presenting, so like, for Anil, that was his “father”.
Details…

Thank you all for reading!! See you next week!!

Of Immortality And Eternity

Chapter Summary

A complicated subject will have the Queen Mother rethinking the decisions she shall make in the near future, and remind her just how important enjoying each moment is…
» —Angie? I thought you'd… be having breakfast and all. Did something happen?
» —Not at all, my Love. I would like to have breakfast with you, if you don't mind.
» —Of course! I'd be glad!
» —Excellent.

Likewise, the passage of time will make itself noticeable as kids grow and age wages on everyone more and more…

Chapter Notes

This chapter is almost as long as the previous one, oops! <("^_^)
I'm going insane with these last chapters…
Just two more after this one and it will be the end for real this time…
OH GODS I can't believe it TT^TT It's really ending…
It's the saddest most joyful occasion, ending a series this long…

But I promise there's more to come after this series ends!
After all, I have the massive project of *The Tyrant of Mystacor* to post eheheheeheh

Anyways... I hope you enjoy this chapter, more centered in Angella for the first 5k words… and then with some shenanigans near the end XD

Welcome! Have a good time!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was very early in the morning when Castaspella went to visit Angella.

It had surprised the Queen Mother quite a lot, but she didn't question her at first…

Until the Head Sorceress told her what she needed from her.

She had *so many questions*.

But Castaspella had already lost a lot of time since the previous night, so the interrogation would have to wait.

—It's all gone now— Angella assured her. —There's no residual energy.

—Good…

—You should have come immediately. I don't know how you lasted this long!

—I read *somewhere* that part of it could be purged at the Lunarium with the right elements… — Castaspella explained. —So I got rid of most of it, but… I knew there had to be some left.

This made her think back to the issue with the acolyte and how they had failed to do the same with her arm.

If only they had known before… But it had to be *that same acolyte* who discovered all of that, no?

The process wasn't enough on its own, but it was painless and could have bought them more time.

Not like the acolyte had as little time as her, though. After all, Castaspella had purposely guided it close to her heart…

—Why did you do it?— Angella finally asked, after a moment of hesitation. —I must know. I don't get it…

—It's… the only way to remain with Bea- I mean, Spin…

The Queen Mother sighed, smiling faintly.

—While I understand the sentiment, I have to warn you: you just doomed yourself to a damned immortality— she began. —And, this only makes it worse because *any* kind of immortality is akin to a curse *per se*— she warned her. —It's… lonely— she added, looking away and embracing herself.

—Then what about you?— the sorceress questioned her. —Micah isn't immortal…

—Well, I… can extend his life as much as I want— she admitted, rolling her eyes a bit, unable to hold her sight as she said it. However, she then gave her a serious look as she clarified —If I haven't done so, it's solely because of what I just told you. I would never doom him to immortality and have him suffer the loneliness and sorrow of seeing those he loves die while he doesn't. I don't want to be alone again either, of course. But I can't do that to him.

—Well… That's also why I did it— Castaspella said, with a faint smile. —Perhaps, when she died, Spin deserved to spend the rest of eternity alone. But I believe she has earned it to never suffer like that again— she argued. —I *wanted* this. It won't feel like a curse. We'll both be dead, damned, immortal, but *never alone*…

—I see…

—I guess that, after I die, the summoning spell will, well, dispel. So she will vanish. We'll both just linger around the parasitic energy that is now sealed in Mystacor, with our half-lives attached to it and all— the Head Sorceress supposed. —And, naturally, that would mean that, if Micah were to stay with you and continue living, he'd probably want to, you know, summon me. Call me back to the world of the living.

—I imagine he would, yes— Angella nodded, with a sad smile this time.

—Then I need you to promise me that you won't let him do it unless he also summons Spin — Castaspella immediately requested. —The whole point of what I did is to make sure I won't leave her alone, after all…

—Of course— the Queen Mother agreed. —I'll remember.

That day, Angella was left with a bitter feeling.

She loathed discussing *death*.

She had been forced to learn to focus on the present since a "young age", at least for her, and for the past thousands of years, she had always refrained from thinking about the day she would lose those she cared for. Instead, she was determined to enjoy every day with them, without letting the imminence of their future deaths darken her mood.

Now, however, her mind was reeling, thinking about how she could, in fact, lose her husband again *soon*.

Feeling her chest tighten, she returned to her room, where she had left him sleeping, and barely held back her tears while gently embracing him.

He mumbled something incomprehensible, and it made her chuckle slightly.

She cradled him between her arms until he finally woke up, a bit confused but noticeably glad regardless.

—Angie? I thought you'd… be having breakfast and all— he let out, yawning in the middle of the sentence. —Did something happen?

—Not at all, my Love— she denied, smiling softly. —I would like to have breakfast with you, if you don't mind.

—Of course! I'd be glad!— he quickly replied, suddenly more awake.

—Excellent— she sighed, before kissing his forehead.

Reluctantly, the Queen Mother let go of Micah to let him get dressed while she went to the door. She asked the guards standing nearby to order some food to be delivered there and returned with him.

—You seem melancholic, Angie. Are you sure everything is fine?

—Of course. It couldn't be better— she assured him, taking his hands. —I just want to spend more time with you…

—I would love that— Micah replied, smiling brightly.

Soon, Glow's fifth birthday celebration arrived, and it proved highly difficult trying to convince Angella that they were *not* having any grand party, but rather just a small, familiar gathering with the other princesses and some friends.

They did, fortunately, manage as much… eventually.

However, the week of her birthday, the girl had caught a cold and the celebration had to be delayed a few days until she got better.

When the gathering finally took place, all the princesses were in attendance, along with Bow's fathers, Catra and Adora with Finn, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver, and even Delwyn.

As well as both, Hordak and Wrong Hordak, dragged there by Entrapta despite Hordak's complaints, which was worth a *very* tense moment. The Queen Mother already *knew* that he, like Shadow Weaver, had been helping Etheria now. And, of course, just like she had accepted both Catra and Shadow Weaver's current statuses, so did she accept Hordak's. Both of them.

But it was… slightly more awkward since their war had lasted so long. Their enmity predated both Catra and Shadow Weaver, after all…

Yet they were both respectful enough to keep it all civil and seemed to silently agree to keep their distance.

One of the few moments when they participated in the same conversation was as they reminisced about the double wedding that Adora, Catra, Glimmer, and Bow had shared.

—It was a beautiful event, and holding it at the Temple of Mara, the former Crystal Castle, was a fantastic idea!— Castaspella assured.

—It was made into a temple?— Angella asked, curious.

—Yes! We made some modifications, Bow and Entrapta fixed its holograms to inform visitors about Mara and her deeds, and Perfuma decorated it with some flowers Mara liked— Adora explained, excited.

—That sounds like quite the project.

—It was a *massive* undertaking but working with that technology was *absolutely* worth it!— Entrapta immediately commented, as excited as Adora. —And we learnt a lot about the First Ones while programming the holograms, didn't we?

Both Bow and Hordak nodded, which made the Queen Mother ask —You participated too?

He wasn't sure at first, but her sight was undoubtedly fixed on Hordak, so the question had to be for him.

—I did, indeed— he replied.

—I… understood you weren't fond of the First Ones…

—They have been gone for long— he first answered, keeping his tone polite. —And, at the end of the war, it was none other than one of them who saved me— he added, nodding at Adora, grateful.

—I see…— Angella sighed. —So, I take it you also attended the weddings?

—We did.

—It was a very nice ritual— Wrong Hordak chimed in, so cheerful that the contrast with his clone was striking.

—We couldn't miss such an opportunity! We had never been to a wedding!— Entrapta added, surprising everyone as she didn't speak about it as a "social event" where to conduct an "investigation".

—You hadn't?— Bow asked, curious. —I assumed the clones hadn't, but… you neither?

—Nope! The concept of weddings wasn't of my interest before— she admitted. —We haven't had such rituals in Dryl as far as I know.

—I am still a bit confused about those ceremonies— Wrong Hordak let out, pensive. —You led the process, didn't you?— he then asked Castaspella.

—Yes, I did.

—Is it difficult? What are the conditions people must meet to participate?— he further asked.

He seemed unusually serious about this, but it appeared like everyone wanted to see where he was going, so no one dared interrupt.

The Head Sorceress blinked a few times before finding her speech again, explaining —It's not complicated, I guess. I did have to practice the opening speech and the proper formulas, but it's not what I would call "difficult". And, if you mean what are the conditions for the people to get married, I'd just say it's a question of compromise and love for their partner.

—I agree— Mermista nodded. —When Sea Hawk and I married, it was because we reached a stage of compromise that merited as much— she shared.

—Oh, Scorpia and I too!— Perfuma chimed in, smiling brightly. —We think it's a way of showing our love for each other— she explained.

One by one, all the married couples in attendance gave their opinion, even Delwyn made a brief comment, until Wrong Hordak was satisfied. The conclusion was that it's a joyous occasion that people deeply in love, and eager to make their compromise a more consolidated thing, decide to do as a way to celebrate their love and share it with others.

However, that led to him asking Castaspella —And you?

—What about me?

—Will you not marry?— he asked, genuinely curious.

—Wha-what?

Half the people held back a laugh, while others didn't even try and openly cackled just thinking about Shadow Weaver *getting married*. The woman herself snorted, which made the sorceress blush even deeper.

Micah, on the other hand, almost choked on his drink and decided it would be for the best to stay out of the conversation.

—Do you not wish to celebrate your love in such a joyful way?— Wrong Hordak insisted, baffled at the reactions he was getting.

—He's so innocent, sometimes— Catra muttered, making Glimmer nod in agreement while snickering more discreetly now.

The only one who wasn't laughing, but rather taking his words quite seriously, was the Queen Mother.

She paid special attention as Castaspella answered —I don't think that's relevant in… our case.

—The living *can't* marry the dead— Shadow Weaver pointed out.

—Precisely. A-and we're perfectly fine as is…

—Oh… I see— he let out, seemingly disappointed.

—Did you want to go to another wedding?— the woman asked him, smirking.

—Perhaps— he admitted, looking away and blushing. —I had a very delightful time and haven't had another opportunity since— he argued, ending with a wink and making Hordak close his eyes as he took a deep breath to hide his second-hand embarrassment.

The conversation finally changed focus and split into several smaller groups once again. Castaspella was still quite awkward, but disguised it with ease while she chatted with George and Lance.

As the celebration came to an end, one by one the guests left Bright Moon, until only the royal family, Castaspella, and Shadow Weaver remained. They were about to leave too, but the Queen Mother asked the Head Sorceress for a minute and took her aside to speak.

—I know it was just… a very odd conversation with that… uh, clone— she began. —But don't you think, maybe…

—Listen— Castaspella interrupted her. —I think I know where you're going. I… kind of feel that what I did is pretty much… a symbolic marriage, in a way.

—Precisely— Angella nodded. —It's not the same ritual, but the significance… the meaning… and what was discussed today, it all fits!

—Yes, I-I know. But… what about that?

—I just think you should tell her…

—What!? No! Especially not framing it this way! She'd combust!

The Queen Mother couldn't help laughing at that, which caught everyone's attention.

—Sorry, sorry… I suppose you're right— she managed to apologize, calming down a bit.

—Anyways… We're leaving now…

—Alright, I won't hold you back— she sighed. —But I still think you should tell her.

—I'll see… Angella— Castaspella sighed too. —Good night…

For a while, the matter was forgotten.

But the Queen Mother would hardly let go and, as she did a follow-up on the Head Sorceress' state, for the fourth week in a row, she decided to bring it up again.

—So?

—So what?

—Have you told her what you've done?

—No— Castaspella denied. —I don't think I will.

—Why?

—I *told you*! She'd… hate the idea so much…

—What makes you think that?

—Angella, whatever you think a loving relationship is, or rather, *everything* you know about how loving relationships are, *forget it*. It's all in reverse with Spin.

—What!? Why!? I-I don't think I understand.

—To give you an example, I can't even… *kiss her* unless she allows me to, because a part of her still thinks love is a weakness, and that all displays of love are showing said weakness, and so on…

—Well, but… you- I mean, you certainly don't have such issues in private, do you?

Castaspella folded her arms and made the same face she did all those years ago, when Angella told her the spare room was the "prison".

—Are you trying to ask whether we have sex or not?

—I-I wouldn't put it that way…

—Never mind— she sighed, rolling her eyes. —The answer remains: it took me *too long* to get her to, at least, show me her concern for me instead of disguising it with some mean remark. And yes, I mean *in private*. Do you understand that?

—So that's a redundant "no".

—More like… I can't risk it yet.

—You plan on telling her, eventually?

—Lest she figures it out before I can do so, yeah… I will. I'll *try*— Castaspella nodded. —Preferably before she has to find out the hard way.

—Yes, please, do consider that.

The women laughed slightly for a moment before finally parting ways, each to tend to her matters…

As soon as a month later, the Queen organized another gathering with her friends, to which close family was invited. Hence, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver once again visited the palace.

—Nothing bad with coming here so often, but…

—But it's losing its charm— the woman interrupted Lance. —You can always refuse to come too…

—And you?— George asked, folding his arms.

—I can refuse… but *someone* won't let me live with that decision, you know?— she argued, rolling her eyes.

—If you didn't want to come, why didn't you tell me!?

—Would you have cared?

—Of course!

—I think you underestimate Castaspella's regard for your feelings— Lance chuckled.

—Yes, she does!— the sorceress agreed, folding her arms too. —Why wouldn't you tell me!? I don't want to torture you by dragging you here!

—Calm down, woman…— Shadow Weaver sighed. —It's not how I wanted to spend the day, but it's not torture either— she assured her.

Meanwhile, a few meters away, the Queen Mother hogged Glow's attention.

—I can't blame her— Glimmer sighed. —But I feel like she's overdoing it— she told Bow.

—Overdoing it, how?

—It's like she wants to be *the* best grandmother or something, but there's no one to compare to!

—So…

—So she's overdoing it!

—I'm hearing you, you know?— Angella suddenly said, despite her sight remaining on Glow as she raised her up in the air with both hands, making her feel like she was flying. —If you feel like I'm stealing your daughter, you can tell me— she added, finally looking down at her.

For a moment, Glimmer observed Glow's bright smile and heard her joyous laughter.

—Of course not, Mom. You're not stealing her or anything— she assured her. —But, at the same time, you don't have to put so much effort, you know?

—She's right. Glow loves you, and clearly enjoys playing with you— the King agreed.

—We're thrilled that you love her so much too, but sometimes it feels like… you're afraid she won't like you if you don't spend hours with her— the Queen explained.

Halting the little flying game, Angella sat the girl on her lap and replied —I suppose I… may be. I missed her birth and the first few years of her life.

—Well, you didn't miss her first words, at least— Bow chuckled.

—She's probably just shy— she commented, smiling down at Glow. —Aren't you, Little One?

The girl only laughed cheerfully and jumped a bit in place. They weren't sure whether she understood but, at the same time, they felt they were maybe underestimating her. She was already five years old; her lack of speech didn't necessarily mean a lack of understanding.

—Don't worry, Mom. She's always really happy to see you, I promise.

—Hey, Glow!— Finn suddenly called, rushing towards them. As they halted in front of the Queen Mother, they asked the girl —Wanna play Hide and Seek!?

—What do you say, Baby?— Glimmer asked too, smiling at her daughter.

Glow, however, looked up at Angella, as if asking for permission, and that was exactly what Finn understood, so they pleaded —Can she!? Please!?

—Oh, of course!— the Queen Mother accepted.

—Thanks, Tall Bird Lady!

—You're wel- What did you call me!?

At a certain distance, but close enough to have heard them, Adora and Catra audibly facepalmed, almost in unison. At the same time, Castaspella had to halt her conversation with George and Lance to cover her mouth and hold back a cackle, while Bow's fathers shared an awkward look. On the other hand, Shadow Weaver didn't even try to keep herself from laughing.

—Finn!— Catra called, but the child and Glow had already run away to play. —We're *so sorry*, your Majesty— she apologized. —Finn likes using those silly names…

—I believe I've heard them use one of those before…— she replied, surprised still.

—We're trying to teach them, but… they say using normal names is "lame". They only like Glow's name— Adora commented.

—I see…

—Yeah, they use the same nicknames Catra uses for us— Bow chimed in. —But they are still just ten, it will pass— he smiled.

—Probably— Glimmer added.

—*It better*, Sparkles.

—In any case, we should probably go supervise the kids; we left Melog sleeping at home— Adora commented.

—Oh, of course! Let's go!— the Queen cheerfully said.

—You coming, Catra?— Bow asked, looking back as he followed his wife.

—You three go. I'll join you later— she replied, nodding.

Angella waited until they were out of earshot before addressing Catra.

—Everything alright?

—I just wanted to apologize again for the nickname thing… We really tried teaching them to use the right names, for instance, to stop calling Shadow Weaver "Ghost Lady", but we had to give up. Besides, they didn't even say "Light Spinner" right— she replied, laughing slightly at the end.

—You have nothing to apologize for— the Queen Mother assured her. —It was a bit shocking, but they meant no disrespect, I'm sure— she added.

—Yeah. And it's certainly better than their nickname for your husband— Catra chuckled.

—Which would be?

—"Magic Grandpa"— she snickered.

Angella laughed daintily and shook her head, amused.

—Really!?

—Oh, and Bow's fathers are "Arrow Grandpa" and "Heart Grandpa", Lance and George respectively, which is a bit ironic because, as far as we know, George is the one who used to be an archer— Catra told her. —But I guess the nicknames come from how they call Bow "Arrow Boy" like me— she further explained.

—I see— Angella laughed. Then, something occurred to her, and she asked —Can I tell you something?

—Sure.

—I know little about the subject, and Glimmer has told me she's changed a lot, but… I didn't expect you to be so comfortable letting Finn around Shadow Weaver— she pointed out.

—Well, yeah, that's… a long story.

—You don't have to share if you don't want to.

—It's fine— Catra assured her. —Truth is… I didn't even dare tell the woman about Finn for, what? Three years? I think…

—Oh.

—But, what I didn't know, was that she already knew about them. In fact, Finn began talking about this "Ghost Lady" before I went to tell her so, yeah…

—How?

—It's difficult to explain but, at the time, Shadow Weaver wasn't really summoned like now, or like she initially was. She could only show up on the surface at a magical groove in the Whispering Woods. Somehow, she also appeared at home, but invisible to everyone except Finn— she managed to explain.

—I suppose the technicalities aren't important— Angella sighed, not even starting to comprehend. —But I imagine you didn't exactly like that…

—Not at all. Specially since she told us she had been "helping", by which she meant making Finn cry to call our attention whenever they needed something— she scoffed, shaking her head. —I mean, yeah, when Finn tried to munch on some wires, it *was okay* to scare them, I guess; they never tried again. But I still don't exactly like the idea of her scaring Finn… At all.

—And yet you allow them to be around her.

—Well, they grew fond of her, you know? And she hasn't done that since Finn grew older; I think— she replied. —Thing is, they really like her for some reason; I was scared of them being traumatized like me, but it's the opposite really…

—That sounds good then…

—I guess, yes— Catra agreed, smiling faintly. —Sorry to keep you, your Majesty.

—You can call me "Angella", you know?

—Angella, then— she nodded. —Thank you.

—Of course, Catra.

The Queen Mother watched as she left to join her friends in supervising their children, and let out a deep breath. She was ready to join her family too, yet someone interrupted the gathering.

—Head Sorceress!

An acolyte arrived running, followed by a pair of guards who saluted Angella with a respectful bow, and only stopped to catch his breath in front of Castaspella.

—What's going on?

—I am… sorry… to interrupt…— he began, still out of breath.

—Calm down, breathe, and then speak.

The acolyte did as told, inhaled deeply, and only then could he explain —I'm so sorry to interrupt, but we need your help now.

—Unless someone's life is on the line, I don't see why you had to interrupt her family reunion today— Shadow Weaver complained. —Is the concept of a day off so foreign to you?

—We know, but… it *is* urgent. He told us not to bother you, his life isn't exactly in danger, yet… his condition is quite bad— the acolyte explained.

—"He"? Who?

—Councilman Nolrem.

—What happened to him!?— she asked, immediately standing up, along with Shadow Weaver.

—We don't know how, but he fell and broke his hip; he's being tended to by a healer and has been assigned a nurse— he further explained. —For the time being, he will remain bedridden — he concluded.

—Oh, my… I-I'm so sorry, I have to return, then…— Castaspella apologized.

—Wait. Believe it or not, I am just as worried as you are, but he's receiving attention already. He probably needs rest before he can speak to anyone; why don't you stay?— Shadow Weaver told her. —If so you want, I can always go check on him and tell you how he looks… But again, going back to Mystacor to see how he's doing is pointless now. You wouldn't be allowed into his room.

—I… know…— she replied, looking down. —Though, please. Go to see him, then. I want to be sure he has everything he requires.

—Alright— the woman sighed. —I'll be right back.

Shadow Weaver arrived at Mystacor fully prepared to find the man in bed, being tended to by some nurse, possibly downplaying his pain; she'd mock him a bit, hide that she's just as concerned as Castaspella, interrogate the old man about his surely-silly fall…

But he wasn't conscious at all.

And what's more, she could recognize the nurse tending to him.

Nolrem had to be worse than she expected…

—Who's there?— the nurse asked, approaching the entrance. —He's in no condition to receive anyone— he insisted, finding the door to close it.

—Relax, I was just sent to check on him— Shadow Weaver replied, smirking.

—Ah… It's you. No wonder I heard nothing— he let out, sneering slightly. —I do not care if the Head Sorceress herself sent you, my patient needs rest.

—I am aware… Just give me a brief overview of his state, so I can reassure her— the woman requested.

—The healers have done everything necessary, his fractured hip is back in place and set to heal soon. Give him time and space to recover— the nurse sighed.

—Much appreciated.

—Sure…

Shadow Weaver smirked as she walked away, amused by his attitude, and heard the door close soon enough. She didn't have bad news, at least, but it was evident that "time and space to recover" wouldn't be enough for Nolrem…

It would be about a week since the incident before Castaspella was allowed to visit her councilman.

—I apologize for taking so long to visit— she began.

—No need, Head Sorceress— Nolrem replied, his voice a bit strained. —I woke up yesterday.

—Spin says you have the most dedicated nurse and… that it means your state isn't the best.

—Ah, yes… I have quite a diligent nurse, indeed. His reputation may be what gives that impression, I suppose. But I don't feel as if I required this much care— he replied.

—You did spend many days unconscious after the fall.

—For my own good, I would say— he laughed slightly. —I hope you haven't halted all council activities, right?

—We haven't had much to discuss anyways, worry not— Castaspella assured him, smiling faintly.

—Excuse me— the nurse suddenly interrupted, irked. —Is her presence here completely necessary?— he asked, gesturing in Shadow Weaver's general direction.

—I mean… Wha-what are you doing, Spin?

—Why, I'm only here catching up with a friend— she replied, smirking teasingly as she walked past the nurse.

—I am *not* your friend— he immediately clarified, turning around to return to his work.

—Sure, Zack.

—And *stop* calling me that!— he added.

—How do *you* know his name? I haven't managed to get it since I woke up— Nolrem immediately asked.

—You call him that once and, just like magic, you'll get his real name, I promise— she replied.

—And how do you know him?— Castaspella asked too.

—He doesn't remember me, but I remember him from before the corruption. He must be about our age, perhaps a bit younger. The thing is, I was there when he first put on that blindfold. There aren't that many prodigies on this island, much less blind ones— she revealed. —But he's a special case in more than one way— she added. —The moment I saw him here, I knew the true severity of your case.

—I will be fine.

—Or not.

—Spin…

—Just don't get your hopes up. He's a great nurse, but having him tending to you only means you will *not* walk out of this room any time soon.

—You just *have* to, don't you!?— Castaspella complained.

A few steps away, the nurse was paying attention to their conversation, and he knew exactly what she meant. Unfortunately, she wasn't wrong… But he couldn't say that.

—Well, I am afraid to say that visit hours should end— he claimed instead, without turning around. —My patient needs to rest.

—I have rested quite enough…

—I cannot be fooled by a tough attitude, Councilman. Your magical energy is telling me otherwise— he insisted.

—I think it's better if we leave, he's right— Castaspella smiled. —I'll visit you again soon— she promised.

—Heard that? We'll be back soon, Zack— Shadow Weaver mocked him.

—I will no longer answer to you if you keep calling me that— he finally decided.

—Alright. Enough, let's go— the Head Sorceress ordered, dragging the woman out of the room.

—Excuse me— Nolrem called. —If your name isn't "Zack", what should I call you?

—You will receive assistance whenever you require. There's no need to know my name, Councilman.

—You can call me “Nolrem”, you know?

—That wouldn’t be respectful— he quickly countered.

—Well, having to call you by a different name isn’t either, but you’re leaving me no choice, *Zack*.

—“Zacharias”— he finally let out, resigned. —I do not know why she insists on calling me that but, please, do not follow her example, Councilman— he pleaded, keeping his attention on a few vials he was handling.

—A beautiful name— Nolrem commented, causing him to almost drop a flask. —Just ignore her. She can be even worse and, if your reaction amuses her, she’ll just continue with that attitude.

—I did not expect you to be so… familiar with her— Zacharias pointed out, turning around as he approached with a full syringe.

—I- We used to be friends… best friends, in fact. Before her graduation, of course. Then, we drifted apart, then she… betrayed us. Now she’s back— he explained. —She’s complicated, but I guess she’s no longer that bad— he laughed slightly, never noticing the injection on his hip. —I can’t blame you for disliking her, of course. But it will be better for you to ignore her.

—I do. I still don’t understand why she insistently addresses me, however— he replied.

—Well, there aren’t that many known faces for her here anymore.

—I don’t understand that either. Why- How would she know me?

—She said it herself…

—I am no prodigy— Zacharias quickly denied, returning to the table with the vials.

—Trust me. She has an eye for prodigies. If she noticed you, then you most certainly are— Nolrem insisted. —Her attention may be unwanted, and she won’t stop being a thorn in your side any time soon, but the *fact* that she notices you and even knows your name, sort of, is a form of praise from her— he laughed.

With everything organized, the nurse rested his hands on the table and sighed —Then I don’t want it. I am just some lucky boy who got a chance here long ago.

—Here in Mystacor, *luck* hardly gives us anything.

—That much is true— he admitted. Then, he suddenly straightened up and turned to face Nolrem as he said —Well now, please allow me to turn off the lights and rest, Councilman.

Before anyone noticed, a whole month went by.

The attention was mostly on Councilman Nolrem as he didn't seem to get any better. Hence, that day, the Head Sorceress, Councillor Arden, Shadow Weaver, Delwyn, and Queen Glimmer had all gathered in his room to check on him.

—So you've been unable to stand at all?— Castaspella asked, concerned.

—Yes, unfortunately.

—Maybe it is still too soon, Old Pal— Arden commented.

—Perhaps…

—I still think the fact that Zack is your nurse speaks volumes about how bad your condition is, Inny…— Shadow Weaver insisted.

—*Not helping*— Glimmer reproached her. —If he is as good as you say, shouldn't it mean he will recover just fine?

—It only means his quality of life will be good *despite* his condition being, most likely, irreversible.

—Well, even if he can't stand, there are ways for him to still move around. I reckon you also have wheelchairs here?— Delwyn asked.

—Is that something you have in Ak'kelon?— Glimmer asked back.

—It's a device that allows movement without using your legs, like a chair with wheels, from which the name comes.

—Oh! A mobility chair!— the Queen realized. —I believe here in Mystacor they use hoovering seats, though. Right, Auntie?

—Yes. But I don't think we have any available…

—We can lend you some from Bright Moon's medical bay. A regular one, I mean— she offered. —And I can ask Bow and Entrapta to help make a hoovering one that works with sorcery if he still requires it!

—You don't need to do that, your Majesty— Nolrem replied. —At least, not for now. A regular mobility chair should suffice.

—Alright, then I'll order for one to be brought as soon as possible.

—Much appreciated— he thanked her.

—Speaking of medical bay, I still can't believe the one Mystacor had has been closed— Shadow Weaver commented.

—I've told you already: people prefer being in their rooms instead of there, and the medical bay was seldom used; we had to repurpose it as a storeroom for medical supplies only, so it's

not that far off either— Castaspella replied.

—It's ridiculous! Even the Horde had a medical bay!— the woman insisted, outraged.

—Really?— Glimmer reacted.

—Yes, really— she sneered.

—Can you calm down? Why do you always get so worked up when this subject is brought up?— the Head Sorceress asked.

—What is going on in here!?— a sudden voice asked from the door, before Shadow Weaver could reply. —I'm getting overwhelmed with so many magical firms…— Zacharias complained. —This is too many people, and my patient requires a calm environment to recover.

—Oh, so sorry— Castaspella apologized. —We didn't mean to visit him at the same time, it was a coincidence— she explained.

—Well, I'll have to ask you to leave, please. I need to work— he insisted.

—Alright, see you soon— Arden smiled, before heading outside.

—Thank you all for the visit. And for the suggestion of using a mobility chair— Nolrem smiled.

—Gladly— Delwyn replied, smiling back before walking away too.

—I'll have it brought soon— Glimmer assured him again.

—Oh, that would be very useful; I just went to for one and found there are none available— Zacharias sighed, relieved.

—Before we leave, can we get a prognosis, maybe?— Shadow Weaver requested.

The nurse sighed and replied —Of course. But only if my patient agrees.

—I do— Nolrem nodded when he looked back at him.

—Then, please— Zacharias asked, gesturing in the door's general direction.

The Queen, Castaspella, and Shadow Weaver exited the room, followed by the nurse, whom they saw feel the wall with his hand to reach the entrance safely.

Once the door was closed, the four gathered a few steps away and the Head Sorceress said — It *is* bad, isn't it?

—I would like to think he can still recover well, but what I think isn't relevant. His current state indicates the opposite, as he's healing very slowly and hasn't recovered sensitivity under the waist…

—I told you— Shadow Weaver sighed, shaking her head. —And it's to be expected of someone his age— she pointed out.

—Well, yes, his age may affect— Zacharias admitted, albeit a bit annoyed. —I can only say we must wait. The healer will know better, but the next revision is in a month— he clarified.

—Alright, thank you— Castaspella sighed. —We'll leave now and let you work.

—You're welcome— he replied, and returned to the room.

—I'm so sorry, Auntie— Glimmer let out.

—Well, if he is as good as Spin claims, despite the outcome I believe he'll be fine. Right?

—Of course. Nolrem is getting the best treatment possible.

—Are you… okay, Shadow Weaver?— the Queen asked, surprised hearing her reassuring Castaspella in such an unusually gentle and supporting manner.

—Careful what you will say, your Majesty— the woman warned her.

—I just never expected to hear something like that from *you*.

—And you may never hear it again— she replied, her tone almost threatening.

—Alright, that's enough— Castaspella interrupted. —Thank you, Spin. And, please, Glimmer, don't go speaking about this.

—She's afraid I will revert to being condescending to her— Shadow Weaver commented, smirking and folding her arms.

—Bitch…

—I have no reasons to talk about this, I swear. And I wasn't trying to mock her, I was really surprised— she told her aunt. —But, even if word got out, if people called you "soft" or something, don't let that change you back to the old Shadow Weaver; don't let *them* decide how you behave— the Queen pleaded, addressing the woman.

—I can't make promises…

—Right— Glimmer sighed. —I have to go back now, and get that mobility chair delivered here. I'll see you another time, Auntie.

—Of course. And thank you— she replied with a smile.

As Zacharias said, a month went by before the healer's new assessment.

In the meantime, the councilman went back to participating in council meetings and finally started leaving his room for a while a day, usually taken around by the nurse on the mobility

chair when he was free.

For weeks, he had been attempting to stand up, always with help, but his legs remained numb; he had no stability at all. He just couldn't stand up, even when supporting himself on a wall.

Hence, when the healer and Zacharias exited the room and addressed the visitors, it was no surprise hearing that Nolrem would *not* recover his legs despite their best efforts.

—Congratulations, you were *right*. Must be glad…— the nurse reproached Shadow Weaver.

—Believe it or not, Zack, I *hate* being right this time— she retorted.

—Please, don't start.

—Can we… go in to see him?— Glimmer asked.

—Certainly, your Majesty. Just, not all at the same time, please.

—How many at a time?

—You're six, right?— he asked.

—Yes.

—Then three at a time should be fine— the nurse decided.

—Who wants to go first?— the Queen asked.

—Please, you three go first— the foreman-councilman suggested, referring to Castaspella, Shadow Weaver, and Glimmer.

—Thank you, Geldirik— the Head Sorceress replied.

Meanwhile, the nurse decided to stay outside with Delwyn and the councillors.

—We really appreciate your help, Zacharias— Arden told him.

—Indeed. We know you're quite busy with other patients, so we thank you for your time.

—It's my job— he replied. —I have to go now, but as soon as they are out, you can visit him.

—Good afternoon, Councilman— the Queen said.

—Afternoon, your Majesty— he replied, nodding slightly.

—How do you feel?— Castaspella asked, her expression sorrowful.

—Physically? As well as I can be, despite not feeling my legs yet— he replied. —Emotionally, I would… need some time to recover, I believe— he lamented.

—You already know— Shadow Weaver realized.

—I only guessed from the healer's expression…

—You won't… be able to use your legs anymore— the Head Sorceress apologetically confirmed.

He sighed deeply and looked away.

—I suppose I will need that hoovering seat after all— he let out.

—I'll ask Bow to make it as soon as I'm back— Glimmer promised.

—I don't know how I'll ever repay you, your Majesty.

—You don't have to— she assured him. —We're talking about your quality of life, and I rather help make it as comfortable as possible.

—I… appreciate it.

—Worry not, Inny. I'll still respect you even if you're no longer as tall as me— Shadow Weaver mocked him, smirking.

Castaspella was about to tell her off, yet stopped herself upon hearing Nolrem laugh wholeheartedly.

The woman chuckled briefly too, while the Head Sorceress and her niece remained speechless.

—Thank you— he sighed.

—Alright, I believe we should leave. You have more visitors— Glimmer said.

—Don't tell me Zacharias had you enter in small groups…

—Yes, he did— Castaspella nodded, resigned.

—Alright, I can't exactly argue with him… He's only looking out for me, after all.

—Precisely.

—Well then, let's go— the Queen insisted. —I'll make sure to deliver the hoovering chair as soon as it's done.

—Goodbye, Inny— Shadow Weaver farewelled.

—We'll see you soon— the Head Sorceress promised.

—I'll be glad— he replied.

It took them about a week, but the hoovering seat was finally crafted, with a comfortable cushion, armrests, and a magical seal that could be activated with sorcery. It floated up to a meter above ground, casting a faint golden light as it carried the councilman around. With a little help from Entrapta, Bow delivered the hoovering chair and promised to fine-tune it once Nolrem had gotten accustomed to it.

With assistance from his nurse, as well as Shadow Weaver, he managed to activate it and hesitantly use it. The woman would give him recommendations to better balance the magical energy output, so the seal wouldn't be underloaded nor overloaded, and so the councilman would, little by little, move larger distances, always under Zacharias attentive gaze.

By the second week, Shadow Weaver had asked anyone with hoovering seats on Mystacor what they could recommend to someone who just began using one, and then brought all those recommendations to Nolrem.

However, even when his navigation around Mystacor got better, the continuous use of sorcery started draining the councilman to the point he sometimes fell asleep on the corridors, making the seat little by little lower to the ground. At least once, Zacharias had found him like that and had to wake him up to help him back.

Hence, Councillor Arden offered him some tips on magical energy efficiency, and mentioned he can also get help from other sorcerers. Magical energy sharing was rarely used, but in his case, it would come in handy. As soon as Zacharias learnt about it, he didn't hesitate to offer help with that too, assuring him he'd rather make sure Nolrem won't exhaust himself traveling around all day.

And so, within a month, the councilman finally got accustomed to his new hovering seat. Being informed of all the little issues he had, Castaspella decided to speak with Bow to discuss the improvements he promised to make.

As she arrived at Bright Moon's palace, she came across Delwyn, who happened to be returning from a meeting with the Queen.

—Fancy finding you here— she greeted him.

—I wasn't expecting to see you here today— he replied, surprised.

—Well, Councilman Nolrem has finally gotten used to the hovering chair and now requires a few adjustments for it to be more comfortable…

—So you came to see the King.

—Exactly.

—May I accompany you? I could provide a few pointers based on our wheelchairs from Ak'kelon.

—That would be wonderful— she accepted, thankful.

They both quickly made their way to Bow's workshop and found him tinkering with his trackpad.

—Oh, welcome!— he greeted them, smiling. —What can I do for you?

—Sorry to bother you, Bow, but it's about Nolrem's hoovering seat— the sorceress explained.

—You don't bother me, don't worry, Casta. And I was hoping he'd be used to it by now— he admitted. —As we made it following generic blueprints, I imagined he'd require some adjustments eventually.

—Oh, it's just details. He found the seat pretty comfortable— she assured him. —He only has some issues controlling the height, finds the direction too stiff, and has a few issues with stairs that others don't seem to have.

—Ah, yeah. We didn't want to make the direction too sensitive so it wouldn't make him dizzy or anything, but that's easy to adjust— he began, thinking aloud. —The height is more tricky, but I can ask Entrapta if she has any ideas. And for the stairs, I'd probably need to take a look at the other hoovering chairs to see how those handle them— he went on. —But I was more concerned about the sorcery integration. Does it work fine?

—Quite, yes. He has no problems powering the seal.

—I understand he finds it pretty consuming, though— Delwyn commented.

—Well, yes. One isn't meant to use sorcery for such long periods, but with Arden's pointers and the help from Zacharias, he's handling that.

—We could still add something for him to rest if he gets too tired— Bow suggested.

—May I recommend something, your Majesty?— Delwyn asked.

—Of course!

—In Ak'kelon, we don't have such sorcery, so our wheelchairs are more like your mobility chairs, with wheels, which have similar issues with direction sometimes, but ultimately can be handled with the assistance of technology— he explained. —In this case, hoovering chairs require constant powering of the seal to keep it floating even when he's standing in place, meaning he has no rest as long as he's in the chair— he went on. —So, what about some retractable legs like those of a normal chair?

—That's… a good idea. I think it can be implemented, yes.

—And, on the other hand, our wheelchairs are powered by batteries that have about fourteen hours of autonomy. If it were possible to use some technology capable of storing magical energy, that could also help the Councilman when he gets tired, right? Perhaps not something to last for hours, but enough to let him reach his room without having to push himself beyond his limit.

—Oh, of course! If we use some First Ones tech, it would be possible…

—Excuse me…— a voice suddenly interrupted.

They all turned to look at the door as the Queen Mother walked in.

—Oh, Angella— Castaspella noticed. —Sorry, were you looking for Bow? I believe we're done here…

—Actually, I was just passing by and overheard a little— she admitted. —How is the councilman?

—He's… doing much better. In spite of everything.

—I see— she nodded. —And, has the special mobility chair helped him? Glimmer has been a bit worried about that.

—Oh, of course— Castaspella replied. —We were just discussing some enhancements for it now that he's more comfortable with it.

—I'll tell Glimmer more about it later— Bow assured her. —But, if you see her, please tell her I went to Dryl— he requested, turning to pick up a few things. —I'll return before dinner.

—Oh, of course— she accepted.

As the King walked away, the three of them were left alone in his now-quiet workshop.

—Well, I… suppose it's time to get back— the Head Sorceress decided to say, breaking the silence.

—Mind if I accompany you? I've been meaning to visit him since I saw Glimmer so worried…

—Oh, really!?— Castaspella let out, surprised.

—I'm sure he'll be glad…— Delwyn chimed in.

—A-alright, then. Let's get going.

As they walked through the corridors of Mystacor, the Queen Mother was suddenly curious and asked them —You two seem to be very good friends. How did an Ambassador of another planet meet the Head Sorceress of Mystacor?

—Ah… that's… an unfunny story— Castaspella replied, tense.

—Well, yes. It wasn't the best of introductions, but fortunately, we managed to sort it out— Delwyn assured her.

—Can I ask what happened?

—*Your husband* set us up— the sorceress uttered, trying to sound less annoyed than she was.

—Set you up?

—At a Guild Dance. We made a deal, and he challenged me to convince her to dance with me the special choreography they learn for the Dances, which I had learnt out of respect after being invited by the Queen— Delwyn began. —It was… a very awkward situation, I still feel ashamed, but…

—But the outcome wasn't that bad, after all— Castaspella interrupted, with a sigh. —It wasn't Micah's brightest plan, but he did help in some way, I guess. Delwyn provided me with a lot of information I required; the assistance I could no longer get from Spin, I would get from him.

—Oh, I see…

—We're here— the Head Sorceress said, before knocking on the door.

Zacharias promptly opened, seemingly about to complain, yet stopped himself when he felt the Queen Mother.

—Qu-Queen Angella— he stammered. —I-I'm sorry, but the Councilman needs rest… I…

—I can see her for a few minutes, Zacharias— Nolrem said from inside.

—Ah…— he sighed. —Alright. Just a few minutes— the nurse conceded, letting Angella inside.

Chapter End Notes

And you may wonder: "Why does Zacharias wear a blindfold? Just because he's blind?" But, uh, you do not want to know why he's blind… it's not nice. What I can tell you is that he wasn't blind when he was born; his family was, however, and that *is* related to why he's now blind… but I rather not say it… unless u really wanna know, in which case, drop me a comment, I guess <("^_^)

Anyways!! That's all for today! What do you think!?
I hope you liked the chapter! Thanks for reading, and see you next week!!

The Question of Mortality

Chapter Summary

Time keeps flying by, and soon it's time for another Guild Dance, which will turn out to be… eventful, from a few days prior, and until the very night of the Dance.
» Like every year, everything was just *perfect*, fortunately. And, despite this being the second Dance to which Angella attended since being brought back, the guests' excitement over her presence was just as great as the first time.
» However, that wasn't the only event repeating from past years…
» —Oh, damn it!
» —Well, well… Look who's coming for another round…
» —If it isn't the most controversial couple in Etheria (…)

Chapter Notes

Welcome back! This chapter is shorter again, more… reasonable in length, but I hope you enjoy it.

We have mostly shenanigans in this chapter, surrounding *one* important event. It'll probably make u laugh/cry cause it's just so ironic TT-TT

Anyways!
I don't know if there was anything else I wanted to say…
So I hope u enjoy it, and get ready for the finale next week. XD

~~I am not ready~~

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Months went by, Councilman Nolrem returned to his normal activities, for the most part, and his hoovering chair got enhanced so that he could move around with more ease. However, his nurse continued working to help him.

As a council meeting ended, Arden walked out next to Nolrem, following his chair's pace, and stopped with him just a few meters away from the door.

—So… you will wait for him here?— Arden asked, curious.

—He asked me to do so, yes— the councilman nodded, extending the retractable legs of his seat to rest for a bit.

—Didn't you say you could move around on your own already?

Their look made Nolrem think there was more to the question, but he still answered plainly —I can, but if he insists on assisting me, I don't see why I shouldn't welcome the help.

—Aha… just that…

—What do you mean, Arden? Speak clearly.

—It sounds more like you two *enjoy* each other's company— they commented, knowingly.

—Don't be ridiculous…— Nolrem dismissed them, gesturing with a hand. —Why would Zacharias have any interest in me? I'm just a patient.

—You are *the* patient he pays more attention to, the one he's always helping in his free time, and…

—And he won't even pronounce my name— the councilman pointed out, annoyed.

—That upsets you, doesn't it, Old Pal?

—What are you trying to say?— Nolrem asked once more.

—Isn't there just a *tiny* chance that maybe you're…

—Don't say it…

—Interested in him?

—Not you too, Arden!— he exclaimed.

—Someone else mentioned it?

—Ambassador Zhaleh may have… made a reference to it— he began. —While Light- Eh, Shadow Weaver has been completely unbearable about it.

—Don't you think that's because we're all seeing *something* there!?

—Ridiculous— he insisted.

With a sigh, the councillor pressed on —Just be honest with me. How do *you* feel?

—That's irrelevant. Like I said, I am just another patient Zacharias has to take care of.

—But regardless of that! Are *you* interested in him, maybe?

—Arden…

—Just tell me!

—Good afternoon— a voice interjected. It was the nurse. —Am I interrupting?

—Of course not.

—I was just… asking Nolrem who he would invite to the Guild Dance— Arden mischievously lied.

—Alone. I will go *alone*, like every year.

—A-ah… Of course— Zacharias stammered, fidgeting with his hands. —If you prefer, I can return later…

—Of course not. I wouldn't want to delay you— the councillor immediately replied. —See you, Old Pal.

—I… apologize for that— Nolrem sighed, activating his hoovering seat again and pulling back the retractable legs.

—There's nothing to apologize for, Councilman.

—*Nolrem*— he insisted.

—That would be disrespectful.

—Right…— he sighed, resigned. For a few minutes that felt eternal, they continued on their way to the councilman's room in silence, until he couldn't bear it anymore. —So… About the Guild Dance. Are you, um, looking forward to it?

—I don't… attend the Guild Dances. Ever— he admitted.

—Why would that be?

—They aren't for people like me— he denied. —Too many attendees, gets overwhelming. And… who would like to dance with a visually impaired sorcerer…

—You can't be serious… Why wouldn't…

—Please, don't worry, Councilman. I don't care about the Guild Dance, in any case. But, whether you go alone or accompanied, I hope you enjoy it— Zacharias interrupted him, opening the door to the room.

—Listen… being blind doesn't mean you can't dance. Even I, with some imagination, can still do something akin to dancing— Nolrem began, smiling faintly. —So, perhaps, give it a chance. If you get overwhelmed, then, of course, you don't have to stay. But, try to go to the Dance next month— he concluded.

—I… shall see. Thank you, Councilman.

—Of course. Thank you for walking me here.

—Just my job— he replied. —Good evening.

The month quickly passed, and the Guild Dance would be in just five days. As always, Castaspella was in charge of organizing it, and kept running up and down, sometimes even staying awake the whole night planning things. That evening, Shadow Weaver found herself gravitating towards the sealed chamber once more…

She was just thinking, or rather, agonizing, about the fact that, in the current year, Castaspella would be turning the age she herself was when she died. It made her think about a rather simple fact she had been avoiding the past few months: at some point, eventually, *inevitably*, Castaspella would *die*.

She would be alone again.

—But what if I… No. No… Or… Perhaps…— she was muttering, while pacing in front of the door, when she noticed something. —This can't be— she sighed, realizing there was, in fact, a gap between the seals, wide enough for a person to go through. —Should I take it as a sign?— she wondered, letting out a scoff as she tentatively tried and succeeded in getting into the chamber. —I have to… do it…

—No, you won't!

Illusion magic suddenly pushed the woman out of the chamber, away from the contained parasitic energy, and made her almost go through the wall in front of the entrance to the room.

—Mi-Micah!— she realized. —I wasn't…

—Don't try to lie to me! I *know* what you were doing!

—I was not! I swear!

—Oh, really!? You were *not* trying to take the power!? You were *not* trying to use it to revive!?

—I was *not*!— she angrily insisted, closing her hands in tight fists and towering over him. —I was only…

—What's going on here!?— the Queen asked, arriving with her husband and her friends. —Dad, why did you come here in such a rush!?

—I have spells that warn me if someone *like her* enters the chamber!

—Shadow Weaver? What's going on?— Adora asked too.

—You weren't trying to… take the power, were you?— Bow dared say.

—She was…

—I was *not*!

—Then *what* were you doing?— Catra insisted, suspicious. —Just explain yourself or we'll have to go get the Head Sorceress.

—No! Listen… ugh…— she reacted, deflating little by little. —I wasn't trying to take the power of the parasite. I am just…

—Just *what*!?

—Dad, wait…

—I am… *scared* of losing her— she admitted, gritting her teeth. —But if you tell anybody…

—We will not— Bow calmed her down. —Though, I don't understand. What were you doing *here* then?

—*Oh*… You *absolute* monster!— Micah reacted, as soon as he realized. —I *know* what you planned to do! And I am *absolutely* not allowing it! I don't care how much you love her, it *will not happen*!

—Dad, what do you mean!?

—She wants to attach Casta's soul to that *thing*!

—What!?

—Wait, wait, hold on— Catra stopped them. —Is that true!?

Shadow Weaver looked away, having the decency to look ashamed at least, and nodded.

—One day, when she dies, the summoning spell bound to her heart will dispel, and I'll… be alone again— she sighed.

—Wait, what!?

—I don't understand… You… want to *corrupt* the Head Sorceress?

—No, no! Not… not corrupt like it happened to me…— she denied, upon being interrogated by Adora. —You can be corrupted without getting attached to that thing, and you can get attached to that thing with a minimum level of corruption that is… completely reversible, I swear.

—Don't swear anything! Don't make promises! This is not a game, Shadow Weaver! I am *in no way* letting you do this!— Micah exploded.

—Alright, calm down, Dad— Glimmer immediately interceded.

—Look, we… understand your point— Catra began, letting out a sigh. —But we also understand *his*… So, I'm sorry, but you shouldn't be doing this— she sentenced. —Not without her consent.

—No, no! Even with her consent! I am not letting you or anyone do that to my sister!— the King Father insisted.

—I think that's enough, Dad. They understand.

—Look— Catra addressed him. —You may not like it, but there's a chance Castaspella would agree to this, *if Shadow Weaver spoke to her first*— she pointed out, reproaching the woman too. —And if that were the case, neither you nor anyone would have the power to keep her from doing it.

—Exactly. We agree that she shouldn't be doing this on her own, without Castaspella knowing until it's too late… But… what if she *wanted* to do it!?— Adora asked him.

—Want *that*!? Hah! As soon as she learns about it, it'll be over. You can't expect her to trust you anymore after *this*!

—Enough!— Glimmer exclaimed. —I am *sure* she will speak with Auntie about this if she still wants to do it, and that is *not* something you can interfere with. And I am *absolutely sure*, Dad, that you won't cross the line and go exposing her, neither with Auntie nor with the council. Am I right!?

—Yes, your Majesty. Just, please, let me be the one who tells her— Shadow Weaver let out, bowing slightly.

—Of course. Dad!?

—Fine…— Micah had to agree.

—Good! We should all go to sleep now— Bow said, a bit more cheery.

—Right! I'm sure Auntie is still making her rounds… so why don't you get her and convince her to sleep?

—Yes, that- I should do that— Shadow Weaver sighed.

—Good night— Adora farewelled.

The woman replied with a light nod and walked away.

As promised, she went to find Castaspella, who was discussing with a few providers.

—If you can get everything here within three days, it would be ideal— she was telling them.

—Of course…

—Sure. We'll get that done.

—I believe we can have them by tomorrow.

Each provider answered in turn, referring to their own goods, and bowed slightly before leaving.

—Don't you think it's a bit late to be in a meeting with providers?— Shadow Weaver asked from behind her, startling her a bit.

—Oh, Bea… You scared me— Castaspella sighed.

—I don't suppose this is an under-the-table deal, is it?

—No, no. It's just that these people have very busy days— she explained, amused. —They could only meet me now.

—Well, meeting's over. I believe it's time for you to go to sleep already— the woman exhorted her.

—Alright, alright— she sighed. —You didn't have to come for me, though.

—It seems I did…

—No, really! I… Is everything alright?

—If you're reading my feelings again…

—No, just your expression— Castaspella assured her.

Shadow Weaver hesitated for a moment, considering whether to tell her now or not, but Micah's words lingered in her mind and she decided against it.

"As soon as she learns about it, it'll be over. You can't expect her to trust you anymore after *this*!"

She couldn't lose her like that now…

—Everything is fine, no need to worry.

With that, she placed a hand on the sorceress' back and gently pushed her towards the exit.

The day of the Guild Dance finally arrived.

Like every year, everything was just *perfect*, fortunately. And, despite this being the second Dance to which Angella attended since being brought back, the guests' excitement over her presence was just as great as the first time.

However, that wasn't the only event repeating from past years…

—Oh, damn it!— the Head Sorceress sighed.

—Well, well… Look who's coming for another round…— Shadow Weaver let out, smirking.

—If it isn't the most controversial couple in Etheria— the theatre manager began. —Still together, I see… I hoped you had seen reason already, Head Sorceress.

—Will you do this *every Dance*!? This is the fourth year you do this!

—One would think *you* had seen reason by now— the woman spat, condescending but noticeably annoyed by the manager.

—Very funny…

—Look, I do *not* care what you think and, at this point, I'm beyond caring about your feelings. *Go away*!

—I see her worst traits are rubbing off onto you…— the theatre manager commented, rolling her eyes.

—You want to see my worst traits?— Shadow Weaver asked, threateningly. —Why don't I tell you what she did *every time* you pestered her while I wasn't here?

—No, no. That's not going to happen— Castaspella stopped her. —Just leave us alone, alright? Stop pushing me— she told the obnoxious manager.

—You're making a mistake.

—You have said so *every year*, and I still care as little as the first time— the Head Sorceress rebuked. —Leave or I'll make you.

—I'd like to see you try— she defied her.

—As you wish— she smugly replied, before turning to look at Shadow Weaver. —Do you mind?

The woman sighed, understanding what she meant, but, finding it pretty smart of her, she accepted —Go ahead.

Castaspella smirked and pulled the woman into a passionate kiss that lasted enough to make the theatre manager uncomfortable. Disgusted, she turned and stalked away, ignoring how nearby guests snickered and cheered.

Once the Head Sorceress let go of Shadow Weaver, she hummed and let out —Thank you very much…

—No need. I quite liked it… despite the unwanted attention…— she replied, trying not to look around.

—Sorry for that— Castaspella giggled. —I- Would you like- What am I saying? I almost offered you food… Erm, I'll…

—I'll get some for you, just sit down and relax a bit— the woman interrupted, realizing she was getting increasingly nervous.

Meanwhile, Councilman Nolrem was just arriving at the Main Hall, assisted by Zacharias, who had been sharing some of his magical energy with him. As the nurse bowed respectfully and aimed to leave, the councilman stopped him.

—Wait— he called, making him turn back to face him. —I know you said this many people are… overwhelming for you. But…— he began, and hesitated a bit. However, he noticed Councillor Arden looking his way and gesturing encouragingly, so he dared finish —If you don't mind, I would like it if you stayed, at least for a while.

—Re-really?

—Absolutely.

—I-I suppose— Zacharias stammered. —Where would you like to settle?

—Near a balcony would be fine— Nolrem replied, unsure of whether the nurse had any way to notice him smiling, and hoping he couldn't.

—Alright, sure— he accepted, fidgeting with his hands again as he realized a part of him hoped the councilman's decision to settle far from the crowd was somehow related to him. Once they reached the farthest table, set right next to the open gateway to a balcony, the nurse breathed out, relieved. —Should I bring you something to eat? I may not be able to see the food, but I can always ask the acolytes in charge of the food table for whatever you'd like— Zacharias offered, overexplaining.

—I am well aware you're capable, don't worry— Nolrem replied with a chuckle. —Anything will be fine; if you have any preferences, I'll go with whatever you want…

—Oh, that's- A-are you sure, Councilman?

He didn't even *try* to correct him this time.

—I'm sure— he sighed.

—I reckon you have told him too?— Shadow Weaver asked Delwyn, as they eyed Nolrem and Zacharias from the other side of the room.

—I did. And so has Councillor Arden.

—No wonder he dared bring Zack to the Dance, then— she smirked.

—Does Castaspella know?

—I don't think so, yet…

—Where is she?

—She went to speak with the Queen Mother— the woman explained. —At some point, she'll see them, I suppose.

—Or, you could tell her— Delwyn proposed.

—Why should I? Pestering Inny about this was already enough… I am not that interested in things related to love— she reminded him.

—Then why did you bother with them?

—Because his obliviousness was *baffling*— she groaned, making the ambassador laugh daintily.

Just as Shadow Weaver said, the Head Sorceress had gone to speak with Angella after she asked her for a minute.

—It's nothing urgent, but I suppose you might know— the Queen Mother began. —Micah has been a bit off lately, seemingly sad. Not depressed, but he's looking gloomy since a friend of his rejected the invitation to the Guild Dance— she explained. —I don't think I know this friend, or what could have happened… Do you have any idea?

Oh, did she?

Unfortunately, of course she did…

—Well, you see… A few years ago, almost a year before you were brought back, Micah managed to find this friend; some strategist from the Rebellion who was captured by the Horde too and shared some time in prison with him— Castaspella began. —Apparently, they promised that, if they managed to escape, they would come here to Mystacor to the Steam Grotto. But since he fled, he hid somewhere so remote that he barely even knew about the Rebellion's activity, and it took Micah more than a decade to find him.

—Wow, alright. So that's the friend he's been talking about— she understood, surprised. —But, if they barely got in touch again so little ago, why would he have stopped answering his letters all of a sudden and now even reject his invitation? Oh, right, the invitation to the Gift Exchange too…

—About that, let's just say that I *tried* telling my brother I got this impression when he explained all of that to me, but, uh…— the sorceress hesitated. —It was just an impression, and he didn't have the faintest idea of how it sounded. I mean, a promise to be fulfilled once they met again, that was pretty much taking a bath together? And, what's more, they had dinner afterwards; Glimmer mentioned his friend invited him…

Pensive, the Queen Mother took a moment to decipher what Castaspella meant, and finally opened her eyes wide.

—Oh. *Oh*! I see… My, my… No wonder— Angella realized. —Micah can be so innocent sometimes.

—I *know*! So, you can imagine what's going on there. And yet he has no idea…

—He even thinks he did something to offend his friend.

—And, let me guess: this issue began when he mentioned in his letters that you were back…

—Yes…

—Well… Maybe we should tell him? I mean, he should know that his friend doesn't hate him, but rather… the opposite— Castaspella pointed out.

—How!?

—I-I don't know! I'm telling you, I almost did back then, but he's completely oblivious!

—Right… It will be difficult— Angella sighed.

Just a few meters away, the Queen and her husband were trying to teach Glow to speak.

—Come on, my Girl. Copy Mom— Glimmer gently told her, almost begging, while caressing her purple and now-pink curls. —"Ma", say "Ma".

The kid only laughed in a way that sounded similar, yet wasn't exactly a word, and Bow commented —At least she's having fun.

—But I am not! I'm worried!

—I know, Love. But give her time…

—How much more!? She just turned *six*!

—Hey, Sparkles— Finn cheerfully called from behind, approaching with their mothers. —Why are you so angry?

—I'm not… angry. Just upset— she replied.

—She still won't talk?— Adora asked.

—Not words, at least…

—Oh— the kid let out. —Come on, Glow! Say "Finn"! "Finn"!— they said, extending the word.

In reply, the girl let out a cheery burble that sounded a lot like their name, but wasn't quite it.

—That was…

—Eh, close enough— Finn accepted, interrupting Catra. —She'll speak eventually— they insisted.

—How did Finn learn to speak?

—I'm not sure, they just… did— Adora replied, uncertain. —I mean, there's a chance…

—Don't say it— her wife cut her. —I refuse to give her all the credit.

—You mean…

—I'm just saying, maybe she did!

—Look, if you mean Shadow Weaver knows how to do this, then I'm willing to ask for her help. I swear, I don't know what else to do, I'll try *anything*!

—Careful with your words, your Majesty— the woman suddenly said, approaching them from behind.

—Fuck! Don't… do that!— Glimmer exclaimed, startled.

The woman snickered yet said —Apologies.

—You're not sorry in the slightest— Catra called her out, folding her arms.

—In any case, I happened to overhear your little predicament…

—Do you *really* know how to make kids talk?

—I taught Adora, did I not?

—Oh, really?— she replied, completely oblivious.

—Yes, your first word was a mispronunciation of your name. And, of course, you then taught Catra— Shadow Weaver nodded.

—Of-fucking-course you didn't teach *me*.

—However, your Majesty, I'm sure your mother is more than fit to teach Glow to speak, wouldn't you say?— she went on, seemingly ignoring Catra despite giving her a brief smirk.

—I guess, yeah… I'm just…

—Impatient— the woman interrupted. —While it's rare that a kid her age still doesn't talk, I believe it's possibly just that she's shy. I wouldn't dare say she's understimulated; I wouldn't know— she continued. —But… perhaps she needs more social interaction— she concluded, her condescending tone making Glimmer roll her eyes.

—You know what? Fine… I'll let Glow interact with more kids her age, I guess— she finally accepted.

—Don't worry, Sparkles— Finn confidently said. —I'll look after her. I won't let other kids bully Glow— they promised.

Adora laughed daintily and Catra ruffled their hair affectionately.

—That’s our kid— she proudly said.

Chapter End Notes

That was all for today <("^_^)
As I said, far shorter than the chapters before…

I reckon the last chapter will be long again… I'm still writing it TT^TT

I simply can't get the words out because it's like I don't wanna end it ._. Or don't know how…
~~Bullshit, the ending is written, I'm missing the middle of the chapter~~

Oh, and about the lil thing with Micah's friend, there will be more next chapter hehe

Well, that'd be all!! I hope to see you on Monday in *Demonic Hues*, and next week for the last chapter, the very end of Path 1, at long last!

You Don't Have to Say It

Chapter Summary

Time, that won't ever stop, keeps flying by quite fast…
Some things change, others remain, and *everything* evolves.

» (…) They didn’t have to wait much until Glow began escaping from the palace…
» On the day of her seventh birthday, no one could find her anywhere. The Queen was about to start panicking when Adora and Catra showed up, bringing both Finn and Glow.
» She had to hold back a swear upon seeing her and realizing the girl had traversed the Whispering Woods on her own.
» How she had even managed to find their home was an absolute mystery, but it was easy for Adora and Catra to guess that Glimmer had not given her permission.
» Regardless, they took the girl on a little trip around the Woods before returning her to the palace, remembering her birthday gathering was supposed to begin at noon.
» Just later, when attending the event, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver learnt about Glow’s getaway, and each had very different opinions on it.

And so, before you realize, the end has arrived…

Chapter Notes

Welcome, everyone, to the very last chapter of *Life Will Change* & Path 1!!

I was going to post this as soon as midnight struck BUT, tbh, I wanted to be able to pour my heart out here in the notes, for which I needed to be able to type out freely, which wasn't possible last night so late because everyone had gone to sleep and my keyboard is very noisy (I love noisy keyboards)

Well, now, I've been waiting a really long time to write some of these scenes, I swear, I was dying to finally post this!
But, at the same time, I didn't want to.
I didn't want this to end…
I had the idea of making it a super late April's Fools joke or something (post something about the story not going to end, or me retiring, some bullshit like that XD and only later post the actual chapter), but I value my life + I personally hate April's Fools jokes so, absolutely out of the question.

Thing is… I am being both, very evil, and very nice in this chapter; I had no plans of giving you all a certain particular detail of something you want SW to *say, but I am now… Just, at the end. Like, the end end…*

Now…
Let me tell you: "Post-War: Path 1" is a folder in my Google Drive with 15 documents. The first one, the initial idea, the origin of all of this, was Jul 17, 2021, and it was just a "promised idea" for a friend --> Behind The Mask.
That same doc first was a whole lot of gibberish and notes taken while watching every single Castaweaver interaction, and then included lots of notes for the subsequent parts of this path (that was still far from being a series yet), and eventually became all separate documents.
Then you have the instance of Throw away The Mask, which had to be separated in several documents, 4 for the mainline (ch 1-10, 11-20, 21-30, and 31-40), and another 4 for the flashbacks!
~~There's the eliminated scenes docs…~~
And finally, the doc for this fic! (That has about 111 pages!!!! I almost had to divide it too cause it was starting to get stuck!!)
But well, that's already a lot of ramble, and I'm so sorry for that if u had no interest…

ANYWAYS!!!!
*Be **WELCOME** to the last chapter!!*

(#^_^#) I certainly hope you enjoy!! <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Months passed, many things changed, and others remained the same.

Among the things that changed, or rather, evolved, was Glow finally speaking her first words. Just as Shadow Weaver said, interacting with kids her age helped her overcome her shyness; once she began talking, she didn't stop. Even if she could hardly be understood sometimes, it seemed like she had known how to speak all along, yet wouldn't dare.

Another thing that evolved quite well was Nolrem's relationship with Zacharias. Once the nurse got over calling him just "Councilman", they soon became a couple in just a few months.

On the other hand, among the things that remained the same was Finn's habit of using nicknames for everyone but Glow; even after turning twelve, their childish personality remained intact. Adora and Catra little by little resigned to the fact they might never drop it…

After another five months, the Guild Dance was almost upon them again, and King Micah once more tried inviting his friend to the party, despite knowing the truth now.

He looked clearly disheartened.

—I understand why he's being distant and all, but… even after I apologized in my letters, in case he felt like I gave him hope or something, he still won't answer! A-and I even tried to

visit him at his place and got told, not even *by him*, that he didn't want to see me!— the King Father expressed.

—He's an important friend to you, isn't he?— Angella gently asked him.

—O-of course! Besides, I don't have many friends, Angie. Especially after my time in Beast Island— he lamented.

—Have you told him so?

—Yeah!

—And he still doesn't answer…

—No… Not even to reject my invitation this time— he denied, shaking his head.

—I'm so sorry, my Love— she replied, hugging him.

—It's… fine, Angie— he sighed, burying his face in her shoulder. —I should probably just let go.

—It's not easy, so don't feel like you *have to*.

—I… know.

And yet, when the Guild Dance arrived just five days later, a familiar figure showed up.

He walked into the hall awkwardly, looking around, until he finally spotted the King Father waving at him.

However, he immediately saw his wife next to him, and recoiled, regretting having shown up.

Micah let out a sigh and looked down, which called Angella's attention, and she didn't hesitate to place a hand on his shoulder, encouraging.

—Go— she told him with a smile.

—And tell him what?

—First of all, that you appreciate your friendship with him and don't want to lose it— she suggested. —And, in case he mentions it, let him know I don't mind, and would like to meet him, if he's alright with it.

—Really?

—He's your friend— she first replied, nodding. —And has good taste— she added, winking.

He chuckled, flushing a bit, and thanked her before going after his friend.

At the same time, on the other side of the hall, Shadow Weaver was having an interesting "conversation" with little Glow.

—Ghost?

—Yes?

—*Aidy*— the girl laughed, mispronouncing "Lady".

—Yes…— the woman sighed. —What is it, little princess?

—*Whas* that?— she asked, mispronouncing "what" this time, and pointing at an ornate chalice on the table.

—A cup— Shadow Weaver replied.

—That not cup!— Glow replied, annoyed.

—It is.

—Is not.

—It is…

—Is not!

—Where is your mother?— the woman decided to ask, her patience wearing thin.

—There— the girl said, now pointing at a different table.

—Then go with her— she ordered.

—No.

—Glow…

—No!— she insisted, getting angry again, her voice going shrill.

Shadow Weaver took a deep breath, closing her eyes, and tilting her head slightly.

—Listen, princess— she began. —I'm sure your mother doesn't want you wandering around… Just go back to her.

—I don't want to!— she clearly replied, stomping her foot.

With another deep breath, the woman stood up and began looking around, searching for either Castaspella, the Queen Mother, or just *anyone* who could help, letting out —Life isn't fair, little girl…

—Why!?

—Because that's how things *are*— she sneered. As she finally saw the King looking her way, she gave him a look that said enough, and he rushed towards her. —I believe this is yours…

—I'm so sorry, Shadow Weaver…

—No need to apologize. But I would recommend *not* letting her argue with me *alone*.

—Argue?

—A trifle; she asked what the chalice is, I said it's a cup, but it seems *this cup* doesn't fit her understanding of it, and she stubbornly argued as much… You can imagine why that's quite annoying— the woman explained.

—Ah… She does that a lot— Bow admitted, ashamed. —We'll try to keep her away from you for now, then…

—Why!?— Glow suddenly exclaimed, looking up at her father. —It's the Ghost *Aidy*!

—But the Ghost Lady wants to be alone now, Glow— he explained, kneeling to her height.

—But, but…

—What did Mom say?

—*But*!

—No more buts, Baby— he sighed, shaking his head as he stood up again. —We're leaving. Sorry, Shadow Weaver. Let's go.

Taking his daughter by the hand, he walked her back to their table, where the woman could see Glimmer patiently speaking to Glow, possibly telling her off.

—What just happened?— Castaspella suddenly asked, approaching from the opposite side.

—Now that the princess of Bright Moon speaks, she's proved to be quite belligerent… It almost didn't end well— Shadow Weaver admitted.

—Oh, my… That's not good…

—You have no idea— she sighed.

—Well, *nothing* happened, especially nothing bad, so I believe that's pretty good— Castaspella pointed out.

—Barely. If I hadn't seen the King, or if he hadn't seen me, I would have…

—I'm sure you wouldn't— she interrupted. —Your self-control has improved.

—I was *so* close to insulting her for… Ugh!— Shadow Weaver admitted, but couldn't finish the sentence; she hated thinking about it, and feeling so much rage towards a little kid again.

Just like it used to happen with Catra…

—Calm down, please— the sorceress gently said. —I understand.

—Yet you refuse to admit I'm a monster— the woman reproached her, sitting down.

—Because you're not— she promptly replied. —You got angry at her, but you held back. You sought help and, in the end, *didn't* hurt Glow in any way.

—I shouldn't even *want* to hurt or insult her.

—I know— Castaspella sighed, looking down. —But, for a very long time, you just did whatever you felt like doing, never cared for how the kid on the receiving end would feel, so now… you just… can't help feeling like that. It's a… very deeply rooted habit— she explained, taking a seat in front of the woman. —However, the fact that you no longer want to feel like that, that you *can* control yourself just enough to seek help, and that you recognize how wrong it is to have acted like that in the past… it's all…

—Proof that I grew?— Shadow Weaver interrupted, scoffing. —Sometimes I feel like you're too… *optimistic* about me.

—I'm not making it all up!

—I know.

—Then stop being so negative about yourself!

The woman shook her head, amused, and let out a breathless laugh.

The Guild Dance ended on a good note, fortunately, and during the next couple of days, the Queen Mother finally met the mysterious friend of Micah. She happened to remember the strategist and apologized profusely for never doing anything to help the people captured by the Horde.

He didn't mind; in fact, he admitted he would have made the same decision in her place, as it was more strategically sensible.

Little by little, he felt more at ease with them, and by the second day he was invited for some tea, he didn't even hesitate to attend.

After two weeks, it was time for the Gift Exchange, and Micah's friend was invited once more.

From a distance, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver observed as the King Father gave his friend his gift: his old arm cuffs and Sorcerers' Guild badge.

—A bit of a waste, if you ask me.

—Didn't ask you. But *why*!?— the Head Sorceress inquired, almost indignant.

—Do you *know* what's inside those badges?

—O-of course! Some, uh… powder…

—Lunar crystals' powder— Shadow Weaver remarked, rolling her eyes.

—And how is that related?

—Giving the badge to someone who's not a sorcerer is *a waste*.

—It's *symbolic*!

—Ridiculous— Shadow Weaver insisted, gesturing dismissively with a hand.

Well… if she can't appreciate symbolic gestures… then she most certainly wouldn't appreciate what Castaspella did, right?

Perhaps…

But there was no time to dwell on it.

The Head Sorcerer had a bunch of socks to give out!

And so did Finn, it appeared…

—Mom— Glow called, trying to put on the sweater Finn gave her as a gift. —Help!

—Alright, alright— Glimmer giggled. —Careful, you'll tear it, Baby— she warned her, taking it off her hands. She then rolled it back and said —Pass your head through here first.

Bow only observed them with a fond expression as he wouldn't dare interrupt, finding the situation quite endearing.

The Queen patiently helped Glow pass her arms through the sleeves, and the girl quickly ran off as soon as the sweater was in place.

—Finn!— she yelled, extending the word, while running to find them.

—She's really similar to you, you know?— Bow told Glimmer, smiling lovingly.

—What makes you say that?

—Mainly, she's just as hot-headed— he laughed. —It wouldn't surprise me if she starts sneaking out once she's old enough.

—Oh, please, no. Don't say that— the Queen let out, disgruntled. —I'll start acting like Mom, and I *don't* want that— she added, making her husband laugh again.

—Would that be so bad?

—You know how I felt about Mom when she grounded me for escaping with you and all! I don't want Glow to feel like that towards me!

—Come on. How long did your anger last, eh? I think it's only natural for parents and kids to have such disagreements— he pointed out. —We can just… try to talk it out with her the way you would have wanted Angella to talk to you— he suggested.

—It's just… Bow, now there's no real danger out there anymore. What reason can we possibly have to keep her from escaping?

—There are still some threats; magical beasts running around in the Woods, places no one should go for safety reasons, and, of course, we can't assume everyone in Etheria is nice— the King enumerated. —Even if she wasn't alone in her escapades, even if she already had control over her powers, there might be… people out there who could pose a threat.

—So… regular stuff that's… unrelated to being at war or not— Glimmer reflected. —Of course. The things we couldn't worry about before, right?— she commented, with a sad smile. —Yeah…

—Don't fret, Glim. We'll keep her safe— Bow promised, hooking an arm around her to pull her closer.

However, they didn't have to wait much until Glow began escaping from the palace…

On the day of her seventh birthday, no one could find her anywhere. The Queen was about to start panicking when Adora and Catra showed up, bringing both Finn and Glow.

She had to hold back a swear upon seeing her and realizing the girl had traversed the Whispering Woods on her own.

How she had even managed to find their home was an absolute mystery, but it was easy for Adora and Catra to guess that Glimmer had *not* given her permission.

Regardless, they took the girl on a little trip around the Woods before returning her to the palace, remembering her birthday gathering was supposed to begin at noon.

Just later, when attending the event, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver learnt about Glow's getaway, and each had very different opinions on it.

Surprisingly, the one who dismissed it as normal children's behaviour, due to their natural curiosity, was Castaspella. She insisted it's normal for kids to test limits like that…

On the contrary, Shadow Weaver believed it was unacceptable, and that Glow had to be taught never to disobey like that again.

The Queen was suddenly in a bit of a predicament, realizing she did, somehow, agree with the woman.

Perhaps she had to find a middle ground between both opinions…

Fortunately, Glimmer managed to handle it quite well, and more than a month passed without any more incidents.

That afternoon, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver happened to be discussing the matter while walking down the halls of Mystacor.

—See? Being so severe about it wasn't necessary— the sorceress remarked. —It was a question of communication and trust! As Glow was reassured that she can trust her parents, and that it's important to let them know when she leaves the castle for safety reasons, she…

—Yes, yes. I know. The girl wasn't scared into obedience but still respects their decisions and orders— the woman interrupted. —Trust me, that wouldn't have worked at the Horde, if that's where you're going to with this.

—Ah… I imagine— Castaspella sighed, giving up. —But…

—No! Fuck off!— a sudden yell interrupted, calling the women's attention.

They exchanged a glance and rushed towards the sound, turning around the corner to find none other than Catra and Micah arguing, or rather *fighting*.

—I will do what's necessary!— the King Father yelled back.

—And so will I!— she rebuked, throwing a punch at him.

Castaspella and Shadow Weaver were frozen in shock, not knowing how to stop them; Micah kept blocking Catra's punches and pushing her back with spells, yet she didn't stop, clearly enraged.

Getting more furious with each swat that didn't connect, Catra threw one last punch, aiming for his face.

—Stop!

It connected.

But it didn't hit Micah.

Castaspella had gotten in the middle and, after a moment, her nose started to bleed…

Taking a step back, and so mortified her wrath waned in a second, she promptly apologized —Shit! So-sorry! I…

—*Catra*!

She froze in place.

That tone was *unmistakable*.

And she *had* fucked up…

Resigned, she readied herself to face Shadow Weaver's full rage, closing her eyes and bracing for impact.

She didn't know what to expect; memories of being electrocuted or paralyzed by the woman's magic returned to her, but now she couldn't do that.

So *what* would she do to her?

She thought she'd find out soon, yet… nothing happened.

Confused but still wary, she opened her eyes only to find Castaspella standing protectively in front of her… her nose *still* bleeding.

—Wha-what are you doing?— Catra stammered, her heart hammering inside her chest as she could see the furious woman had aimed to grab her.

The sorceress had put up a shield behind her and in front of Catra, as an extra layer of protection, while facing Shadow Weaver without fear of being hurt.

Expression severe, she ordered —Back off. Now.

The woman immediately opened her eyes wide, looked at her hands, and almost gasped before taking a step back.

—I- E-excuse me— she uttered, looking down, ashamed.

Castaspella's expression relaxed immediately and she let her shield fall.

Sighing in relief, she turned around to address Catra, who spoke first.

—I am *really* sorry. I-I don't know what happened to me, and I didn't see you, and…

—Calm down— the sorceress interrupted, placing a hand on her shoulder. —I know you didn't mean to. But now I need to know what happened. What were you two arguing about?

—I… *cannot* tell you, I'm sorry.

—Why?

—I was trying to keep him from telling you about it. I-I mean, it's something neither of us should be telling you; it's not *our* business.

Surprised, Castaspella looked between them all and, clearly indignant, put her hands on her hips.

—Are you three hiding something from me!?

—Yes.

—No!— Catra yelled at Micah, before shaking her head. —I mean, yeah, but it's *not* for us to tell!

The three of them immediately looked at Shadow Weaver, who had been silently looking away.

As she felt them staring, she finally sighed and told Catra —I didn't know you were- I-I am… sorry. Thank you.

She only took a deep breath and nodded at the woman as a reply.

—So?

—I will tell you— Shadow Weaver decided. —In… private, if you may.

—Alright— Castaspella sighed. —Let me just sort this out first— she requested.

When the woman nodded, she took Catra a few steps away and gently asked —Why were you trying to hit my brother? Did he try to attack you or something?

—I… N-no, I don't think- I'm not sure why I was trying to hit him— she admitted, looking away, ashamed. —I wish Adora or someone had been here to stop me— she lamented. —I-I just *saw red*. Before I knew it, I was trying to punch him.

—Well, at least you were… holding back, no?— Castaspella pointed out. —You weren't using your claws or your magic.

—I guess, yeah. I didn't really want to hurt him. I wouldn't— she nodded, feeling just a bit better. —But I should still apologize.

The sorceress smiled and gestured at him, encouraging her to do so.

—Go ahead.

Both the King Father and Catra took a deep breath as she approached, and she bowed slightly.

—Please, excuse me. I shouldn't have reacted like that.

—I…— he began, but interrupted himself to clear his throat. —Thank you. But I suppose I pushed you to the limit. This wasn't the first time we discussed this, and you are… right. I-I don't even know how we ended up arguing about this again, to begin with.

—Me neither— she admitted.

—But, now…— he went on, addressing Shadow Weaver this time. —You *better* tell her, once and for all, or I swear…

—Yes, I will— she vowed.

They both arrived at their room shortly after, the woman closed behind her, and the sorceress went straight to her terrariums.

—Give me a second. I'll feed my babies and then we can talk— she said, without looking back at her.

—Of course. And clean your nose— Shadow Weaver breathed out, thankful to have a few more seconds to prepare.

Sitting on the bed, she observed with fondness as Castaspella fed her spiders, one by one, gentle as usual.

Shortly after, she briefly visited the bathroom to wash away the blood.

Only then did the Head Sorceress finally join Shadow Weaver.

With a gentle look, Castaspella cradled her hands and tried to encourage her to speak.

—Please, Bea. You know I won't judge you.

—You don't know what I have to tell you… You'll- You may… lose your trust in me.

—How many times have we been in this situation? And how many times have I *not* lost trust in you?— the sorceress pointed out. —If you tell me- I mean, If you *don't* tell me, if I have to hear this from someone else, then I could lose it… Or maybe not entirely, but it would… most likely affect my trust in you— she admitted. —Because it would mean *you* don't trust *me* enough to tell me whatever this is…

—I… don't know— she hesitated.

—Trust me, please.

—I do, but- I-I think Micah's right. It's… something I shouldn't even have thought about; much less attempt to do.

—Why don't you let me judge that?

The woman sighed and nodded.

—Alright— she muttered. —I've been… thinking about… what will happen the day you… *die*.

—The day I…

Right.

But then, could she be talking about what Castaspella thought?

Pushing her thoughts away, she focused on Shadow Weaver and gave her time to find her speech.

—I went to the chamber again, some time ago, and was… just *thinking* about the possibility of keeping you… with me— she began. Seeing the sorceress open her eyes wide, she quickly blurted out —But I wasn't- I didn't think I could do it, i-it was supposed to be impossible for me to get in, but I found a breach and I made it inside. Micah had some spells to alert him if I got in, and showed up immediately, pushed me away… I-I did nothing! I swear!

—Bea…

—I shouldn't have thought about it to begin with! I couldn't- I was about to-to attach part of you to the parasite without your knowledge and…

—Bea!— Castaspella interrupted her, as the woman's anxiety rose rapidly. —Calm down, yes?

—But…— Shadow Weaver began, until she noticed the sorceress' loving expression. —Why are you looking at me like that? Aren't you mad at me?

—Why would I be?

—I wanted to *corrupt you*! Ju-just based on an investigation that has yet to prove anything!

Castaspella looked down, smiled briefly, and squeezed her hands.

—So you haven't realized— she let out.

—What do you mean?

Glancing at the door, the sorceress first asked —Is it locked?

—Yes— she nodded.

—Good…— Castaspella breathed out.

She finally let go of Shadow Weaver's hands to reach for the rim of her dress, and slowly uncovered her chest.

—Are you trying to distract me? Right now?

—No?

—This is supposed to be a serious conversation, woman— she smirked.

—Bea!— Castaspella laughed. —It is! I am not- Ju-just… take a closer look, alright?

Confused still yet resigned, Shadow Weaver leant forward slightly… and *saw it*.

—What are… those?— she asked, almost in a whisper. She tentatively reached out to brush her fingers over light scars around the area of the sorceress' heart and gasped. —*You* did it.

—Yes…

—When!?

—After… A-after what happened with that stupid Anil— she replied, looking away. Putting her dress in place again, she explained —It all made me realize a lot of things and… I may have taken a peek at that investigation too.

—You…

—I had been thinking about doing it for a while, but wouldn't dare. Until *that* happened, and I easily made up my mind— she concluded. —I thought about telling you after we were asked about… you know, *marrying* and that… Indeed, we *can't* technically marry or anything, but I began thinking about this as some form of *symbolic* marriage and supposed you wouldn't… like the idea.

—How could you survive?

—I was careful, alright? I did what the investigation said, to get rid of as much of the parasite magic as possible, and then got help from Angella to make sure none of it lingered.

—But… Why did you do it?

—For the same reason you wanted to do it. To make sure I'd never leave you alone, even after my death.

—You really… want to stay with me?

—Why wouldn't I? After everything we've been through…

—I still… don't think I'm worth it— she admitted, looking down.

—Bea…— Castaspella softly said, cupping her cheek. —For me, you are.

—Cas, I- Why?

—Why not?

—I know it's been… a long time, but I still don't understand what you've seen in me…

—A lot, it seems— she giggled. —Even things *you* couldn't see— she added, taking her hands again. —I saw a potential you've lived up to- Well, not *lived*, but you get the point— she awkwardly went on. —Just… trust me. I made the right choice. I know it— she assured her.

—Can't say I'm… *not* pleased— Shadow Weaver admitted, looking away. —But it's… incredible for me… still.

—I *love* you, Bea— she insisted. —Whether you feel the same or not… I just can't control my feelings, so it won't change a thing.

—I… Li-listen, I- Ugh…— Shadow Weaver struggled.

—You don't have to say it…

The woman glanced down at their joined hands for a moment, took a deep breath, and looked up again, serious.

—Cas… You have no idea how much you've influenced me since you summoned me. For the best, I dare admit, even if I resisted— she began, laughing breathlessly. —I just… may not have expressed it as much as you'd like, or as you deserved— she went on. —So, I…

—Bea…

Shadow Weaver took a deep breath, squeezed her hands, and breathed out —I love you, Cas.

Chapter End Notes

And that was it…

There it ends…

I entertained the idea of continuing until Casta's death from old age… BUT
But, indeed…
I preferred to end on a more positive note, on a *happy* note, and like… with you all wanting SW to say "I love you" so hard, I was like "You know what? Yeah, let's do it" lol

And it's now getting late for me because I have to clean, go to buy something, then to my psychologist, then I'm meeting a friend for a coffee, then to a doctor's appointment, and finally return home to take a class so… (/-\) Someone end me…

Nah, ok ok, just… Let me check all of this one last time and, if you're seeing this, I didn't chicken out and actually posted it!!

Goodbye for now! And I hope I'll see you in some of my other works!! (Or, in the future, in *The Tyrant of Mystacor*, a long multichapter canon divergence of what would have happened if SW took over Mystacor instead of joining the Horde! XD)

I'll miss you all!! <3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!